



BIG 12

GAME GRADER	2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
	3	TEXAS TECH	84.3	20	TEXAS TECH	61.5	12	UTAH	61.6	13	UTAH	61.7
	10	UTAH	72.3	22	KANSAS STATE	60.1	14	KANSAS STATE	60.8	18	IOWA STATE	58.4
	18	ARIZONA	63.6	24	IOWA STATE	57.2	20	IOWA STATE	58.8	21	UCF	55.7
OFFENSE	19	BYU	63.4	25	UTAH	56.5	22	TEXAS TECH	57.9	22	TEXAS CHRISTIAN	55.4
	30	TEXAS CHRISTIAN	56.4	26	TEXAS CHRISTIAN	56.1	25	TEXAS CHRISTIAN	55.2	26	KANSAS STATE	54.0
	32	IOWA STATE	54.9	27	ARIZONA	55.6	27	BYU	53.9	27	OKLAHOMA STATE	53.5
	35	HOUSTON	53.9	28	BYU	55.3	32	BAYLOR	51.5	28	BYU	52.7
	36	ARIZONA STATE	53.1	30	KANSAS	53.1	36	CINCINNATI	49.9	32	TEXAS TECH	51.1
DEFENSE	41	KANSAS STATE	49.5	31	ARIZONA STATE	51.3	38	UCF	49.2	36	BAYLOR	48.9
	43	BAYLOR	46.9	38	UCF	48.3	42	ARIZONA STATE	47.8	37	CINCINNATI	48.9
	47	CINCINNATI	44.7	48	BAYLOR	44.9	45	HOUSTON	47.1	40	WEST VIRGINIA	48.4
	49	KANSAS	44.2	53	COLORADO	43.8	46	ARIZONA	46.6	42	ARIZONA STATE	48.0
	52	UCF	41.9	56	WEST VIRGINIA	43.4	49	OKLAHOMA STATE	45.6	47	HOUSTON	46.5
GAME GRADER	58	WEST VIRGINIA	35.9	57	CINCINNATI	42.8	53	KANSAS	44.7	58	ARIZONA	41.2
	63	COLORADO	31.4	59	HOUSTON	41.5	56	WEST VIRGINIA	42.8	64	COLORADO	39.0
	68	OKLAHOMA STATE	20.4	64	OKLAHOMA STATE	35.0	67	COLORADO	33.4	67	KANSAS	33.0
	2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
OFFENSE	8	UTAH	1.2	8	KANSAS	1.1	13	KANSAS	0.7	11	UCF	0.7
	11	CINCINNATI	1.0	17	UCF	0.7	14	TCU	0.7	23	IOWA STATE	0.4
	16	KANSAS	0.8	22	TCU	0.5	18	KANSAS STATE	0.5	24	BYU	0.3
	20	BAYLOR	0.6	24	KANSAS STATE	0.5	20	UCF	0.5	25	ARIZONA	0.3
	24	TEXAS TECH	0.5	28	CINCINNATI	0.4	27	CINCINNATI	0.4	28	TCU	0.3
DEFENSE	26	TCU	0.5	29	IOWA STATE	0.4	28	ARIZONA	0.3	29	OKLAHOMA STATE	0.2
	27	BYU	0.5	31	ARIZONA	0.3	30	IOWA STATE	0.3	37	CINCINNATI	0.2
	30	KANSAS STATE	0.4	32	BAYLOR	0.3	30	BYU	0.3	38	TEXAS TECH	0.2
	32	ARIZONA STATE	0.3	44	TEXAS TECH	0.1	33	BAYLOR	0.3	39	UTAH	0.2
	35	HOUSTON	0.2	47	BYU	0.0	35	UTAH	0.2	40	KANSAS STATE	0.1
GAME GRADER	40	ARIZONA	0.1	49	UTAH	-0.1	41	TEXAS TECH	0.1	42	HOUSTON	0.1
	43	IOWA STATE	0.1	50	ARIZONA STATE	-0.1	45	HOUSTON	0.1	43	ARIZONA STATE	0.1
	47	UCF	0.0	54	WEST VIRGINIA	-0.1	49	ARIZONA STATE	0.0	47	BAYLOR	0.1
	60	COLORADO	-0.3	56	COLORADO	-0.2	60	WEST VIRGINIA	-0.2	52	WEST VIRGINIA	0.0
	64	WEST VIRGINIA	-0.7	57	HOUSTON	-0.2	62	OKLAHOMA STATE	-0.3	55	KANSAS	-0.1
GAME GRADER	65	OKLAHOMA STATE	-0.7	58	OKLAHOMA STATE	-0.2	68	COLORADO	-0.6	65	COLORADO	-0.5
	2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
OFFENSE	1	TEXAS TECH	1.7	15	TEXAS TECH	0.7	17	IOWA STATE	0.6	15	UTAH	0.6
	11	ARIZONA	1.0	21	UTAH	0.6	20	UTAH	0.5	17	IOWA STATE	0.5
	23	ARIZONA STATE	0.6	22	BYU	0.5	30	TEXAS TECH	0.4	22	BYU	0.4
	24	BYU	0.6	27	ARIZONA STATE	0.5	32	ARIZONA STATE	0.3	23	CINCINNATI	0.4
	30	UCF	0.5	31	TCU	0.4	35	BYU	0.3	26	TCU	0.4
DEFENSE	34	TCU	0.3	32	UCF	0.4	36	KANSAS STATE	0.3	28	UCF	0.3
	36	KANSAS STATE	0.3	36	ARIZONA	0.3	37	UCF	0.3	38	HOUSTON	0.1
	37	UTAH	0.3	39	IOWA STATE	0.2	40	CINCINNATI	0.2	39	KANSAS STATE	0.1
	47	BAYLOR	0.0	42	HOUSTON	0.2	43	HOUSTON	0.2	42	BAYLOR	0.1
	48	WEST VIRGINIA	0.0	43	KANSAS STATE	0.2	48	BAYLOR	0.1	46	ARIZONA STATE	0.1
GAME GRADER	49	IOWA STATE	-0.1	45	COLORADO	0.2	50	ARIZONA	0.0	47	WEST VIRGINIA	0.1
	52	HOUSTON	-0.1	55	KANSAS	-0.1	51	TCU	0.0	49	OKLAHOMA STATE	0.0
	54	CINCINNATI	-0.1	58	WEST VIRGINIA	-0.2	54	OKLAHOMA STATE	0.0	52	TEXAS TECH	0.0
	59	KANSAS	-0.2	60	BAYLOR	-0.3	57	COLORADO	-0.1	54	COLORADO	0.0
	60	COLORADO	-0.3	61	CINCINNATI	-0.3	58	WEST VIRGINIA	-0.1	61	ARIZONA	-0.2
GAME GRADER	62	OKLAHOMA STATE	-0.5	66	OKLAHOMA STATE	-0.6	65	KANSAS	-0.4	65	KANSAS	-0.4

ALL-TRANSFER TEAM

QB	DREW MESTEMAKER	North Texas	→	OKLAHOMA ST	DL	ADAM TRICK	Miami (Ohio)	→	TEXAS TECH
RB	CALEB HAWKINS	North Texas	→	OKLAHOMA ST	DL	TREY WHITE	San Diego State	→	TEXAS TECH
RB	CAM COOK	Jax State	→	W. VIRGINIA	DL	MATEEN IBIROGBA	Wake Forest	→	TEXAS TECH
WR	OMARION MILLER	Colorado	→	ARIZONA ST	DL	WENDELL GREGORY	Oklahoma State	→	KANSAS STATE
WR	DANNY SCUDERO	San Jose State	→	COLORADO	LB	AUSTIN ROMAINE	Kansas State	→	TEXAS TECH
WR	WYATT YOUNG	North Texas	→	OKLAHOMA ST	LB	OWEN LONG	Colorado State	→	ARIZONA ST
TE	WALKER LYONS	USC	→	BYU	LB	CADE ULUAVE	California	→	BYU
OL	BRAYDON NELSON	North Texas	→	OKLAHOMA ST	DB	BOO CARTER	Tennessee	→	COLORADO
OL	PAKI FINAU	Washington	→	BYU	DB	ASHTON STAMPS	LSU	→	ARIZONA ST
OL	NOAH McKINNEY	Oklahoma St	→	TCU	DB	JA'SON PREVARD	Virginia	→	KANSAS STATE
OL	SHADRE HURST	Tulane	→	HOUSTON	DB	KALEB PATTERSON	Illinois	→	KANSAS STATE
OL	BO HUGHLEY	Georgia	→	COLORADO	DB	LYRIK RAWLS	Kansas	→	ARIZONA ST



BIG 12

1 TEXAS TECH



2 BYU



3 UTAH



4 TCU



5(TIE) HOUSTON



5(TIE) KANSAS ST.



7 ARIZONA ST.



8 ARIZONA



9(TIE) OKLAHOMA ST.



9(TIE) UCF



11(TIE) BAYLOR



11(TIE) WVU



13 CINCINNATI



14 KANSAS



15 COLORADO



16 IOWA ST.



ALL-BIG 12: OFFENSE

1st TEAM	2nd TEAM	3rd TEAM
QB NOAH FIFITA ARIZONA	QB DREW MESTEMAKER OKLAHOMA ST	QB DEVON DAMPIER UTAH
RB LJ MARTIN BYU	RB CALEB HAWKINS OKLAHOMA ST	RB J'KOBY WILLIAMS TEXAS TECH
RB CAMERON DICKEY TEXAS TECH	RB WAYSHAWN PARKER UTAH	RB CAM COOK W. VIRGINIA
WR AMARE THOMAS HOUSTON	WR JORDAN DWYER TCU	WR REED HARRIS ARIZONA ST
WR OMARION MILLER ARIZONA ST	WR WYATT YOUNG OKLAHOMA ST	WR COY EAKIN TEXAS TECH
WR DANNY SCUDERO COLORADO	WR TRE SPIVEY ARIZONA	WR KENNY JOHNSON TEXAS TECH
TE TERRANCE CARTER TEXAS TECH	TE GARRETT OAKLEY KANSAS ST	TE KA'MORREUN PIMPTON TCU
OL EVAN TENGESDAHL CINCINNATI	OL BEN TAYLOR-WHITFIELD TCU	OL NICK KRAHE W. VIRGINIA
OL JOE COTTON CINCINNATI	OL BRAYDON NELSON OKLAHOMA ST	OL AMARE GRAYSON W. VIRGINIA
OL BRUCE MITCHELL BYU	OL TARAN TYO CINCINNATI	OL SHADRE HURST HOUSTON
OL JOHN PASTORE KANSAS ST	OL JACOB PONTON TEXAS TECH	OL PAKI FINAU BYU
OL HOWARD SAMPSON TEXAS TECH	OL SHERIDAN WILSON TEXAS TECH	OL ANDREW GENTRY BYU

ALL-BIG 12: DEFENSE

1st TEAM	2nd TEAM	3rd TEAM
DL WENDELL GREGORY KANSAS ST	DL ANSEL DIN-MBUH TCU	DL KHALIL LAUFAU HOUSTON
DL KEANU TANUVASA BYU	DL ZACH CHAPMAN TCU	DL CJ FITE ARIZONA ST
DL ADAM TRICK TEXAS TECH	DL AJ HOLMES TEXAS TECH	DL MATEEN IBIROGBA TEXAS TECH
DL TREY WHITE TEXAS TECH	DL LEROY HARRIS KANSAS	LB TRAVION BARNES BAYLOR
LB AUSTIN ROMAINE TEXAS TECH	LB TAYE BROWN ARIZONA	LB LEWIS CARTER UCF
LB BEN ROBERTS TEXAS TECH	LB ISAIAH GLASKER BYU	LB OWEN LONG ARIZONA ST
LB CADE ULUAVE BYU	LB TREY LATHAN KANSAS	LB JOHNATHAN HALL UTAH
DB BRICE POLLOCK TEXAS TECH	DB JACKSON BENNEE UTAH	DB LeVAR THORNTON BAYLOR
DB FALETAU SATUALA BYU	DB EVAN JOHNSON BYU	DB ANTWAN PEEK CINCINNATI
DB JAY'VION COLE ARIZONA	DB WILL JAMES HOUSTON	DB JACOB FIELDS TCU
DB JAMEL JOHNSON TCU	DB JAYDEN BELLAMY UCF	DB ZASHON RICH KANSAS ST



BIG 12 - UNIT RANKS

TEAM	QB	RB	WR/TE	OL	DL	LB	DB
TEXAS TECH	6	1	1	1	1	1	2
BYU	5	2	10	3	3	2	1
UTAH	3	3	8	7	7	5	3
TCU	11	7	5	4	2	10	5
HOUSTON	4	12	9	6	6	13	10
KANSAS STATE	7	5	7	10	8	7	4
ARIZONA ST	9	8	2	8	4	3	6
ARIZONA	1	9	6	11	5	4	7
OKLAHOMA ST	2	4	4	5	10	12	13
UCF	8	11	13	14	12	6	8
BAYLOR	10	10	14	12	9	8	9
WEST VIRGINIA	14	6	12	9	11	16	16
CINCINNATI	15	16	11	2	16	14	14
KANSAS	16	14	15	13	13	9	11
COLORADO	12	15	3	16	14	11	12
IOWA STATE	13	13	16	15	15	15	15





TEXAS TECH

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#1

BIG 12

#8

OVERALL



TEXAS TECH				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14				(P) Oregon
13	BAYLOR	TCU	TEXAS	(B) Arkansas
12	OKLA ST	BAYLOR	BYU	ARIZONA ST
11	OKLAHOMA	OKLA ST	KANSAS ST	(CG) BYU
10	KANSAS ST	KANSAS ST	WVU	W. VIRGINIA
9	TCU	NC State	Oregon	UCF
8	TEXAS	(B) Ole Miss	Wyoming	BYU
7	(B) Miss St	OKLAHOMA	(B) California	KANSAS ST
6	IOWA ST	IOWA ST	UCF	OKLA ST
5	KANSAS	KANSAS	KANSAS	KANSAS
4	WVU	WVU	TCU	HOUSTON
3	FIU	TEXAS	BAYLOR	UTAH
2	SFA (FCS)	Houston	HOUSTON	Oregon St
1	Houston	Murray St (FCS)	Tarleton (FCS)	North Texas
			Abilene (FCS)	Ark PB (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	WELLS	JOEY MCGUIRE		

TEXAS TECH				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
ARK. PB (FCS) W 67-7	433	1	77.7	
KENT ST W 62-14	373	1	79.7	
OREGON ST W 45-14	310	0	77.9	
UTAH W 34-10	221	2	124.0	
HOUSTON W 35-11	285	2	101.9	
KANSAS W 42-17	186	0	85.0	
ARIZONA ST L 22-26	-118	-1	31.3	
OKLAHOMA ST W 42-0	188	0	79.9	
KANSAS ST W 43-20	111	3	94.5	
BYU W 29-7	113	3	107.3	
UCF W 48-9	269	2	92.0	
W. VIRGINIA W 49-0	392	0	93.0	
(CG) BYU W 34-7	174	4	117.5	
(P) OREGON L 0-23	-94	-3	18.6	
OVERALL: 3rd / 68	BIG 12: 1st / 16	84.3		

TEXAS TECH	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 16)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	6	
RUNNING BACKS	1	6
RECEIVERS & TE	1	10
OFFENSIVE LINE	1	9
DEFENSIVE LINE	1	9
LINEBACKERS	1	3
DEFENSIVE BACKS	2	14

TEXAS TECH	RANK	
Scoring Offense	39.4 ppg	7
Points per Play	0.53	11
Total Offense	461 ypg	10
Yards per Play	6.2	26
Rushing Offense	183 ypg	33
Yards per Carry	4.6	42
O-Line Run Push	4.3	60
Explosive Rush	7.0	23
Passing Offense	279 ypg	17
Yards / Attempt	8	35
QB Rating	151	23
TD / INT Ratio	3.3	21
Sacks / Attempt	6%	51
Explosive Pass	8.8	16
Return. Production	67%	20
Returning Snaps	17,072	6
23.8 SECONDS/PLAY	#8 of 68 P4	
LEFTWICH (2025 TX TECH)	FAST	

first Big 12 title game appearance, and then suffocated BYU 34-7 to win the school's first outright conference title in 70 years.

Joey McGuire, Mr. Texas High School Football, delivered the best season in Texas Tech history.

Yes, the Matador Club provided a program-changing budget, but they are not the only program with similar resources. At the Big 12 post-game press conference, McGuire made it a point to mention the roots of his three stars sitting next to him – quarterback Behren Morton was a hometown hero, Rodriguez was a converted quarterback walk-on, and linebacker Ben Roberts' only offer in 2022 was Texas Tech.

Their Playoff debut was a 23-0 shutout loss to Oregon, but with their roster retention and another elite transfer haul, Texas Tech is just getting started.

OFFENSE

Morton went pro, and the staff signed the #2 rated transfer quarterback this cycle, five-star Brendan Sorsby (Cincinnati). With an ongoing legal battle, in June his college career ended and he will prepare for the pros.

Former Top200 Will Hammond was Morton's backup last year and played well when Morton was injured. Hammond led four scoring drives late in the Utah win, ran for two touchdowns against Kansas, and has thrown for 1,151 yards and nine touchdowns so far. He is also an effective runner on zone reads, scrambles, and quarterback designed runs – he even showed off breakaway speed on a 64-yard run in the opener.

Hammond is still recovering from an ACL injury but with Sorsby gone, the timeline has been moved up to a full return in mid-August, just in time for kickoff. Tech also signed Tulsa's 2024 starter Kirk Francis and four-star freshman Lloyd Jones got game reps against West Virginia.

Tech's one-two punch at running back returns with 1,000-yarder Cameron Dickey and explosive J'Koby Williams. Dickey posted a 263-yard game against Kansas State, both backs earned All-Big 12 honors and combined to catch 60 balls for 600+ yards in the pass game. 2025 four-star transfer Quinten Joyner (USC) is back healthy and somehow they retained all three.

Receivers Caleb Douglas, Reggie Virgil, and Coy Eakin all ranked in the league's Top 16 WR in receiving yardage, but only Eakin returns for 2026. The two outside spots are open and the staff signed a pair of two-year starters Kenny Johnson (Pittsburgh) and former Top200 Malcolm Simmons (Auburn). Micah Hudson was a five-star and Tech's highest-ranked recruit and he has breakout potential. From the 2026 class they signed Top100 Chase Campbell (Wolfforth, TX) and have three more four-stars in the room. There is plenty of firepower here yet again.

All-Big 12 Terrance Carter returns after placing second in the league in receiving categories among tight ends. Jett Carpenter (Nevada) was All-Mountain West and actually led his team in receptions and yards.

The offensive line was strong enough to win the conference, but on the Playoff tier it appeared to be a limiting factor. Texas Tech ranked slightly above average in both my OL Run Push (#60) and Pass

TEXAS TECH					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)				
O	24	42	56	49	21	28	34	50	27
F	24	42	56	49	21	28	34	50	27
F	LEFTWICH	ZACH KITTLEY	CUMBIE	DAVID YOST	JOHNS	ERIC MORRIS			38th
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017
D	WOOD	TIM DeRUYTER	KEITH PATTERSON	DAVID GIBBS					
E	1	58	20	49	50	36	64	43	36
F	1	58	20	49	50	36	64	43	36
									67
									52nd

TEXAS TECH		RANK
Scoring Defense	11.8 ppg	3
Points per Play	0.18	2
Total Defense	258 ypg	3
Yards per Play	3.9	1
3rd Down Conv%	30%	7
Rushing Defense	68 ypg	1
Yards per Carry	2.2	1
Negative Play %	11%	6
Explosive Rush	3.4	3
Passing Defense	190 ypg	26
Yards / Attempt	5.5	4
QB Rating	106	6
Completion %	59.2%	33
Explosive Pass	3.8	5
Return. Production	64%	17
Returning Snaps	18,766	1

TEXAS TECH		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		24
Rushing Offense	0.3	28
Passing Offense	15.2	22
Defense Overall		1
Rushing Defense	2.3	1
Passing Defense	28.2	8

Protection (#51) though against Oregon, outside of one Williams' run, Tech was held to 1 yard/carry and sacked four times. This room is upgraded for 2026 with three All-Big 12 starters back – left tackle Howard Sampson, center Sheridan Wilson, and right tackle Jacob Ponton – plus four blue-chip additions. A pair of four-star transfers will fill the guard spots with Jordan Church (Louisville) and Hunter Zambrano (2025 transfer) both earning Top 10 rankings. Five-star Felix Ojo (Mansfield Lake Ridge, TX) and Top100 Bryce Gilmore (Prosper, TX) bolster the tackle spots.

DEFENSE

McGuire saw coordinator Shiel Wood build a Top 25 defense at Houston and hired him to do the same here. Texas Tech pumped the defense with four-star transfers, loaded up the best defensive line in school history, and they surged all the way to the #1 spot in my opponent-adjusted defensive rankings.

Nine starters got All-Big 12 honors, five were first-team, and David Bailey and Rodriguez were unanimous All-Americans. Rodriguez swept the defensive awards, finished fifth in the Heisman and posted the most productive linebacker stat-line in a generation: 117 tackles, 11 for loss, 7 forced fumbles, 4 interceptions, 2 fumble recoveries, and even two rushing touchdowns out of the wildcat. Against Oklahoma State, he shot through the line and grabbed the ball right out of the back's arms and sprinted 70 yards for a touchdown. J-Rod earned my vote.

Rodriguez and four defensive linemen were all drafted. Bailey, Romello Height, Lee Hunter, and Skyler Gill-Howard formed a legendary defensive line and McGuire admits that while there are no exact replacements, Tech added "four future NFL draft picks" through the portal. Top-rated four-star transfer Mateen Ibirogbu (Wake Forest) and Bryce Butler (Washington) fill Hunter's spot at nose tackle. Off the edge they signed a pair of first-team all-leaguers from the non-AQ level in Adam Trick (Miami, OH) and Trey White (San Diego State). AJ Holmes is a returning starter at defensive tackle with All-Big 12 accolades, and Jayden Coffield is back in the two-deep. Tech signed five-star edge rusher LaDamon Guyton (Savannah, GA) for additional firepower.

Roberts was the Big 12 Title MVP with two interceptions and returns as the leader at linebacker. While Rodriguez cannot be replaced, Tech signed the #2 linebacker transfer, two-time All-Big 12 Austin

Romaine (Kansas State). Corey Platt (Houston) has high upside but has missed two seasons with injury.

Four defensive back starters return, led by the corner pair of first-team All-Big 12 Brice Pollock and Amier Boyd. Linebacker/safety hybrid John Curry and safety Brenden Jordan are back, and then Top200 Peyton Morgan was a spring hero and "ballhawk" to earn the open safety spot.

OUTLOOK

Texas Tech's transfer portal dominance translated into on-field dominance with an 11-win regular season – all by 20+ points – and the school's first outright Big 12 title. They are just getting started.

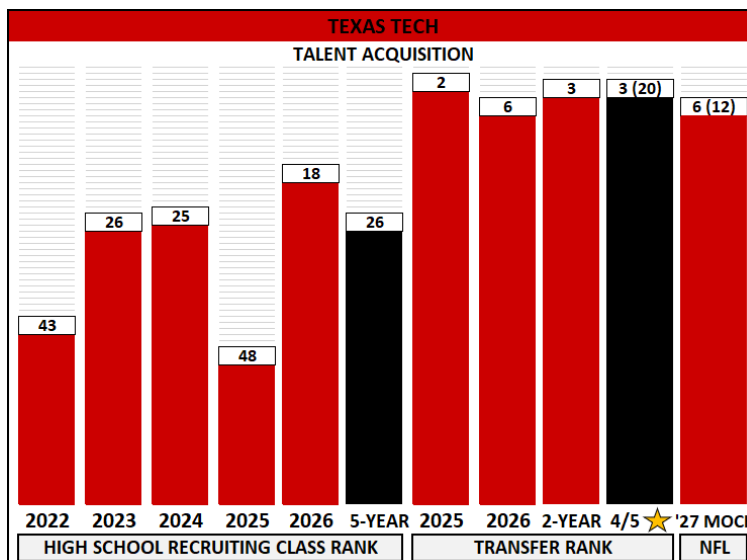
Over the past two cycles, the average Big 12 team has signed two four-star transfers. Texas Tech signed 20. They are fully reloaded again with the most talented roster no matter how you view it: recruiting rankings, transfer rankings, all-conference players, mock NFL Draft picks, etc.

Tech avoids BYU and Utah, and their four toughest Big 12 opponents all have to come to Lubbock. Texas Tech proved me right by getting to Dallas last year. This year they are my pick to repeat as Big 12 champs, and have the best shot in Power 4 to go undefeated.

TEXAS TECH	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	ABILENE CHR. (FCS)
S. 12	@ Oregon State
S. 18	HOUSTON
S. 26	SAM HOUSTON
O. 3	@ Colorado
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	ARIZONA STATE
O. 24	@ Cincinnati
O. 31	ARIZONA
N. 7	WEST VIRGINIA
N. 14	@ Oklahoma St
N. 21	@ Baylor
N. 26	TCU

TEXAS TECH		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	617	55
All-Time Win %	0.557	39
Wins (Last 100)	611	28
Wins (Last 50)	328	34
Wins (Last 25)	184	30
Wins (Last 10)	66	38
Wins (Last 5)	42	18
Game Grader (10 yr)	51.1	32
Game Grader (5 yr)	57.9	22
Game Grader (3 yr)	61.5	20
Draft Picks s' 2000	48	52
Draft Picks s' 2010	31	48
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)	2	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)	4	

TEXAS TECH		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
84.3 (3)	50.9 (39)	49.3 (39)	54.2 (29)	50.7 (39)	39.3 (55)	43 (45)	46.8 (43)	47 (41)	44.9 (43)	51.1 (32)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



BYU

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#2

#17

BIG 12

OVERALL



BYU				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14				
13	(B) UAB	E. CAROLINA	ARIZONA ST	(CG) TX TECH
12	BAYLOR	LIBERTY	KANSAS	TEXAS TECH
11	BOISE ST	ARKANSAS	(B) Colorado	(B) GA Tech
10	USC	NOTRE DAME	HOUSTON	UCF
9	GA SOUTHERN	OREGON	UTAH	CINCINNATI
8	IDAHO ST (FCS)	(B) SMU	UTAH	IOWA ST
7	VIRGINIA	STANFORD	OKLA ST	UTAH
6	WASH ST	UT TECH (FCS)	ARIZONA	ARIZONA
5	UTAH ST	BOISE STATE	BAYLOR	W. VIRGINIA
4	USF	UTAH STATE	KANSAS ST	COLORADO
3	ARIZONA ST	WYOMING	Wyoming	E. Carolina
2	UTAH	BAYLOR	SMU	Stanford
1	ARIZONA	USF	S. Illinois (FCS)	Port. St (FCS)
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				
KALANI SITAKE				

BYU				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
Portland St (FCS) W 69-0	555	0	77.7	
STANFORD W 27-3	171	3	81.2	
E. CAROLINA W 34-13	14	2	77.2	
COLORADO W 24-21	96	1	52.1	
W. VIRGINIA W 38-24	225	-1	69.5	
ARIZONA W 33-27	47	-1	70.0	
UTAH W 24-21	-102	2	57.8	
IOWA ST W 41-27	-85	4	68.6	
TEXAS TECH L 7-29	-113	-3	18.4	
TCU W 44-13	149	1	106.1	
CINCINNATI W 26-14	5	2	62.4	
UCF W 41-21	111	2	73.2	
(CG) TEXAS TECH L 7-34	-174	-4	8.1	
(B) GA TECH W 25-21	40	0	64.7	
OVERALL: 19th / 68	BIG 12: 4th / 16	63.4		

BYU	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 16)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	5	
RUNNING BACKS	2	10
RECEIVERS & TE	10	
OFFENSIVE LINE	3	14
DEFENSIVE LINE	3	
LINEBACKERS	2	7
DEFENSIVE BACKS	1	13

BYU	RANK	
Scoring Offense 31.4 ppg	32	
Points per Play 0.47	32	
Total Offense 400 ypg	55	
Yards per Play 6.0	38	
Rushing Offense 178 ypg	40	
Yards per Carry 4.7	38	
O-Line Run Push 4.5	33	
Explosive Rush 5.4	61	
Passing Offense 221 ypg	74	
Yards / Attempt 7.7	43	
QB Rating 137	62	
TD / INT Ratio 2.1	63	
Sacks / Attempt 4%	18	
Explosive Pass 6.6	72	
Return. Production 59%	50	
Returning Snaps 12,006	40	
28.8 SECONDS/PLAY #61 of 68 P4		
RODERICK (2025 BYU)	SLOW	

BYU's 2025 season outlook was called into question just weeks before kickoff when their returning starting quarterback was suspended and forced out. Instead, the keys to the offense were handed to a true freshman that spent spring ball at Stanford.

The 6'2, 230-pound Bear Bachmeier didn't look or play like a freshman. The first opposing head coach called him a "centaur" in the postgame after the 69-0 blowout.

The offense scored in a nation-best 27 straight quarters to start the season, and BYU survived one-score tests beating Colorado by three and Arizona by six in double overtime. Bachmeier became a legend in the final minutes of the Holy War as he powered in for the decisive 22-yard touchdown while carrying three Utes with him into the endzone. As ESPN's Jason Benetti put it, "there's a bear on the loose in Provo!"

The 2025 team grew into one of the school's best ever. They went 11-1 in the regular season, lost to Texas Tech in Lubbock and then again in the Big 12 title game, but with the Pop-Tarts Bowl win they got to 12 wins for just the fifth time ever. This time, it was against a Power 4 conference

and it was unquestionably the hardest schedule BYU has ever faced.

Just three years removed from independence, BYU had the breakthrough season in 2024 and now in 2025 they established staying power as a Big 12 contender.

Kalani Sitake's two-year record of 23-4 is the second-best in program history, only behind their 1984 national title run. He was targeted by Penn State in their head coaching search but Sitake remained loyal to BYU and even got a significant boost to roster funding.

While Texas Tech has been dominating the transfer portal, BYU put their chips on high school recruiting and player retention – and they went two for two. BYU signed a record eight four-star prospects and the class earned a program-high #21 national ranking (#2 in Big 12). Then they successfully retained all available returning starters and did so with a coordinator departing for a blueblood school. 17 starters earned some form of Big 12 honors – 10 returned, 7 graduated, and zero transferred out.

OFFENSE

Bachmeier went on to win Big 12 Freshman of the Year with 3,033 passing yards, 527 rushing yards, and 26 total touchdowns. He was the only true freshman in America to post 3,500+ total yards and flipped the program's biggest preseason uncertainty into a strength. Look for a second-year starter bonus here, especially since he'll actually get spring ball in Provo this time. In terms of efficiency, Bachmeier placed eighth in the Big 12 in QB Rating but ranked in the top five in completion percentage (65%) and yards/attempt (7.8).

BYU signed near-five star Ryder Lyons, the #5 quarterback of the 2026 class, though he is serving on a mission this year.

BYU has their "Bear" under center but also got back their workhorse at running back. LJ Martin returns after winning Big 12 Offensive Player of the Year and rushing for a league-high 1,305 yards. He did so after suffering a shoulder injury that eventually required offseason surgery, and still averaged 100 yards/game after the injury. He should push for All-America consideration in 2026 and has a shot at catching Jamaal Williams for the school's career rushing title.

Three pass-catchers earned All-Big 12 honors and all three are gone. Chase Roberts and tight end Carsen Ryan graduated, then Parker Kingston was expelled after a felony charge. Jojo Phillips and Cody Hagen are experienced veterans but the staff leveraged the transfer portal here. They signed three former four-star recruits: 6'6 Kyler Kasper (Oregon) and tight ends Walker Lyons (USC) and Roger Saleapaga (Oregon). Kasper and Saleapaga were stuck in a crowded NFL factory at Oregon, but former Top100 Lyons was a co-starter for USC last year. BYU signed two more Top200 four-stars Ty Goettsche and Brock Harris (out on mission) to complete the reload at tight end.

BYU										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	27	29	67	24	14	1	18	35	64	55	24th
F	AARON RODERICK					JEFF GRIMES			TY DETMER		
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	JAY HILL					ILAISA TUIAKI					
E	24	15	46	44	51	9	37	13	38	31	22nd
F											

BYU		RANK
Scoring Defense	19.1 ppg	19
Points per Play	0.29	19
Total Defense	332 ypg	35
Yards per Play	5.1	35
3rd Down Conv%	33%	19
Rushing Defense	123 ypg	30
Yards per Carry	3.7	40
Negative Play %	8%	58
Explosive Rush	5.3	34
Passing Defense	210 ypg	50
Yards / Attempt	6.5	35
QB Rating	117	25
Completion %	57.5%	23
Explosive Pass	4.7	28
Return. Production	69%	6
Returning Snaps	13,401	22

BYU		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		27
Rushing Offense	0.2	33
Passing Offense	9.5	34
Defense Overall		24
Rushing Defense	0.6	25
Passing Defense	21.0	13

Offensive line coach TJ Woods did it again. BYU again placed in the Top 40 of both OL Run Push (#38) and Pass Protection (#18) allowing a sack on just 4% of attempts. Sitake and Woods have built an impressive physical force when you combine the line with two bulldozers Bachmeier and Martin in the backfield.

Three starters are gone but BYU returns a pair of all-league linemen. Bruce Mitchell is the headliner after first-team honors at center, Andrew Gentry is back at right tackle, and the staff added in three transfers with starting experience: Paki Finau (Washington), Zak Yamauchi (Stanford), and Jr Sia (Utah State). Finau is a former four-star who coaches named the starting left tackle after spring. Overall the line is veteran with five redshirt seniors in the two-deep.

DEFENSE

Longtime Utah head coach Kyle Whittingham took the Michigan job and ended up pulling BYU defensive coordinator Jay Hill with him. Hill's impact on the defense was one of the best coordinator turnarounds over the past few years and helped BYU find its footing at the Power 4 level.

Sitake promoted Kelly Poppinga from within, and the alum says he's got influences from Bronco Mendenhall and Hill, noting "I'd be an idiot to change much of what we're doing." That's wise, given BYU's consecutive Top 25 finishes in my opponent-adjusted defensive rankings.

Usually a departing coordinator is able to pull some starters with him, but not here. Poppinga said he was on the phone non-stop, 12 hours per day, calling every player and keeping the lineup together.

Six All-Big 12 defenders are back – BYU suffered no significant transfer hits – and they even went out and signed the #1 linebacker transfer this cycle in All-ACC Cade Uluave.

Uluave posted 100 tackles, 12 for loss, and is a legit All-America candidate for 2026. Two-year star Jack Kelly graduated and went pro, but do-it-all Isaiah Glasker returns. Uluave and Glasker form a top linebacker duo.

BYU retained their anchor Keanu Tanuvasa, the 6'4 300-pounder who came over from Utah. He earned All-Big 12 honors last year and as Poppinga said, "he elevated everything." BYU does lose two starting linemen John Taumoepeau and end Logan Lutui but the rest of the two-deep is back. They also get back former Oklahoma State nose tackle Justin Kirkland who redshirted and is another space-eater. Bodie Schoonover and Tausili Akana round out the top rotation.

Tanner Wall earned first-team All-Big 12 in his final season, but BYU returns Faletau Satuala who actually grabbed some All-America praise after leading the team in tackles and taking back a key Pick Six in the Iowa State comeback win. Their top cover corner Evan Johnson is back after tying for the league lead with five picks. Two more starters are back with corner Therrian Alexander and safety Raider Damuni. BYU was in the Top 25 in all three opponent-adjusted categories – overall, passing, and rushing – but the pass defense was the strength at #13.

OUTLOOK

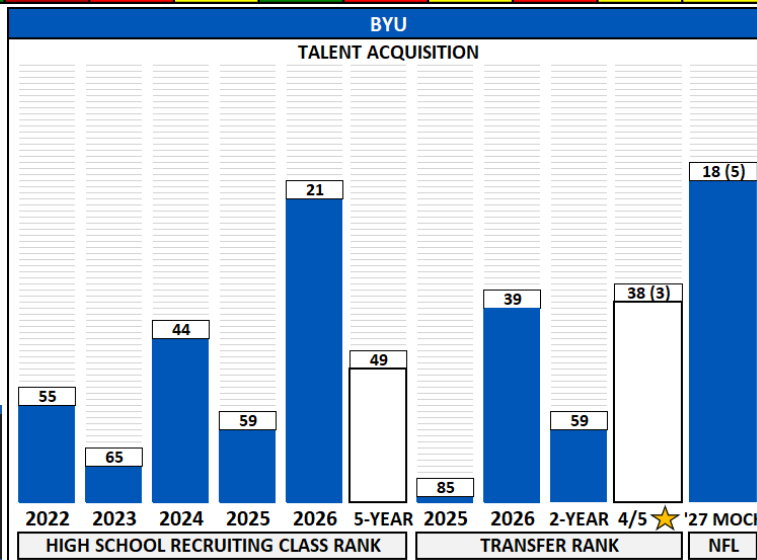
Following their breakthrough 12-win season, BYU doubled down on roster retention and kept all ten All-Big 12 players that were eligible to return for 2026. No departing star players to the transfer portal. In fact they even added the #1 linebacker transfer to stack the defense even more.

BYU's program culture is rock solid, the lines of scrimmage are stout, and now their big quarterback gets a second-year starter bonus. BYU is a clear pick to return to the Big 12 title game.

BYU	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	UTAH TECH (FCS)
S. 12	ARIZONA
S. 19	@ Colorado St
S. 26	--- BYE ---
O. 3	@ TCU
O. 9	IOWA STATE
O. 17	NOTRE DAME
O. 24	@ UCF
O. 31	ARIZONA STATE
N. 7	@ Utah
N. 14	BAYLOR
N. 21	@ Kansas
N. 28	CINCINNATI

BYU		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	639	52
All-Time Win %	0.586	25
Wins (Last 100)	631	19
Wins (Last 50)	441	6
Wins (Last 25)	209	15
Wins (Last 10)	84	14
Wins (Last 5)	46	11
Game Grader (10 yr)	52.7	28
Game Grader (5 yr)	53.9	27
Game Grader (3 yr)	55.3	28
Draft Picks s' 2000	40	59
Draft Picks s' 2010	19	65
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		14
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		2

BYU				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
63.4 (19)	70 (10)	32.6 (61)	45.4 (49)	58.1 (26)	77.9 (5)	47.1 (41)	50.4 (37)	29.6 (59)	52.8 (31)	52.7 (28)



THE BEST COVERAGE OF

BYU

COUGAR TRACKS

WITH MITCH HARPER

LISTEN ON

KSL SPORTS.COM

AND THE

KSL SPORTS APP



UTAH

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#3

BIG 12

#22

OVERALL



UTAH				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14	(B) Ohio St	(B) Penn St	(B) N'Western	BYU
13	OREGON ST	OREGON	WASHINGTON	TEXAS TECH
12	San Diego St	UCLA	ARIZONA	(B) Nebraska
11	BYU	Florida	OREGON ST	KANSAS
10	(CG) Oregon	(CG) USC	COLORADO	KANSAS ST
9	COLORADO	STANFORD	ARIZONA ST	BAYLOR
8	OREGON	ARIZONA	USC	CINCINNATI
7	ARIZONA	WASH ST	UCF	COLORADO
6	STANFORD	UCLA	OKLA ST	ARIZONA ST
5	UCLA	OREGON ST	Utah St	W. VIRGINIA
4	ARIZONA ST	San Diego St	Baylor *	Wyoming
3	USC	ARIZONA ST	S. Utah (FCS)	Cal Poly (FCS)
2	WASH ST	S. Utah (FCS)	Florida	UCLA
1	Weber St (FCS)			
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				
KYLE WHITTINGHAM				

UTAH				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
UCLA W 43-10	272	1	89.7	
Cal Poly (FCS) W 63-9	295	2	77.4	
WYOMING W 31-6	312	1	76.5	
TEXAS TECH L 10-34	-221	-2	8.1	
W. VIRGINIA W 48-14	186	-1	82.8	
ARIZONA ST W 42-10	139	0	99.9	
BYU L 21-24	102	-2	62.4	
COLORADO W 53-7	447	1	92.2	
CINCINNATI W 45-14	53	1	80.5	
BAYLOR W 55-28	-80	2	67.8	
KANSAS ST W 51-47	-23	0	55.0	
KANSAS W 31-21	-63	2	55.8	
(B) NEBRASKA W 44-22	192	1	92.0	
OVERALL: 10th / 68	BIG 12: 2nd / 16		72.3	

UTAH	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 16)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	3	
RUNNING BACKS	3	
RECEIVERS & TE	8	
OFFENSIVE LINE	7	
DEFENSIVE LINE	7	
LINEBACKERS	5	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	3	15

UTAH	RANK	
Scoring Offense 41.3 ppg	4	
Points per Play 0.57	6	
Total Offense 483 ypg	4	
Yards per Play 6.6	18	
Rushing Offense 266 ypg	2	
Yards per Carry 6.0	1	
O-Line Run Push 5.1	2	
Explosive Rush 7.7	7	
Passing Offense 217 ypg	82	
Yards / Attempt 7.5	55	
QB Rating 147	31	
TD / INT Ratio 5.4	6	
Sacks / Attempt 4%	13	
Explosive Pass 7.6	41	
Return. Production 55%	64	
Returning Snaps 9,843	63	
23.8 SECONDS/PLAY	#8 of 68 P4	
McGIVEN (2025 UTAH ST)	FAST	

After consecutive seasons were derailed by quarterback injuries and broken offenses, head coach Kyle Whittingham made a change and brought in the coordinator and quarterback duo from New Mexico's top five offense.

Jason Beck led one of the biggest offensive turnarounds from 2024 to 2025, quarterback Devon Dampier thrived in the step up from non-AQ to Power 4, and Utah powered through the Big 12. They won five league games by 27+ points. Utah routed defending champs Arizona State 42-10, suffocated Cincinnati's pass offense holding Brendan Sorsby to a 33% completion rate, and rolled up a 43-0 halftime lead on Colorado.

Though they came up short in the fourth quarters of their losses to Texas Tech and BYU, this was one of Whittingham's strongest Utah teams, especially along the lines of scrimmage where seven of nine linemen earned All-Big 12 honors.

After 21 seasons leading the program, Whittingham stepped down after the season.

"I'm very grateful for the relationships forged with all the players that have proudly worn the drum and feather during our time here," he said in his final

presser. Whittingham led their BCS Buster undefeated team in 2008, beat Nick Saban's Alabama team in the Sugar Bowl, and then led Utah through their promotion up to the Pac-12. Through consistent player development and a physical brand of football, he eventually led Utah to back-to-back Pac-12 title wins in 2021 and 2022.

His Utah program has been a mark of consistency, especially through the modern era of constant change: 18 winning seasons and eight 10+ win years.

Utah had planned for this eventual transition by naming long-time defensive coordinator Morgan Scalley as their "head coach in waiting" back in 2023. Scalley was an All-American safety on the 2004 undefeated BCS team and has coached here ever since.

Whittingham fully endorsed his successor: "Scalley is an exceptional football coach, a proven commodity, and he's invested in this program as much as anybody ever has been."

OFFENSE

A few days after the announcement, Whittingham took the head coaching job at Michigan. The dominoes started falling as he brought key players and starters with him to Ann Arbor.

He also brought Beck, the mastermind of Utah's overnight offensive fix. Utah ranked #63 and then #66 of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted metrics in 2023 and 2024. They surged to #8 last year with Beck at the helm.

It also helped having what Whittingham called his "best offensive line ever." Far from just coach-speak, this line was absolutely dominant, and paved the way for school rushing records in yards and touchdowns. Utah ranked #2 in my OL Run Push and #13 in Pass Protection. Spencer Fano and Caleb Lomu were both drafted as first-rounders, and all five starters earned All-Big 12 honors.

All five linemen are gone. So is ace line coach Jim Harding and his O-Block.

Their sixth and seventh linemen who were used in some jumbo packages are both back as experienced veteran guards: Solatoa Moea'i and Keith Olson. Alex Harrison got a bonus eligibility season and should start at center. Then the staff added FCS national champion Cedric Jefferson (Montana State) at right tackle, and signed five-star left tackle Kelvin Obot (Fruitland, UT) who could start right away.

Scalley hired Utah State coordinator Kevin McGiven, who will install a scheme similar to what worked here last year – though Scalley wants some of the aggressive mindset of his defense reflected on this side of the ball. There will be a bit more passing, and more vertical downfield shots in the new system.

Dampier returns after earning Big 12 Newcomer and improving on turnovers and passing accuracy even despite the upgrade in competition from the Mountain West to the Big 12. Dampier is the most elusive pocket scrambler in America, threw 24 touchdowns with just 5 picks, and did so while battling injuries. His backup Byrd Ficklin was lightning-in-a-bottle and he rushed for 10 touchdowns (8.4 per carry). Look for Ficklin to get some packages again this year and these two don't mind sharing.

UTAH										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	8	66	63	29	17	43	20	36	47	35	39th
F	BECK	ANDY LUDWIG				TROY TAYLOR				RODERICK	
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	MORGAN SCALLEY										
E	37	18	19	33	17	29	6	18	14	43	15th
F											

UTAH		RANK
Scoring Defense	18.9 ppg	18
Points per Play	0.28	12
Total Defense	359 ypg	60
Yards per Play	5.4	49
3rd Down Conv%	35%	28
Rushing Defense	181 ypg	110
Yards per Carry	4.8	115
Negative Play %	9%	31
Explosive Rush	8.8	128
Passing Defense	178 ypg	17
Yards / Attempt	6	10
QB Rating	102	4
Completion %	49.4%	1
Explosive Pass	4.7	25
Return. Production	55%	53
Returning Snaps	10,110	59

UTAH		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		8
Rushing Offense	1.7	2
Passing Offense	17.8	20
Defense Overall		37
Rushing Defense	(0.4)	60
Passing Defense	30.4	7

Barton and Levani Damuni. Trey Reynolds moves up the depth chart, and the staff must feel confident as they did not sign any transfers here.

The safety room is a strength, and simply put, Jackson Bennee is a play-maker. He had four interceptions, always seems to be near the ball, and should get All-Big 12 hype. Original starter Rabbit Evans and sixth-year veteran Nate Ritchie are both back from 2025 injuries.

Five defensive backs transferred out to Power 4 rosters, including their star Snowden, but the staff backfilled with three-star transfers from the non-AQ and JUCO levels. Scooby Davis is the lone returner at corner, former JUCO Rock Caldwell could start at nickel, and Elijah Reed and James Chenault (USF) will battle at the other corner.

OUTLOOK

Normally the loss of all nine starting linemen would be enough to sink the season. But thanks to years of elite player development, Utah has a pipeline of linemen and they never lose their physicality edge. Even though Whittingham moved on, Scalley's promotion means one thing: Utah is still Utah.

They also have the ultimate ace card at quarterback – the elusive Devon Dampier – and an upgraded receiver room. Despite all the changes, Utah remains in Big 12 title contention.

Wayshawn Parker vowed to be a thousand-yard back and he got to 981 with a high 6.6 per-carry average that ranked second in Power 4 (min. 100 carries) only behind Heisman runner-up Jeremiah Love. Parker returns as the workhorse back, and the staff added short-yardage bulldozer Steve Chavez-Soto (San Jose State).

Utah's top three pass-catchers are gone: Big 12 honorable mention receiver Ryan Davis, plus tight ends Dallen Bentley and JJ Buchanan (Michigan). Even still, Scalley called this 2026 unit "the best wide receiver crew we've ever had at Utah." The program hasn't had a 1,000-yarder in 13 years, but they signed two transfers who got close last year. Braden Pegan (Utah State) and Kyri Shoels (San Jose State) were both All-Mountain West, combined for 1,700 yards last year, and both were graded as four-star transfers. Other returners could be poised for breakout seasons like Larry Simmons, Ricky Johnson, and Creed Whittemore in the slot. Hunter Andrews returns at tight end after his 2025 injury.

DEFENSE

Scalley led the Utah defense for a decade with his "RSNB" culture: Relentless, Smart, Nasty, Ballhawks. That last one, ballhawks, is a perfect description for their nation-best 24 straight seasons taking back a Pick Six.

Scalley delegated the coordinator role and play-calling duties to Colton Swan who has coached the linebackers here since 2019.

Nine starters are gone, including all four defensive linemen, their sack leader, two veteran backers, and their top corner.

John Henry Daley led Power 4 in sacks/game but he and starting tackle Jonah Lea'ea both followed Whittingham to Michigan. So did All-Big 12 corner Smith Snowden.

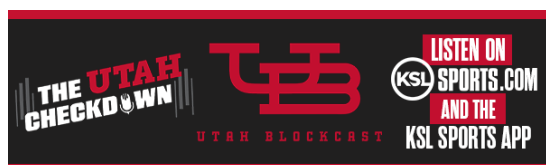
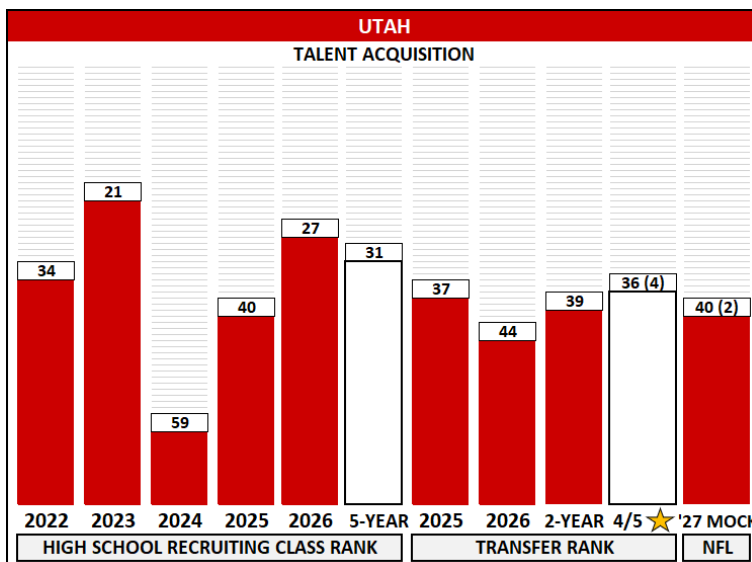
On the inside Pupu Sepulona and Karson Kaufusi both got 130+ snaps last year, and at the end spots Kash Dillon and Lance Holtzclaw move up into starting roles. The staff signed North Texas starter Ethan Day to join the end rotation. Last year, the Utah defense was unusually weak against the run and had some breakdowns in November like when Kansas State rolled up 472 yards on the ground.

Tackle leader Johnathan Hall returns at linebacker though they will miss Lander

UTAH	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	IDAHO (FCS)
S. 12	ARKANSAS
S. 19	UTAH STATE
S. 26	@ Iowa State
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	KANSAS
O. 17	@ Colorado
O. 24	HOUSTON
O. 31	@ Cincinnati
N. 7	BYU
N. 14	@ Arizona
N. 21	@ TCU
N. 27	WEST VIRGINIA

UTAH		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	737	28
All-Time Win %	0.598	21
Wins (Last 100)	626	22
Wins (Last 50)	361	24
Wins (Last 25)	212	13
Wins (Last 10)	83	15
Wins (Last 5)	44	15
Game Grader (10 yr)	61.7	13
Game Grader (5 yr)	61.6	12
Game Grader (3 yr)	56.5	25
Draft Picks s' 2000	75	30
Draft Picks s' 2010	52	24
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		38
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		7

UTAH				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
72.3 (10)	44.9 (48)	52.3 (34)	69.2 (10)	69.5 (8)	61.9 (19)	75.3 (8)	59.9 (23)	56.9 (28)	54.7 (27)	61.7 (13)





TEXAS CHRISTIAN #4 #25

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

BIG 12 OVERALL



TEXAS CHRISTIAN 5-YEAR WIN TREND				
15		(NC) Georgia		
14		(CG) Kansas St		
13		(P) Michigan		
12	IOWA ST	IOWA ST	OKLAHOMA	BAYLOR
11	OKLA ST	BAYLOR	TEXAS	HOUSTON
10	KANSAS ST	TEXAS	TEXAS TECH	SMU
9	WVU	TEXAS TECH	KANSAS ST	UCF
8	OKLAHOMA	WVU	IOWA ST	(B) Louisiana
7	TEXAS	KANSAS ST	ARIZONA	CINCINNATI
6	SMU	OKLA ST	Colorado	ARIZONA
5	KANSAS	KANSAS	BAYLOR	W. VIRGINIA
4	BAYLOR	OKLAHOMA	BYU	HOUSTON
3	TEXAS TECH	SMU	SMU	UTAH
2	California	Tarleton (FCS)	HOUSTON	KANSAS
1	Duquesne (FCS)	Colorado	Nicholls (FCS)	Long Isl. (FCS)
				Stanford
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	PATTERSON	SONNY DYKES		

TEXAS CHRISTIAN				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
UNC	W 48-14	320	2	89.3
Abilene C. (FCS)	W 42-21	36	-1	52.9
SMU	W 35-24	133	1	94.9
ARIZONA ST	L 24-27	-229	-2	25.6
COLORADO	W 35-21	26	4	61.4
KANSAS ST	L 28-41	105	-3	39.2
BAYLOR	W 42-36	-12	3	54.5
W. VIRGINIA	W 23-17	1	0	50.3
IOWA ST	L 17-20	160	-1	59.5
BYU	L 13-44	-149	-1	7.5
HOUSTON	W 17-14	35	-3	54.7
CINCINNATI	W 45-23	147	1	80.5
(B) USC	W 30-27	-17	1	63.1
OVERALL: 30th / 68	BIG 12: 5th / 16			56.4

TCU		UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 16)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	11		
RUNNING BACKS	7		
RECEIVERS & TE	5		
OFFENSIVE LINE	4		
DEFENSIVE LINE	2		
LINEBACKERS	10		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	5		

TEXAS CHRISTIAN		RANK	
Scoring Offense	30.7 ppg	40	
Points per Play	0.45	46	
Total Offense	422 ypg	27	
Yards per Play	6.1	32	
Rushing Offense	131 ypg	100	
Yards per Carry	3.9	97	
O-Line Run Push	3.9	108	
Explosive Rush	4.6	99	
Passing Offense	290 ypg	9	
Yards / Attempt	8.2	28	
QB Rating	150	24	
TD / INT Ratio	2.0	68	
Sacks / Attempt	5%	32	
Explosive Pass	7.6	42	
Return. Production	44%	100	
Returning Snaps	9,634	67	
24.6 SECONDS/PLAY #13 of 68 P4			
DYKES (2025 TCU)			FAST

In 2024 TCU went 9-4 with a pair of league losses by a combined four points that could have vaulted them back to Dallas for a title shot.

With their gunslinger quarterback surrounded by a veteran roster, that remained the target for 2025.

They certainly looked the part in the season opener, a Labor Day national spotlight game with all the coverage focused on Bill Belichick's UNC program. TCU flattened them. The 48 points were the most ever allowed by a Belichick defense.

TCU knocked off both rivals, too. Eric McAlister posted 254 yards and three touchdowns on eight catches as TCU won the final scheduled Iron Skillet over SMU. Then the defense picked off the nation's passing leader Sawyer Robertson three times in the 42-36 win over Baylor.

A knock on the 2024 team was their schedule strength and lack of a ranked win. TCU ended the drought by beating #23 Houston and then #16 USC in the Alamo Bowl. But like 2024, two close losses leave behind a mixed legacy for the season. TCU blew a 17-0 lead, and then later a 24-17 fourth-quarter lead to defending league champs Arizona State. Then after dominating the stat sheet, a crazy rambling punt return touchdown in the final minutes flipped the Iowa State

game to a loss.

Another year, the same 9-4 record, and two winnable games that blocked potential runs to the league title game.

Turnovers were a constant theme in the losses, with Josh Hoover tossing eight picks in the four losses, with a 4-8 touchdown-to-pick ratio in losses compared to the 25-5 split in wins. Hoover holds the TCU single-season passing record and was eligible to return for a fourth season as the starter, but he shockingly transferred out to Indiana. When asked about it, head coach Sonny Dykes noted "Josh started 31 games here, and turned the ball over 42 times."

Hoover's departure was shocking, but otherwise TCU excelled in player retention this offseason cycle. In fact he appears to be the only guy from the two-deep to transfer away.

It was a smaller transfer haul, but TCU placed #1, #2, and #1 in Big 12 high school recruiting 2023-2025 and doubled-down on retaining and developing that talent.

OFFENSE

Offensive coordinator Kendal Briles left for South Carolina after some mixed results here: strong passing attack, but an ineffective run game. Dykes hired UConn's coordinator Gordon Sammis who posted #15 and #35 scoring offenses in his two years at the helm there. Sammis will implement a pro-style offense with more tight end usage and more under-center snaps – a move away from Briles' spread, Air Raid, veer-and-shoot scheme.

With Hoover leaving for Indiana, the staff pulled their next starter from the FCS level. Jaden Craig was a three-year starter for Harvard, holds their career touchdowns record, and took care of the ball with a 52-12 TD-INT ratio. Craig is a 6'3, 230-pounder who brings mobility to the position and showed off straight-line speed on scrambles. In spring, Craig impressed with big arm strength, looks to improve on accuracy in fall camp, but is the unquestioned starter heading into the season. Craig was ranked as the #22 transfer quarterback this cycle, and is a rare FCS to Power 4 starter.

Adam Schobel was a Top200 prospect in the 2025 class and is the heir apparent for 2027.

Original starter Kevorian Barnes was injured halfway into the season and Jeremy Payne thrived with the opportunity. Payne surged in the final few games – 174 yards vs. Cincinnati, 103 vs. Houston – and then scored the overtime game-winner by breaking four USC tackles. He ended with 623 rushing yards (5.7 per carry) and should hit 1,000 with Sammis' tilting the play selection more towards the run.

Eric McAlister was a dominant force all season. He finished with 1,190 receiving yards, 10 touchdowns, and was named a third-team All-American and Biletnikoff semifinalist. He and starting slot receiver Joseph Manjack are both gone, but TCU did retain Jordan Dwyer (730 yards and 7 touchdowns) who takes over as the new #1 target. TCU has recruited well here with three former four-stars batting for starting spots: slot Ed Small, 6'4 spring hero Terry Shelton, and former Notre Dame transfer Braylon James. The staff also signed South Alabama starter Jeremy Scott.

TEXAS CHRISTIAN					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	26	28	27	12	9	20	59	63	41	45				
F														
F	KENDAL BRILES		RILEY	MEACHAM	SONNY CUMBIE		MEACHAM							
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	ANDY AVALOS		JOE GILLESPIE		CHAD GLASGOW									
E	34	23	42	37	67	40	23	8	8	22				26th
F														

TEXAS CHRISTIAN		RANK	
Scoring Defense	25.3 ppg	72	
Points per Play	0.37	69	
Total Defense	379 ypg	72	
Yards per Play	5.5	63	
3rd Down Conv%	40%	74	
Rushing Defense	133 ypg	43	
Yards per Carry	3.7	37	
Negative Play %	8%	94	
Explosive Rush	5.3	31	
Passing Defense	246 ypg	117	
Yards / Attempt	7.5	95	
QB Rating	137	88	
Completion %	61.4%	63	
Explosive Pass	6.5	94	
Return. Production	58%	42	
Returning Snaps	12,365	33	

TEXAS CHRISTIAN		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		26	
Rushing Offense	(0.3)	49	
Passing Offense	19.1	16	
Defense Overall		34	
Rushing Defense	0.8	22	
Passing Defense	2.5	40	

TCU needs improvement from the corners, and while they brought in two starters – Teon Parks (Colorado) and Kalen Carroll (Central Michigan) – it appears Gil Jackson surged in spring alongside returning starter Vernon Glover.

The defensive line loses a big one in defensive end Devean Deal, but has plenty of star power as the strength of the 2026 defense. Nose tackle Markis Deal is poised for a breakout, Ansel Din-Mbuh is a returning starter at tackle, Paul Oyewale is a rotational veteran at end, and Zach Chapman ranked in the Big 12's top ten in QB Pressures after an All-Freshman campaign in 2024.

OUTLOOK

The Big 12 has a crowded top-half of the league and each team has strengths and uncertainties. TCU is tied with Texas Tech for the #1 five-year recruiting average and Dykes' plan has been recruit & retain, rather than enter the transfer market.

TCU was in the Big 12's top six in all three opponent-adjusted metrics – Game Grader, Offense, and Defense – and is strong on both lines of scrimmage. The wildcard is at quarterback with Craig, an FCS star with NFL buzz, who is stepping up from the Ivy League to the Big 12. TCU is my pick for fourth in the league.

Both tight ends DJ Rogers and Chase Curtis graduated, but a potential All-Big 12 star is emerging. Former Top100 recruit, 6'6 Ka'Morreun Pimpton exploded in spring and looks like a third-down favorite for Craig. Kari Ashley was ranked the #2 JUCO tight end.

The offensive line has been disappointing in the run game the past two years, ranking #103 and #97 in my OL Run Push metric. This is Sammis' area of expertise, and the room looks poised for improvement with three returning starters joined by a pair of impact transfers. Ben Taylor-Whitfield enters his third season as the starting tackle and was named the most impressive spring lineman. Cade Bennett is back at guard for a seventh college season after winning an appeal, and original starter Ryan Hughes is back from an injury. The staff signed Oklahoma State starter Noah McKinney who barely missed a four-star transfer rank, and Jaheim Buchanon (FIU) who was All-CUSA and allowed just two sacks over 1,600 snaps.

DEFENSE

Andy Avalos didn't get a second-year coordinator bonus, as TCU regressed 11 spots in my opponent-adjusted defense rank from #23 to #34 of 68 Power 4. The pass defense fell further – below average in the Big 12 – despite two all-league safeties and two of the top five fastest linebackers at the NFL Combine.

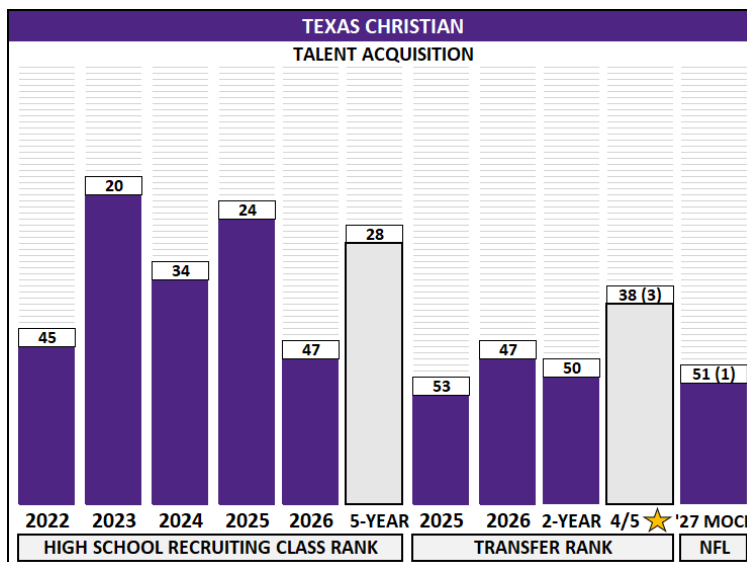
Those backers will be missed. Kaleb Elarms-Orr earned first-team All-Big 12 honors with 130 tackles (#4 in Power 4), Namdi Obiazor added 88, and the pair combined for 15 tackles for loss. Last year's third backer Max Carroll steps up into the lead role and Virginia Tech transfer Michael Short battles a bunch of three-stars for the other spot.

Bud Clark has been a program icon all the way back to his Pick Six against Michigan in the 2022 Playoffs. Clark took another one back in the UNC win and became a three-time All-Big 12 pick. Clark, nickel Austin Jordan, and corner Channing Canada are all gone but the secondary has a star to build around with second-team All-Big 12 safety Jamel Johnson back. Johnson was heavily involved in the run game with 96 tackles and also grabbed five picks. Kylin Jackson moves up to the starting nickel spot and C-USA Defensive Player of the Year Jacob Fields (Louisiana Tech) is projected at safety.

TEXAS CHRISTIAN	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	*UNC (IRELAND)
S. 5	--- BYE ---
S. 12	GRAMBLING (FCS)
S. 19	ARKANSAS ST
S. 26	@ UCF
O. 3	BYU
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	@ Baylor
O. 24	WEST VIRGINIA
O. 31	KANSAS
N. 6	@ Arizona
N. 14	KANSAS STATE
N. 21	UTAH
N. 26	@ Texas Tech

TEXAS CHRISTIAN		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	702	36	
All-Time Win %	0.546	45	
Wins (Last 100)	598	32	
Wins (Last 50)	320	35	
Wins (Last 25)	219	9	
Wins (Last 10)	76	24	
Wins (Last 5)	41	23	
Game Grader (10 yr)	55.4	22	
Game Grader (5 yr)	55.2	25	
Game Grader (3 yr)	56.1	26	
Draft Picks s' 2000	71	33	
Draft Picks s' 2010	50	28	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		7	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		26	

TEXAS CHRISTIAN		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
56.4 (30)	58.9 (26)	53 (31)	71.2 (8)	36.6 (57)	61.5 (20)	54.2 (26)	47.1 (41)	65.8 (14)	49.8 (38)	55.4 (22)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS

HOUSTON

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#5_(TIE) #30

BIG 12 OVERALL.



HOUSTON					
5-YEAR WIN TREND					
14	(CG) Cincinnati				
13	Texas Tech	TULSA			TCU
12	(B) Auburn	SMU			W. VIRGINIA
11	UConn	TULANE	UCF	BYU	TEXAS TECH
10	MEMPHIS	Kansas	OKLA STATE	BAYLOR	(B) LSU
9	TEMPLE	Texas Tech	CINCINNATI	KANSAS	BAYLOR
8	USF	(B) UL-Lafayette	KANSAS ST	IOWA STATE	UCF
7	SMU	ECU	TEXAS	CINCINNATI	ARIZONA ST
6	ECU	TEMPLE	TEXAS TECH	Oklahoma	ARIZONA
5	TULANE	USF	TCU	UNLV	OKLA ST
4	TULSA	NAVY	BAYLOR	KANSAS ST	Oregon St
3	NAVY	MEMPHIS	WVU	UTAH	COLORADO
2	Grambling (FCS)	Rice	Sam Houston	TCU	Rice
1	Rice	UTSA	UTSA	Rice	SF Austin (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
	DANA HOLGORSSEN			WILLIE FRITZ	

HOUSTON				
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE
SF Austin (FCS)	W 27-0	199	2	67.7
RICE	W 35-9	164	2	69.1
COLORADO	W 36-20	131	2	69.8
OREGON ST	W 27-24	-38	-1	35.4
TEXAS TECH	L 11-35	-285	-2	6.8
OKLAHOMA ST	W 39-17	260	1	74.9
ARIZONA	W 31-28	15	0	59.8
ARIZONA ST	W 24-16	-42	1	63.7
W. VIRGINIA	L 35-45	-3	-4	24.3
UCF	W 30-27	151	-2	54.9
TCU	L 14-17	-35	3	47.9
BAYLOR	W 31-24	-4	1	54.5
ALU LSU	W 38-35	93	1	72.2
OVERALL: 35th / 68		BIG 12: 7th / 16		53.9

HOUSTON	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK (of 16)	NATIONAL	
	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	4	
RUNNING BACKS	12	
RECEIVERS & TE	9	
OFFENSIVE LINE	6	
DEFENSIVE LINE	6	
LINEBACKERS	13	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	10	

HOUSTON		RANK	
Scoring Offense	29.1 ppg	55	
Points per Play	0.41	62	
Total Offense	395 ypg	61	
Yards per Play	5.5	78	
Rushing Offense	178 ypg	39	
Yards per Carry	4.2	80	
O-Line Run Push	3.9	106	
Explosive Rush	4.9	84	
Passing Offense	216 ypg	83	
Yards / Attempt	7.5	54	
QB Rating	144	41	
TD / INT Ratio	2.6	47	
Sacks / Attempt	5%	40	
Explosive Pass	6.7	69	
Return. Production	71%	7	
Returning Snaps	18,538	2	
 26.6 SECONDS/PLAY #35 of 68 P4 NAGLE (2025 HOUSTON)			

After a 4-8 transition season, Willie Fritz knew the importance of the upcoming talent acquisition cycle. With a funding disadvantage compared to some of their conference peers, Houston had to go with the “moneyball” approach of finding under-recruited gems and as Fritz put it simply “we have to be right.”

Houston was right. With an emphasis on college experience and career starts/snaps, Houston's transfer haul ended up producing 13 starters on the 2025 team and *eight* of them earned All-Big 12 honors.

They also led the school's first 10-win season in a Power conference since 1990.

Houston ended up in seven one-score games and thanks to three game-winners by kicker Ethan Sanchez, and gutsy performances by quarterback Conner Weigman, they went 6-1 in those toss-ups.

After he was hired, Fritz called Houston a “sleeping giant” due to their location in talent-rich Texas, their academic profile, and now their Power conference patch on their uniforms. The 2025 season was a

breakthrough with six Big 12 wins – more than their first two seasons combined post-transition.

The 2026 transfer haul may not be as highly-touted on paper, but Houston only lost two starters to the portal, signed two Power 4 starters of their own, and added another round of all-conference performers from the non-AQ level. Fritz is doubling down on what worked last cycle.

They also landed a potential program-changer on the high school recruiting trail by signing five-star super-recruit Keisean Henderson (Spring, TX), the #1 overall prospect in the nation.

OFFENSE

While Henderson is certainly the future of the program, he will learn from returning starter Weigman who is back after passing for 2,711 yards, 25 touchdowns and a #5 finish in QB Rating in the Big 12. A former five-star himself, Weigman was impressed with Henderson's strong arm in spring ball: "the talent is off the charts, he can throw a football with the best of them."

Fritz did not rule out the possibility of getting Henderson extended game reps in 2026 and depending on fall camp progress, defenses may have to scheme for both guys.

In addition to the passing production and leadership, Weigman also shouldered a heavy workload in the run game with 13 carries/game for 700 yards and 11 rushing touchdowns.

Dean Connors was one of the toughest runners in the nation last year and got All-Big 12 honorable mention after finishing just shy of 1,000 yards. He graduated and leaves behind a three-man committee at running back. DJ Butler rushed for 300 yards last year, Re'Shaun Sanford was the 2024 leading rusher and is back from his ACL injury, and then Fritz signed a familiar face in Makhi Hughes (Oregon). Before getting stuck in a crowded NFL backfield at Oregon, Hughes rushed for 1,378 yards for Fritz's Tulane team in 2023, and then another 1,401 in 2024. Over 1,000 of that yardage was after contact, and if he can get back to 2024 form, Houston has a star to rely on.

Houston focused their targets on just two pass-catchers with Amare Thomas and tight end Tanner Koziol getting 141 receptions – all other receivers combined for just 45. Both guys earned first-team All-Big 12 honors, but Koziol went pro after an FBS TE-high 74 catches.

Thomas returns in the slot after his 966-yard, 12-touchdown explosion last year. Koby Young started eight games and returns on the outside, and the staff signed two-year Oregon State lead receiver Trent Walker who put up 1,714 yards the past two seasons. The staff added two more three-star transfers from Power 4 rosters in Tyson Turner (Texas Tech) and Muizz Tounkara (Florida) and then signed four-star Jeremiah Bushnell from the high school ranks.

Patrick Overmyer (UTSA) was one of the most productive tight ends in the AAC last year and he'll take over Koziol's starting role.

HOUSTON						OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)						
O												
F	35	63	45	20	40	32	29	12	34	50	42nd	
F	NAGLE	BARBAY	NAGHAVI	SHANNON DAWSON			BLACKWELL	BRILES	JOHNSON	APPLEWHITE		
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
D	ARMSTRONG	WOOD	DOUG BELK			JOE CAUTHEN		MARK D'ONOFRIO		ORLANDO		
F	52	24	48	45	34	30	65	64	17	11	38th	

HOUSTON		RANK	
Scoring Defense	22.8 ppg	47	
Points per Play	0.35	47	
Total Defense	348 ypg	47	
Yards per Play	5.3	45	
3rd Down Conv%	36%	40	
Rushing Defense	129 ypg	38	
Yards per Carry	3.7	36	
Negative Play %	7%	108	
Explosive Rush	5.3	32	
Passing Defense	219 ypg	66	
Yards / Attempt	7.1	63	
QB Rating	127	50	
Completion %	60.3%	45	
Explosive Pass	6.7	101	
Return. Production	58%	44	
Returning Snaps	13,901	17	

HOUSTON		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		35	
Rushing Offense	0.1	39	
Passing Offense	12.4	28	
Defense Overall		52	
Rushing Defense	0.3	41	
Passing Defense	(3.7)	51	

Javion White (Tulane) was All-AAC last year and will start at nickel, while Jalen Mayo (Stephen F. Austin) was an FCS standout corner who played well against Houston in the 2025 opener. Incoming four-star Paris Melvin may play early after the two-deep was thinned out by three backups graduating.

OUTLOOK

Fritz has done an excellent job identifying under-the-radar transfer talent and coaching them up into all-leaguers. To continue the momentum from last year's breakthrough season, this next round of transfers has to hit again.

The formula is similar as they targeted experienced, veteran, all-conference players from the lower tiers. Despite losing 13 starters, they reloaded their experience level and Houston still ranks in the national top ten of career snaps.

Houston will continue to improve each year into their Power 4 transition, and even signed a five-star superstar for the future. But they were #7 in the Big 12 in my Game Grader last year -- #12 in the opponent-adjusted yardage margin -- which both signal they were not as strong as their record. Their 6-1 performance in one-score games is unlikely to be repeated, and they remain outside the Big 12 title game projection.

The offensive line struggled with a #106 rank in my OL Run Push metric and now must replace three starters Dalton Merryman, Jason Brooks, and center Demetrius Hunter who left for Colorado. Alvin Ebosele and McKenzie Agnello are returning starters and then the staff pulled in three all-league linemen from the Non-AQ level to round out the new starting five. Anthony Boswell (Toledo) and Drew Terrill (Miami, OH) were both All-MAC, Shadre Hurst (Tulane) was first-team All-AAC at guard, but they all earned three-star transfer grades.

Fritz's coordinator hire Slade Nagle led the offensive improvement from bottom five in 2024 up to #35 of 68 Power 4 in 2025. Now Houston gets a second-year bonus at coordinator and quarterback, coupled with the boost of several proven Non-AQ stars.

DEFENSE

Last offseason, coordinator Shiel Wood left for Texas Tech and then Houston slid from #24 to #52 of 68 Power 4.

Six defenders earned All-Big 12 honors and five are gone. The defensive line loses their best run stopper Carlos Allen and sack leader Eddie Walls. Khalil Laufau is back at defensive tackle along with both edge hybrids Brandon Mack and Latreveon McCutchin. The staff signed former four-star Ashton Porter (Oregon), All-Ivy Ejiro Egodogbare (Yale), and former Vanderbilt starter De'Marion Thomas.

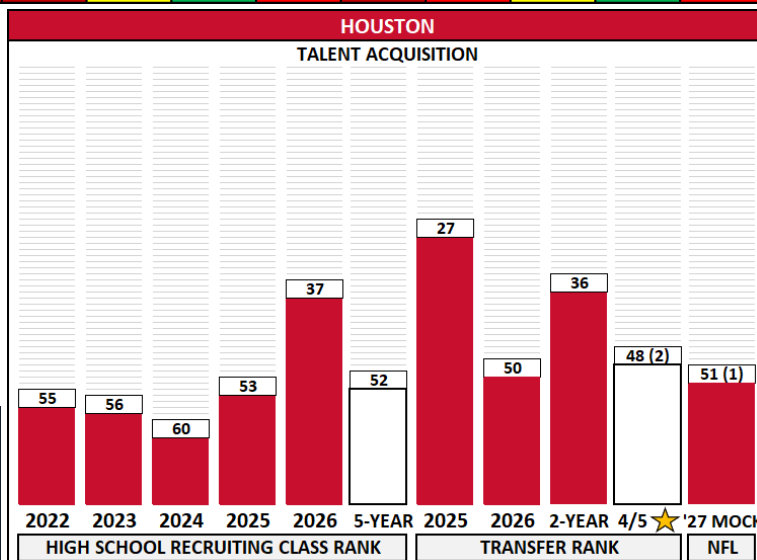
Two starting linebackers are gone after Jalen Garner graduated and Corey Platt transferred out to Texas Tech. The staff signed a Power 4 starter of their own with Jaden Yates (Ole Miss) who started nine games last year. Yates posted 115 tackles the year prior at Marshall and earned his "100-Yard Landlord" nickname. Starting middle backer Sione Fotu is back and Chance Bryant and Carmychah Glass move up the depth chart.

Three starters return to the secondary but Houston loses two All-Big 12 stars in Latrell McCutchin and Wrook Brown. Will James is an all-leaguer at cornerback, Kentrell Webb and Jordan Allen are both veteran returning starters at the safety spots, and the staff signed two high-three star transfers.

HOUSTON	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	OREGON STATE
S. 12	SOUTHERN (FCS)
S. 18	@ Texas Tech
S. 26	@ GA Southern
O. 3	UCF
O. 10	@ Kansas State
O. 17	OKLAHOMA ST
O. 24	@ Utah
O. 31	--- BYE ---
N. 7	CINCINNATI
N. 13	@ Colorado
N. 21	@ WVU
N. 28	BAYLOR

HOUSTON		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	486	67	
All-Time Win %	0.545	46	
Wins (Last 100)	486	59	
Wins (Last 50)	316	39	
Wins (Last 25)	178	32	
Wins (Last 10)	69	36	
Wins (Last 5)	38	29	
Game Grader (10 yr)	46.5	47	
Game Grader (5 yr)	47.1	45	
Game Grader (3 yr)	41.5	59	
Draft Picks s' 2000	32	63	
Draft Picks s' 2010	25	56	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		16	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		10	

HOUSTON		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
53.9 (35)	37.5 (57)	33 (60)	49.7 (38)	61.5 (18)	40.6 (50)	33.5 (60)	45.5 (49)	48.9 (38)	61.1 (16)	46.5 (47)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



KANSAS STATE

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#5(TIE) #31

BIG 12 OVERALL



KANSAS STATE					
5-YEAR WIN TREND					
14		(B) Alabama			
13	TEXAS	TEXAS	IOWA ST	IOWA ST	UTAH
12	BAYLOR	TCU	TEXAS	ARIZONA ST	TEXAS TECH
11	IOWA ST	Tulane	OKLA ST	HOUSTON	BAYLOR
10	OKLAHOMA	(CG) TCU	Missouri	BYU	Arizona
9	OKLA ST	KANSAS	(B) NC State	(B) Rutgers	Army
8	(B) LSU	WVU	KANSAS	CINCINNATI	KANSAS
7	WVU	BAYLOR	BAYLOR	KANSAS	IOWA ST
6	KANSAS	OKLA ST	HOUSTON	WVU	COLORADO
5	TCU	IOWA ST	TCU	COLORADO	OKLA ST
4	TEXAS TECH	TEXAS TECH	TEXAS TECH	OKLA ST	KANSAS
3	Nevada	OKLAHOMA	UCF	Arizona *	TCU
2	S. Illinois (FCS)	Missouri	Troy	Tulane	UCF
1	Stanford	S. Dakota (FCS)	SE MO (FCS)	UT Martin (FCS)	N. Dakota (FCS)
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025					
CHRIS KLIEMAN					

KANSAS STATE					
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
IOWA ST	L 21-24	70	0	52.2	
N. Dakota (FCS)	W 38-35	107	0	43.0	
ARMY	L 21-24	-86	-1	30.2	
ARIZONA	L 17-23	-219	1	27.7	
UCF	W 34-20	32	2	63.2	
BAYLOR	L 34-35	63	1	49.6	
TCU	W 41-28	-105	3	67.9	
KANSAS	W 42-17	124	3	85.0	
TEXAS TECH	L 20-43	-111	-3	16.7	
OKLAHOMA ST	W 14-6	-89	4	47.8	
UTAH	L 47-51	23	0	56.0	
COLORADO	W 24-14	-2	1	54.6	
OVERALL: 41st / 68 BIG 12: 9th / 16 49.5					

KANSAS STATE			UNIT RANKS
BIG 12 RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 16)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	7		
RUNNING BACKS	5		
RECEIVERS & TE	7		
OFFENSIVE LINE	10		
DEFENSIVE LINE	8		
LINEBACKERS	7		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	4		

KANSAS STATE			RANK
Scoring Offense	29.4 ppg	53	
Points per Play	0.47	30	
Total Offense	370 ypg	83	
Yards per Play	6.0	44	
Rushing Offense	171 ypg	52	
Yards per Carry	5.1	23	
O-Line Run Push	4.1	93	
Explosive Rush	7.1	20	
Passing Offense	199 ypg	97	
Yards / Attempt	7	81	
QB Rating	131	75	
TD / INT Ratio	2.6	49	
Sacks / Attempt	4%	16	
Explosive Pass	6.6	70	
Return. Production	65%	25	
Returning Snaps	11,100	48	
27.8 SECONDS/PLAY #52 of 68 P4			
KLEIN (2025 TEXAS A&M)			

Kansas State entered 2026 as the Big 12 media's pick to win the league. That expectation was quickly grounded with a loss to Iowa State in the week zero Ireland kickoff game, losses to Army and Arizona, and a near-loss to FCS North Dakota.

Twice more Kansas State lost games with in-game win probabilities over 95%. They led Baylor by 14 in the fourth quarter, but quarterback Avery Johnson threw a Pick Six and their last-second field goal was blocked. Then, despite rushing for a school-record 472 yards, KSU blew a 12-point lead in the final minutes at Utah.

Though it wasn't the full reason, the wild, emotional, 51-48 loss to Utah apparently weighed on seventh-year head coach Chris Klieman. "I've given my life for this place for seven years, I've given everything," he said after the loss. A few days later he told athletic director Gene Taylor he was ready to retire. And a day after their season-ending win over Colorado capped the 6-6 regular season, Klieman publicly retired.

Klieman hired former Kansas State star quarterback Collin Klein as his offensive coordinator back in 2022 and the move helped spark a title run. They beat eventual national runner-up TCU with a goal-line stand in overtime to earn KSU's third Big 12 title in school history. That 10-win season was followed by a pair of nine-win campaigns and Klieman leaves Manhattan as their second-winningest coach.

Now four years later, Kansas State brought Klein back – this time as head coach.

Klein was a Big 12 champion quarterback here, a Heisman runner-up, and now has stacked four successful years as a playcaller. His Kansas State and Texas A&M offenses have an average rank of #24 in my opponent-adjusted metric, and the final one led A&M's Playoff run last year.

Klein mentioned the impacts of all three head coach mentors. From Bill Snyder he learned how to build a culture and foundation, Klieman's defensive expertise helped grow his football knowledge from the other side of the ball, and Mike Elko helped on the recruiting trail.

OFFENSE

As a runner himself, Klein's offenses are built around mobile quarterbacks and in his transition season he gets to coach a familiar face. Klein originally recruited Avery Johnson to KSU, coached him in 2023 as Johnson got his first starts, and now re-unites with the dual-threat.

Johnson enters 2026 tied with Will Howard for the school's passing touchdown record (48) and is 2,500 yards off Josh Freeman's career yardage record. It has been boom-or-bust for Johnson. He has flashed breakaway straight-line speed, and streaky passing, but has been inconsistent over his career. His rushing skillset needs improvement and he struggles to power for the final extra yard when needed.

He has ranked #9 and #11 in the Big 12 in QB Rating, but he should make some statistical gains here in his final season with Klein's impact. The KS native originally picked KSU over national powerhouses because he wanted to play in Klein's offense.

The staff has mentioned a focus on a downhill, power run game. They certainly have the running back room for it, though the offensive line needs improvement.

In the opener, former five-star Dylan Edwards was injured on his first touch and was out most of the season and has since transferred over to Kansas. Joe Jackson took the opportunity as the new lead back and surged in November with a school-record 293 yards vs. Utah and then another 142 in the Colorado win. Jackson rushed for 900 but it snapped KSU's 1,000-yard back streak since 2020. Jackson is joined by Rodney Fields, who was a rare bright spot for Oklahoma State last year. He rushed for 614 yards (5 per carry), added 276 in the pass game, and was arguably their best player.

The uncertainty is in the trenches after a statistical decline last year from #5 to #93 in OL Run Push and the loss of two-time All-Big 12 lineman Sam Hecht. John Pastore returns as a sound pass-blocker and Gus Hawkins and former Ohio State transfer George Fitzpatrick are both back after injury-shortened seasons.

On the interior, the staff added three guys who could push for starting spots with Keiton Jones (Missouri), Delvin Morris (Akron) and Tanner Morley (Colorado State). All three had three-star transfer grades.

KANSAS STATE										
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)										
O	30	16	34	21	29	29	60	60	40	49
F	40th									
F	MATT WELLS	COLLIN KLEIN	COURTNEY MESSINGHAM	COLEMAN	DANA DIMEL					
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
D	10-YEAR									
E	JOE KLANDERMAN									
F	36	32	52	27	25	56	45	47	39	37
	39th									

KANSAS STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	26.7 ppg	79	
Points per Play	0.37	65	
Total Defense	386 ypg	83	
Yards per Play	5.3	47	
3rd Down Conv%	39%	66	
Rushing Defense	164 ypg	89	
Yards per Carry	4.1	60	
Negative Play %	8%	69	
Explosive Rush	7.0	87	
Passing Defense	222 ypg	73	
Yards / Attempt	6.8	51	
QB Rating	119	29	
Completion %	56.8%	21	
Explosive Pass	5.9	79	
Return. Production	51%	73	
Returning Snaps	9,184	77	

KANSAS STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		30	
Rushing Offense	0.7	17	
Passing Offense	4.2	39	
Defense Overall		36	
Rushing Defense	0.2	43	
Passing Defense	14.9	22	

two-time All-Big 12 Austin Romaine transferring to Texas Tech. Kansas State added All-CUSA Mekhi Mason (Louisiana Tech) and rising sophomore Darien Whitaker has drawn big reviews.

The two returning starters are the two corners: Donovan McIntosh and all-league Zashon Rich. VJ Payne graduated and two more starters left for Power 4 programs with nickel Daniel Cobbs (Baylor) and Qua Moss (Tennessee). Kansas State landed some starters of their own with nickel Ja'Son Prevard (Virginia) and Kaleb Patterson (Illinois). Adrian Maddox (Georgia) was a spring hero that could earn a starting safety spot.

OUTLOOK

The talent drain on defense hurts, but Kansas State leveraged the portal well to backfill with experienced Power 4 starters at end and defensive back. The offense is clearer with Klein reunited with his quarterback, plus a workhorse back, and an elite tight end pair.

Kansas State moves a few spots up the Big 12 ladder due to the best schedule draw as they avoid the league's top three.

Kansas State has one of the best tight end pairs in the Big 12 with the return of school-record holder Garrett Oakley and former five-star Linkon Cure.

Jayce Brown had 1,500+ receiving yards over the past two seasons and was considered one of the top players in the program but transferred out to LSU. Jerand Bradley graduated, so Jaron Tibbs is the lone returning starter at receiver. The staff added three transfers with Hawaii starter Brandon White and a pair of former four-stars Josh Manning (Missouri) and Izaiah Williams (Texas A&M). The staff nearly signed Manning out of high school, and he has a connection with Johnson – this could be the surprise breakout player they need.

DEFENSE

Klieman originally ran a 4-2-5 here, joined the Big 12's 3-3-5 craze, and now the program is back to a 4-2-5 base scheme with Klein's defensive coordinator pick Jordan Peterson. He was a co-coordinator for Texas A&M's playoff team last year, and before that he had a successful stint at Kansas landing four guys on the All-Big 12 teams.

It is a total reload here with *nine* starters gone.

Six of them earned All-Big 12 honors including all four defensive linemen. Cody Stufflebean and Damian Ilalio graduated but then the star duo of edge rushers Tobi Osunsanmi and Chiddi Obiazor both transferred out to Indiana.

The staff landed two proven playmakers of their own in Wendell Gregory (Oklahoma State) and Elijah Hill (Kennesaw State). Gregory earned a high four-star transfer grade and was the best Oklahoma State defender last year, while Hill led the entire C-USA with nine sacks as a freshman.

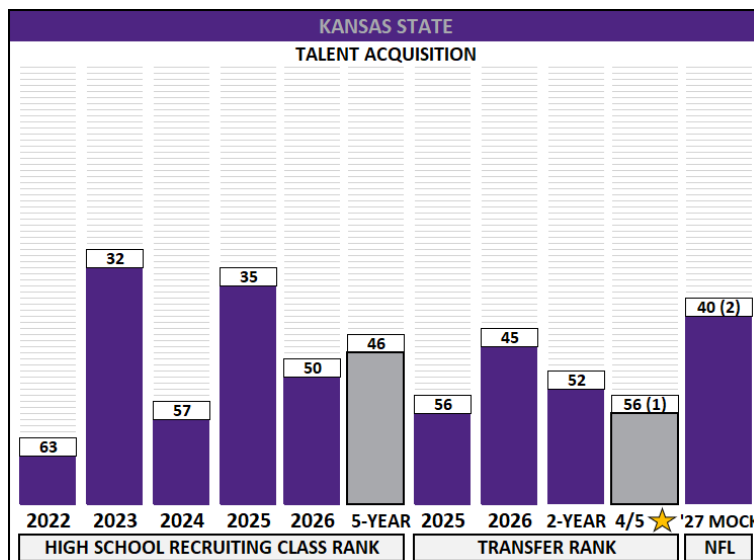
The incoming tackle duo has limited game experience but both are in from Power 4 programs: Kamari Burns (Cincinnati) and Austin Ramsey (Kentucky).

Both linebackers are gone with tackle-leader Desmond Purnell graduating and

KANSAS STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	NICHOLLS (FCS)
S. 12	WASHINGTON ST
S. 19	TULANE
S. 26	@ Cincinnati
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	HOUSTON
O. 17	KANSAS
O. 24	@ Arizona State
O. 31	@ Colorado
N. 7	OKLAHOMA ST
N. 14	@ TCU
N. 21	ARIZONA
N. 28	@ Iowa State

KANSAS STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	586	59	
All-Time Win %	0.464	64	
Wins (Last 100)	467	60	
Wins (Last 50)	317	38	
Wins (Last 25)	187	29	
Wins (Last 10)	76	24	
Wins (Last 5)	42	18	
Game Grader (10 yr)	54.0	26	
Game Grader (5 yr)	60.8	14	
Game Grader (3 yr)	60.1	22	
Draft Picks s' 2000	61	41	
Draft Picks s' 2010	30	50	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		3	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		3	

KANSAS STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
49.5 (41)	61.3 (20)	69.6 (13)	67.3 (14)	56.4 (29)	40.3 (51)	51.7 (30)	43.5 (53)	45.8 (44)	55 (25)	54 (26)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



ARIZONA STATE

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#7

#32

BIG 12

OVERALL



ARIZONA STATE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14	(B) Wisconsin		(P) Texas	(B) Duke
13	OREGON ST	ARIZONA	CINCINNATI	ARIZONA
12	WASH ST	OREGON ST	TEXAS TECH	HOUSTON
11	UTAH	WASH ST	(CG) Iowa St	UTAH
10	BYU	UCLA	ARIZONA	Miss. State
9		STANFORD	BYU	
8	ARIZONA	USC	KANSAS ST	COLORADO
7	WASHINGTON	UTAH	UCF	W. VIRGINIA
6	USC	E. Michigan	OKLA ST	IOWA ST
5	STANFORD	Okla St	UTAH	TEXAS TECH
4	UCLA		KANSAS	TCU
3	COLORADO	COLORADO	Texas St	BAYLOR
2	UNLV	WASHINGTON	Miss St	Texas St
1	S. Utah (FCS)	WASH ST	Wyoming	N. Arizona (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	HERM EDWARDS		KENNY DILLINGHAM	2025

ARIZONA STATE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
N. Arizona (FCS) W 38-19	127	0	56.5	
MISS. ST L 20-24	-12	-2	32.5	
TEXAS ST W 34-15	130	2	74.4	
BAYLOR W 27-24	43	3	54.5	
TCU W 27-24	229	2	80.1	
UTAH L 10-42	-139	0	9.0	
TEXAS TECH W 26-22	118	1	88.7	
HOUSTON L 16-24	42	-1	37.5	
IOWA ST W 24-19	131	-2	72.8	
W. VIRGINIA W 25-23	-91	0	35.5	
COLORADO W 42-17	280	-3	79.6	
ARIZONA L 7-23	-160	-4	16.4	
(B) DUKE L 39-42	80	-2	52.5	
OVERALL: 36th / 68	BIG 12: 8th / 16		53.1	

ARIZONA STATE		UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK	NATIONAL		
(of 16)	TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	9		
RUNNING BACKS	8		
RECEIVERS & TE	2		
OFFENSIVE LINE	8		
DEFENSIVE LINE	4		
LINEBACKERS	3		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	6		

ARIZONA STATE		RANK	
Scoring Offense	25.8 ppg	81	
Points per Play	0.36	97	
Total Offense	417 ypg	30	
Yards per Play	5.9	50	
Rushing Offense	194 ypg	27	
Yards per Carry	5.1	25	
O-Line Run Push	4.5	28	
Explosive Rush	7.4	14	
Passing Offense	224 ypg	69	
Yards / Attempt	6.8	91	
QB Rating	126	87	
TD / INT Ratio	2.2	58	
Sacks / Attempt	6%	69	
Explosive Pass	6.0	93	
Return. Production	53%	70	
Returning Snaps	12,577	32	
25.7 SECONDS/PLAY #26 of 68 P4			
ARROYO (2025 ASU)			

Heading into 2024, Arizona State was picked dead last by Big 12 media but Kenny Dillingham's upstart roster surged to a surprise Big 12 title and Playoff appearance. With virtually the entire starting lineup back – minus the hardnosed running back Cam Skattebo – ASU entered with an AP Top 15 ranking as Big 12 contenders.

Arizona State opened up Big 12 play with consecutive 27-24 wins over Baylor and TCU. Both games featured last-minute drives led by quarterback Sam Leavitt and eventual first-rounder Jordyn Tyson. Leavitt showed off pocket elusiveness, scramble touchdown runs, and even a jump pass.

Leavitt again led a game-winning touchdown drive in the final minute against #6 Texas Tech, fans stormed the field, and Tech head coach Joey McGuire praised him: "that quarterback changes everything – he's a difference maker."

Unfortunately Arizona State learned the hard way, because with Leavitt knocked out of the lineup, his absence *did* change everything. Utah dealt a 42-10 beatdown, ASU lost another to Houston, and then gave away five turnovers in a 23-7 Territorial Cup loss to Arizona.

While the 8-5 season appears to be a disappointment, it should be viewed together with the 2024 title run, within the context of a two-year window. With essentially the same cast of characters, and despite injuries to Leavitt and Tyson, Arizona State won 19 games – the best two-year span since 2013-14 and third best here since the 1970's.

As he promised two years ago, Dillingham did in fact Activate the Valley.

18 starters are gone, and Arizona State flips from the most veteran roster to a new-look transition lineup.

OFFENSE

Dillingham boosted the transition with an impressive transfer haul that ranked third-best in the Big 12 and #15 nationally. While just one starter returns on offense, Arizona State added five other Power 4 starters.

Leavitt transferred out to LSU as the top-rated transfer this cycle, but ASU added back a starter of their own in 6'5 Cutter Boley (Kentucky). The former four-star started ten games as a freshman last year, ranked #12 in the SEC in QB Rating and #6 among all Power 4 freshmen.

Boley completed a high 65% of passes, and showed off a big arm with impressive touch and enough pocket presence and mobility to extend plays. He did toss 12 interceptions, though offensive coordinator Marcus Arroyo claims that many were in end-of-game desperation heaves downfield.

The staff also signed veteran Mikey Keene (Michigan) who started 34 games at UCF and Fresno State, but it was Top100 true freshman Jake Fette who stole the show in spring and could eventually win the backup job in fall camp.

Tyson was picked #8 overall in the NFL Draft and Malik McClain graduated, leaving All-Big 12 honorable mention Derek Eusebio as the lone returning starter on offense. But Arizona State dominated the portal here with one of the nation's best receiver hauls. They signed three starters off Power 4 rosters headlined by All-Big 12 Omarion Miller, who was Colorado's MVP and ranked as the #3 transfer receiver. Reed Harris (Boston College) also earned four-star transfer hype as a vertical threat and Raiden Vines-Bright (Washington) broke into the rotation as a true freshman. Jalen Moss also returns in the slot, and this is the clear strength of the team.

Raleek Brown rushed for 1,141 yards and a high 6.1 per carry in the workhorse role but he transferred out to Texas with four-star grades. Jason Brown rushed for 134 in the Sun Bowl, Kyson Brown is the returning veteran after injuries limited him in 2025, and a pair of FCS backs will compete for carries. Marquis Gillis (Del State) was a Top 10 FCS back (1,200 yards, 6.5 per) and David Avit (Villanova) is the short-yardage hammer.

ARIZONA STATE					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	32	27	66	48	30	6	46	17	33	62				
F	MARCUS ARROYO	BALDWIN	THOMAS	ZAK HILL	ROB LIKENS	NAPIER	LINDSEY							43rd
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	BRIAN WARD	HENDERSON	PIERCE	LEWIS	DANNY GONZALES	BENNETT	PATTERSON							
E	23	20	45	60	19	33	35	54	51	66				46th
F														

ARIZONA STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	24.5 ppg	65	
Points per Play	0.35	50	
Total Defense	358 ypg	57	
Yards per Play	5.1	38	
3rd Down Conv%	36%	41	
Rushing Defense	124 ypg	31	
Yards per Carry	3.6	30	
Negative Play %	9%	29	
Explosive Rush	5.5	37	
Passing Defense	234 ypg	95	
Yards / Attempt	6.6	41	
QB Rating	127	51	
Completion %	60.3%	44	
Explosive Pass	4.7	22	
Return. Production	49%	79	
Returning Snaps	14,625	12	

ARIZONA STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		32	
Rushing Offense	0.6	18	
Passing Offense	(3.7)	48	
Defense Overall		23	
Rushing Defense	0.7	23	
Passing Defense	11.0	24	

West and earned four-star transfer grades. Long was flying all over the field in spring ball and should make this position a “reload” instead of a rebuild.

All five original starting defensive backs are gone, though safety Adrian Wilson stepped up after Xavion Alford was injured, and Montana Warren surged at nickel. ASU will miss the cornerback duo of NFL-bound Keith Abney and Wisconsin-bound Javan Robinson, though the staff added Ashton Stamps (LSU) who was once an SEC starter before falling out of the lineup last year. Rodney Bimage moved up into the other starting job opposite of Stamps, and safety Lyrik Rawls (Kansas) had 73 tackles last year.

OUTLOOK

Arizona State loses 18 starters and the core of their two-year run. Dillingham reloaded at quarterback and landed one of the nation’s best transfer hauls at receiver.

There are too many uncertainties with this transition roster – the offensive line and 10 new starters on defense -- to call for a Big 12 title run, but Arizona State remains in the crowded mid-tier of the league.

Chamon Metayer graduated with Big 12 honors, and now Arizona State turns to a pair of former four-stars Khamari Anderson and AJ Ia.

The offensive line is a total rebuild with all five starters gone and anchor left tackle Max Iheanachor heading to the pros as a first-round pick. At least the center spot is set, as the staff stole Georgia Tech’s starter Tana Alo-Tupuola off a top-rated line. Luke Baklenko was a two-year starter at Stanford, a backup at Oklahoma, and should win the right tackle spot here. Another likely starter is incoming left tackle Jarmaine Mitchell, the nation’s #1 overall JUCO prospect and Georgia flip. Maki Stewart earned some starts late in the season at guard, but given the overall transition here a third-straight Top 40 finish in OL Run Push is in question.

DEFENSE

Brian Ward has stacked consecutive Top 25 defenses per my opponent-adjusted metrics and Arizona State and BYU were the only in the league to do so.

To make it three straight, they must pull off a total reset to the two-deep. Ten opening day starters are gone including six who earned All-Big 12 nominations.

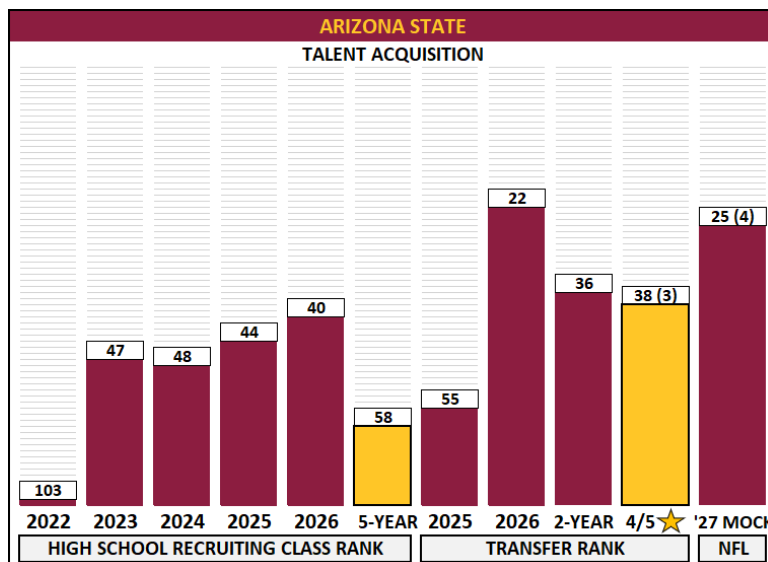
The lone returner is CJ Fite, the star defensive tackle who returned to Tempe after considering an early NFL bid. Prince Dorbah, Justin Wodtly, and Elijah O’Neal are all gone, but ASU got a break when 2024 starting defensive end Clayton Smith won an eligibility appeal for a final bonus year in 2026. The staff signed a pair of Power 4 starters at defensive end with Jalen Thompson (Michigan State) and Emar’rion Winston (Baylor). Four-star signee Julian Hugo was a spring hero per practice reports. Another wildcard is 6’5, 260-pound JUCO transfer Kirt Vakalahi.

Jordan Crook and Keyshaun Elliott both landed on the All-Big 12 second-team after combining for 199 tackles – first and second on the team – but both graduated. Martell Hughes got partial-starter playing time with 400 snaps and now rises to the starting lineup. Then the staff signed the nation’s tackle leader Owen Long (Colorado State) who was first-team All-Mountain

ARIZONA STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	MORGAN ST (FCS)
S. 12	@ Texas A&M
S. 19	*KANSAS (LONDON)
S. 26	--- BYE ---
O. 3	BAYLOR
O. 10	HAWAII
O. 17	@ Texas Tech
O. 24	KANSAS STATE
O. 31	@ BYU
N. 7	COLORADO
N. 14	@ UCF
N. 21	OKLAHOMA ST
N. 28	@ Arizona

ARIZONA STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	657	44	
All-Time Win %	0.601	20	
Wins (Last 100)	622	26	
Wins (Last 50)	337	29	
Wins (Last 25)	167	43	
Wins (Last 10)	62	45	
Wins (Last 5)	33	39	
Game Grader (10 yr)	48.0	42	
Game Grader (5 yr)	47.8	42	
Game Grader (3 yr)	51.3	31	
Draft Picks s' 2000	67	36	
Draft Picks s' 2010	35	45	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		27	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		29	

ARIZONA STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
53.1 (36)	66.5 (14)	34.2 (57)	31.2 (61)	54.2 (31)	64.5 (16)	50 (33)	50.8 (36)	47 (42)	28.1 (63)	48 (42)	





ARIZONA

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#8

BIG 12

#33

OVERALL



ARIZONA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13				
12	ARIZONA ST	WASH ST	USC	(B) SMU
11	WASH ST	UTAH	WASHINGTON	HOUSTON
10	UTAH	USC	Miss St	BYU
9	USC	WASHINGTON	(B) Oklahoma	IOWA ST
8	WASHINGTON	OREGON	ARIZONA ST	ARIZONA ST
7	COLORADO	CAL	UTAH	BAYLOR
6	UCLA	Miss St	COLORADO	CINCINNATI
5	OREGON	ARIZONA ST	UCLA	KANSAS
4	N. Arizona (FCS)	UCLA	OREGON ST	COLORADO
3	San Diego St	COLORADO	WASH ST	OKLA ST
2	BYU	NDSU (FCS)	STANFORD	Kansas St *
1	CAL	San Diego St	UTEP	Weber St (FCS)
		N. Arizona (FCS)	New Mexico	Hawaii
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	JEDD FISCH		BRENT BRENNAN	

ARIZONA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
HAWAII	W 40-6	54	5	79.9
Weber St (FCS)	W 48-3	372	2	77.1
KANSAS ST	W 23-17	219	-1	78.5
IOWA ST	L 14-39	-39	-1	18.4
OKLAHOMA ST	W 41-13	320	-1	76.9
BYU	L 27-33	-47	1	42.4
HOUSTON	L 28-31	-15	0	41.7
COLORADO	W 52-17	118	3	81.8
KANSAS	W 24-20	-46	0	46.5
CINCINNATI	W 30-24	131	2	66.1
BAYLOR	W 41-17	12	2	71.7
ARIZONA ST	W 23-7	160	4	90.2
(B) SMU	L 19-24	49	2	55.8
OVERALL: 18th / 68	BIG 12: 3rd / 16			63.6

ARIZONA		UNIT RANKS
BIG 12 RANK		NATIONAL
(of 16)		TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	1	11
RUNNING BACKS	9	
RECEIVERS & TE	6	
OFFENSIVE LINE	11	
DEFENSIVE LINE	5	
LINEBACKERS	4	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	7	

ARIZONA		RANK
Scoring Offense	31.5 ppg	30
Points per Play	0.45	41
Total Offense	408 ypg	42
Yards per Play	5.8	52
Rushing Offense	152 ypg	75
Yards per Carry	4.3	72
O-Line Run Push	4.4	41
Explosive Rush	5.6	53
Passing Offense	255 ypg	36
Yards / Attempt	7.4	60
QB Rating	143	46
TD / INT Ratio	3.6	17
Sacks / Attempt	7%	90
Explosive Pass	6.2	87
Return. Production	66%	24
Returning Snaps	11,466	43
25.5 SECONDS/PLAY #21 of 68 P4		
DOEGE (2025 ARIZONA)		

The morale was low when head coach Jedd Fisch left for Washington, took several star players with him, and spoiled a potential dream season scenario for 2024.

Instead, Arizona struggled through the conference transition and finished 4-8 with a 49-7 loss to rival Arizona State as the final dagger.

Entering his second year, head coach Brent Brennan went with a double coordinator switch and both moves were home runs. Seth Doege's offense added a full two touchdowns per game, and Arizona had a first-team all-league quarterback for the first time in 50 years.

The other side of the ball was even stronger. Danny Gonzales' 3-3-5 defense puzzled opposing coordinators, and the star-studded secondary posted the nation's #1 pass defense in opposing QB Rating.

Arizona started 4-3 with a pair of losses on the final play – a double-overtime loss to BYU and a walk-off field goal by Houston – but rallied over the back half of the season. Noah Fifita found another gear, the defense held Baylor's top passing attack 200 yards under average, and

then the close games flipped to wins.

Arizona posted a nine-win season for just the eighth time in school history.

How's that for a second-year coach bonus?

Brennan completed the three-year boomerang, from Top 20 in Fisch's final year, to bottom ten, back to the Top 20 with a #18 finish in Game Grader.

OFFENSE

In an era devoid of loyalty, Brennan claims Fifita "is the best story in college football... he's chosen to stay, not take the money and run." Fifita remained after the Fisch coaching change, again after his best friend Tetairoa McMillan went pro, and now again after All-Big 12 honors that certainly would have placed him atop the transfer portal wish list.

Fifita passed for 3,228 yards, 29 touchdowns and only tossed two picks over the final seven games. He even added a new facet to his game, with 220 rushing yards on designed runs. And now finally he gets coordinator stability, with another year in Doege's scheme. He's already got the career passing touchdown record (73) and needs 600 yards to pass Nick Foles for the yardage record.

Earlier in the season Javin Whatley was his top target, then Kris Hutson emerged with several 100+ yard games. Both top receivers are gone, but the 2026 room looks like an upgrade. 6'4 Tre Spivey returns after earning All-Big 12 honorable mention with 8 touchdowns on just 25 touches. Chris Hunter moves up into the starting rotation, Gio Richardson had 299 yards as a freshman, and Isaiah Mizell is the program's fastest player. The staff added a pair of former blue-chippers with West Virginia starter Rodney Gallagher and Top100 DJ Jordan (USC).

The top two tight ends graduated but original starter Tyler Powell is back after his season ended on the first play from scrimmage. Cole Rusk started for Illinois and they signed a four-star Henry Gabalis.

It was a trio of backs last year and the rushing leader Ismail Mahdi graduated after leading with 859 yards. Quincy Craig had the game-winner to beat Kansas, Kedrick Reescano punched in nine touchdowns including the Cincinnati winner, and these two form a thunder-lightning pair for 2026.

The offensive line had to use seven different lineups in 2024 but finally got some stability last year and it paid off statistically with a 50+ spot jump in my OL Run Push from #90 to #40. Three starters are gone including their lone all-league honoree left tackle Ty Buchanan. The right side returns with guard Alexander Doost and tackle Tristan Bounds getting awarded a sixth year of eligibility. Due to injuries last year, Matthew Lado and Rhino Tapa'atoutai were forced into action with mixed results. Both now move up into the projected starting lineup, and in the middle the staff signed Zach Henning (Washington) who also got some starting experience due to injuries ahead of him.

ARIZONA					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	40	43	14	8	59	55	49	24	8	19				25th
F	DOEGE	BABERS	BRENNAN	CARROLL	NOEL MAZZONE	MAGEE / SMITH								
F	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	GONZALES	AKINA	JOHNNY NANSEN	BROWN	RHOADS									
E	11	63	33	63	53	61	57	50	56	56				61st
F														

ARIZONA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	19.3 ppg	21	
Points per Play	0.29	17	
Total Defense	309 ypg	19	
Yards per Play	4.7	11	
3rd Down Conv%	34%	24	
Rushing Defense	143 ypg	58	
Yards per Carry	3.9	52	
Negative Play %	9%	30	
Explosive Rush	5.1	26	
Passing Defense	165 ypg	7	
Yards / Attempt	5.6	6	
QB Rating	97	1	
Completion %	54%	7	
Explosive Pass	4.8	29	
Return. Production	55%	56	
Returning Snaps	13,650	20	

ARIZONA		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		40	
Rushing Offense	0.1	36	
Passing Offense	6.3	37	
Defense Overall		11	
Rushing Defense	0.5	32	
Passing Defense	32.3	6	

DEFENSE

Gonzales led the biggest defensive turnaround in FBS last year. Arizona improved by 50+ spots in all 17 of my stat categories, jumped all the way up to #11 in my opponent-adjusted defense ranking, and the pass defense ranked #1 in Opponent QB Rating.

He says they are now “losing the best secondary in the nation” and before you dismiss that as coach-speak, Arizona had *four* defensive backs drafted this April to tie an NFL Draft record. And a fifth one was signed as a free agent.

Arizona ranked second nationally with 22 interceptions, led with 2.5 takeaways/game, and it seemed like every ten minutes they were stuffing another football on their Turnover Sword. They held eight straight opponents under 200 passing yards – a Big 12 best since 2004 Missouri.

Treydan Stukes and Dalton Johnson both earned first-team All-Big 12 and Genesis Smith got third-team recognition. Their big three are gone along with three other corners and it reminds me of when Illinois built the nation’s #1 pass defense in 2022, sent three guys to the Top 66 draft picks, and then fell all the way to #70 the following year.

In this example though, the mastermind coordinator returns. All-Big 12 corner Jay’vion Cole had four interceptions and is the lone returning starter. And they also packed the room with eight transfers to jump start the reload. Nebraska starter Malcolm Hartzog can play every position, Cam Chapa (Northern Colorado) was first-team All-Big Sky at the FCS level, and Tyrese Boss (Wyoming) was All-Mountain West. Some less experienced signees have bigger recruiting profiles like the pair of former Top100’s Daylen Austin (Oregon) and Matai Tagoa’i (USC) who the staff moved from backer to safety.

There is relatively more continuity in the front six, as they return six of their top ten. Original starter and team captain Tre Smith is back after a season-ending injury last year. He’s posted 60 tackles, 8.5 for loss, and 4.5 sacks over his two seasons. Leroy Palu is back in the middle, alongside

Mays Pese who made an instant impact and was named Big 12 All-Freshman.

Gonzales was creative with his linebackers and lined them up all over the field. He even rolled out a Red Rover package where the backers all held hands pre-snap and then dart in different directions after the snap. It worked right away as Jabari Mann took back a Pick Six the first time the tactic was unveiled. Taye Brown is a third-year starter, Chase Kennedy returns as a backer/edge hybrid, and Mann and Myron Robinson also return.

OUTLOOK

A nine-win team that returns an all-conference quarterback would normally be projected higher but there are some forces against Arizona in 2026. It was actually the defense that was the reason for their breakthrough, specifically their elite secondary, but all four defensive backs were drafted.

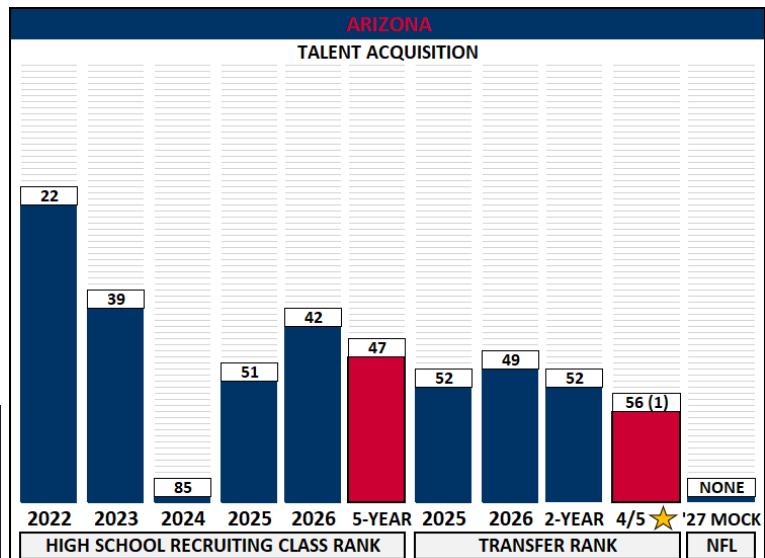
They are #8 in the Big 12 in five-year recruiting, and second-worst from the portal with just one four-star transfer the past two cycles combined.

Lastly, they drew the toughest schedule in the conference, as the only Big 12 contender to draw six of the top seven.

ARIZONA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	N. ARIZONA (FCS)
S. 12	@ BYU
S. 19	N. ILLINOIS
S. 26	@ Washington St
O. 3	CINCINNATI
O. 10	@ West Virginia
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	IOWA STATE
O. 31	@ Texas Tech
N. 6	TCU
N. 14	UTAH
N. 21	@ Kansas State
N. 28	ARIZONA STATE

ARIZONA		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	644	48	
All-Time Win %	0.556	41	
Wins (Last 100)	551	43	
Wins (Last 50)	300	47	
Wins (Last 25)	136	59	
Wins (Last 10)	48	63	
Wins (Last 5)	29	51	
Game Grader (10 yr)	41.2	58	
Game Grader (5 yr)	46.6	46	
Game Grader (3 yr)	55.6	27	
Draft Picks s' 2000	49	49	
Draft Picks s' 2010	28	51	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		5	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		24	

ARIZONA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
63.6 (18)	33.8 (60)	69.6 (14)	38.4 (53)	27.8 (61)	23.4 (65)	30.9 (61)	44.4 (50)	50 (36)	29.9 (61)	41.2 (58)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



OKLAHOMA STATE

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#9(TIE) #47

BIG 12 OVERALL



OKLAHOMA STATE 5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14 (CG) Baylor	(B) Wisconsin	(CG) Texas		
13 IOWA ST	WVU	UCF		
12 (B) Notre Dame	OKLAHOMA	IOWA ST		
11 OKLAHOMA	KANSAS	S. Alabama		
10 TEXAS TECH	KANSAS	(B) Texas A&M		
9 TCU	TCU	BYU		
8 WVU	IOWA ST	HOUSTON		
7 KANSAS	TEXAS	OKLAHOMA		
6 TEXAS	TEXAS TECH	CINCINNATI		
5 BAYLOR	BAYLOR	WVU		
4 KANSAS ST	Ark PB (FCS)	KANSAS		
3 Boise State	Arizona St	KANSAS ST		
2 Tulsa	C. Michigan	Arizona St		
1 MO St (FCS)		Cent. Ark (FCS)		
		Tulsa		
		Arkansas		
		SoDak St (FCS)		
		UT-Martin (FCS)		
2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
MIKE GUNDY				

OKLAHOMA STATE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
UT Martin (FCS) W 27-7	134	1	59.5	
OREGON L 3-69	-420	-2	0.0	
TULSA L 12-19	-21	1	24.7	
BAYLOR L 27-45	-164	1	15.3	
ARIZONA L 13-41	-320	1	7.0	
HOUSTON L 17-39	-260	-1	7.3	
CINCINNATI L 17-49	-50	-2	11.6	
TEXAS TECH L 0-42	-188	0	5.3	
KANSAS L 21-38	-26	0	21.3	
KANSAS ST L 6-14	89	-4	41.3	
UCF L 14-17	-168	1	26.9	
IOWA ST L 13-20	-117	-1	25.0	
OVERALL: 68th / 68 BIG 12: 16th / 16 20.4				

OKLAHOMA ST UNIT RANKS		
BIG 12 RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 16)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	2	15
RUNNING BACKS	4	
RECEIVERS & TE	4	
OFFENSIVE LINE	5	
DEFENSIVE LINE	10	
LINEBACKERS	12	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	13	

OKLAHOMA STATE			RANK
Scoring Offense	14.2 ppg	134	
Points per Play	0.22	135	
Total Offense	292 ypg	130	
Yards per Play	4.6	132	
Rushing Offense	118 ypg	114	
Yards per Carry	3.5	122	
O-Line Run Push	3.8	120	
Explosive Rush	3.7	122	
Passing Offense	174 ypg	116	
Yards / Attempt	5.7	131	
QB Rating	106	134	
TD / INT Ratio	0.7	134	
Sacks / Attempt	6%	78	
Explosive Pass	4.9	124	
Return. Production	62%	35	
Returning Snaps	16,965	7	
23.4 SECONDS/PLAY	#5 of 68 P4		
MORRIS (2025 N. TEXAS)	FAST		

Mike Gundy's 18-year streak of winning seasons was snapped in 2024. He attempted a complete rebuild for 2025 by hiring 11 new coaches and adding 40 players from the transfer portal.

In their first FBS game Oklahoma State lost to Oregon 69-3, for their worst defeat since 1907. Oregon outgained them by 430 yards, scored at will, and took back Pick Sixes on consecutive plays. At times, Oklahoma State looked like an unprepared high school team.

Then Tulsa came into Stillwater and won there for the first time since 1951. The Cowboy fans were chanting "Fire Gundy" throughout the game.

Oklahoma State did just that, four days after the Tulsa embarrassment -- OSU's 11th straight FBS loss -- and ended Gundy's 21-year tenure. The collapse was caused by his resistance to get the fundraising/NIL program up to speed, young/unproven coordinator hires, and below average high school recruiting.

It was time for a change, but Gundy will still be remembered as an Oklahoma State legend, the winningest coach in school history, and the figurehead that elevated them to heights unthinkable a generation ago. As *Pistols Firing* podcast put it: "Mike Gundy is as Oklahoma State as Pistol Pete himself."

The season only got worse after the September firing. Oklahoma State went 0-9 in Big 12 play with the first six by double-digits and the final three in one-score heartbreakers. At 1-11 overall, and the lone win against their FCS opponent, Oklahoma State finished *dead last* 68th of 68 in my opponent-adjusted Game Grader.

For the first time since the 1960s, Oklahoma State hired an active head coach from another FBS program. They picked Eric Morris who led North Texas to a 12-2 dream season that had them in the AAC title game and in the mix for a Playoff spot. The hire signals their desire to return to the brand of football from Gundy's peak years: an explosive Air Raid offensive system.

Morris has been a head coach or offensive coordinator for 13 years at Texas Tech, Incarnate Word, Washington State, and North Texas. Over those 13 years, 9 were Top 5 passing attacks, 10 were Top 10 total offense, and 10 were Top 25 in scoring.

OFFENSE

His 2025 North Texas unit was his best yet, ranked #1 nationally in both scoring (45 points/game) and total offense (512 yards/game). Morris brought his offensive coordinator Sean Brophy and was able to land six of his offensive starters too.

It is a complete roster overhaul here as Oklahoma State signed 62 transfers, 26 from Power 4 rosters, and 18 from North Texas. Most importantly, the staff brought their top passer, rusher, and receiver, with the All-AAC trio each earning four-star transfer grades.

Drew Mestemaker was the nation's passing champ with 4,379 yards, placed second with 34 touchdowns, and finished #4 in QB Rating. The 6'4 pocket passer was ranked the #3 transfer quarterback of the entire cycle and will be Oklahoma State's first NFL-caliber quarterback since Mason Rudolph in 2018. On top of the physical skills, Morris loves Mestemaker's fast post-snap processing.

Oklahoma State's lead rusher and top playmaker Rodney Fields transferred out to Kansas State, the three starting receivers are gone, so the skill positions are total roster resets.

The staff brought their star running back Caleb Hawkins who led the AAC with 1,434 rushing yards. He led the entire country with his 25 rushing touchdowns and also kept a high 6.2 per-carry average. Tre Page is the #2 back after leading FCS Tarleton with 839 yards as a freshman.

Slot receiver Wyatt Young led the AAC with 1,264 yards and ranked second with an explosive 18.1 yards/catch average. Young headlines one of the top transfer receiver hauls this cycle along with four-star speedster Chris Barnes (Wake Forest) and the 6'5 red zone threat Justin Bowick (Illinois).

OKLAHOMA STATE										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	65	48	36	56	53	33	17	27	4	7									29th
F	MEACHAM	KASEY DUNN					GLEESON	MIKE YURCICH											
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016									10-YEAR
D	GRANTHAM	BRYAN NARDO	MASON				JIM KNOWLES			GLENN SPENCER									
E	62	67	59	46	2	20	46	52	30	44									49th
F																			

OKLAHOMA STATE		RANK
Scoring Defense	33.3 ppg	126
Points per Play	0.5	127
Total Defense	418 ypg	116
Yards per Play	6.3	123
3rd Down Conv%	44%	115
Rushing Defense	166 ypg	93
Yards per Carry	4.4	83
Negative Play %	8%	61
Explosive Rush	6.6	72
Passing Defense	252 ypg	121
Yards / Attempt	8.9	132
QB Rating	164	134
Completion %	65.6%	114
Explosive Pass	9.1	134
Return. Production	53%	65
Returning Snaps	17,656	3

OKLAHOMA STATE		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		65
Rushing Offense	(0.5)	60
Passing Offense	(22.2)	67
Defense Overall		62
Rushing Defense	0.3	40
Passing Defense	(23.6)	67

Williams (Florida State). Keviyen Huddleston (North Texas) followed his coordinator, and they were able to retain some partial starters in Jaleel Johnson and Malik Charles.

The secondary was torched last year with bottom-five national marks in Opponent QB Rating, Yards/Attempt, and Explosive Passing. The staff retained cornerback LaDainian Fields and brought their top corner from the North Texas secondary in Kollin Lewis. Mo Horn (Texas Tech) will compete at corner, and Christian Bodnar (Liberty) got huge spring praise from Morris. Cameron Epps is back from injury and hopes to return to his 2023 form, plus another round of transfers will compete for the other safety spot: Vincent Holmes (Washington), Quinton Hammonds (North Texas), and Mose Phillips (Missouri).

OUTLOOK

Gundy's best Oklahoma State teams featured explosive passing attacks and that is exactly what Morris brought with him. As he said, "I was born in the Big 12."

Morris imported the core of his #1 ranked North Texas offense – including first-round NFL quarterback prospect Mestemaker – and this will be the most improved offense of 2026.

The defense is a total rebuilding project, but still Oklahoma State is a darkhorse team and moves up from dead last to the middle of a crowded Big 12 field.

Miles Coleman and Terrence Lewis combined for 734 yards last year for North Texas and should add to the rotation here. Donovan Green (LSU) emerged as the starting tight end in spring as a blocker and pass threat.

Another position, another complete rebuild. The offensive line struggled the past two seasons and last year ranked in the bottom ten in OL Run Push and yards/carry. Six offensive linemen transferred out to Power 4 programs, and their only Big 12 honoree Bob Schick graduated. It will be an all-transfer starting five, with the addition of three North Texas starters and three more from Power 4 programs. All were rated as three-star transfers: center Tyler Mercer (Kansas), guards Jacob Sexton (Oklahoma) and Johnny Dickson (North Texas), and tackles Braydon Nelson (North Texas) and Ashton Lepo (Michigan State). Dickson and Nelson earned All-AAC honors and are familiar with the scheme, while the other three have 31 combined starts at the Power 4 level.

DEFENSE

Last offseason, Morris hired 30-year-old defensive coordinator Skyler Cassity away from Sam Houston State where he led a Top 25 defense. Cassity then led one of the biggest one-year statistical turnarounds last year, improving North Texas from their bottom ten marks (34 points and 460 yards per game) up to middle-of-the-pack (25 points and 370 yards per game).

More importantly, when paired with a high-powered offense, the goal of the defense is to create turnovers and steal extra possessions back. His Sam Houston State defense grabbed 27 takeaways, North Texas had 26 last year, and both were Top 10 ranks.

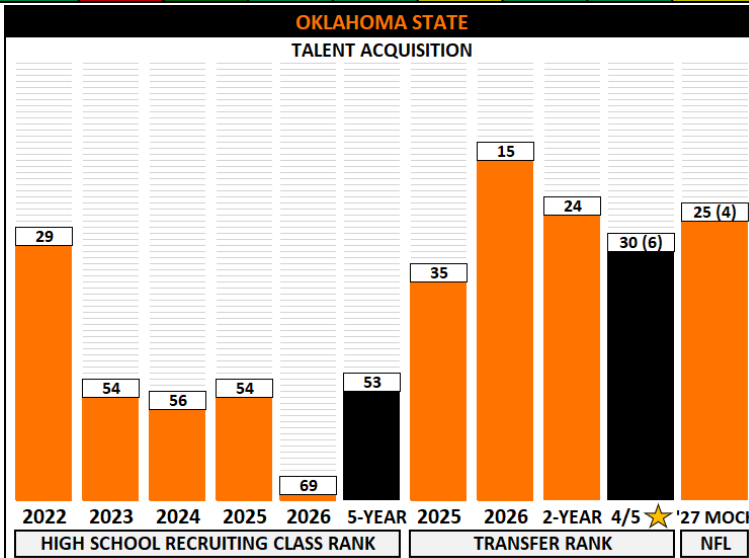
Cassity brought his star linebacker Ethan Wesloski with him and he'll lead another transfer-heavy unit with as many as seven new starters from the portal. Wesloski earned All-AAC honors, Isaiah Chisom (UCLA) and Tate Romney (Arizona State) bring Power 4 starting experience, and Jack Puckett (Central Oklahoma) was a DII All-American.

Oklahoma State lost their best pass rusher as Wendell Gregory transferred out to South Carolina with a four-star transfer grade. But the staff landed some Power 4 vets of their own with tackles Jerry Lawson (Louisville) and Braylon Rigsby (Texas Tech), and pass rush specialist James

OKLAHOMA STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	@ Tulsa
S. 12	OREGON
S. 19	MURRAY ST (FCS)
S. 26	@ West Virginia
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	UCF
O. 17	@ Houston
O. 24	COLORADO
O. 31	@ Iowa State
N. 7	@ Kansas State
N. 14	TEXAS TECH
N. 21	@ Arizona State
N. 28	KANSAS

OKLAHOMA STATE		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	641	51
All-Time Win %	0.519	48
Wins (Last 100)	564	39
Wins (Last 50)	335	31
Wins (Last 25)	198	22
Wins (Last 10)	76	24
Wins (Last 5)	33	39
Game Grader (10 yr)	53.5	27
Game Grader (5 yr)	45.6	49
Game Grader (3 yr)	35.0	64
Draft Picks s' 2000	46	54
Draft Picks s' 2010	33	47
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		59
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		37

OKLAHOMA STATE				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
20.4 (68)	28.1 (64)	56.3 (25)	47.3 (46)	75.9 (5)	60.6 (21)	56.1 (24)	52.6 (32)	73.1 (11)	64.9 (14)	53.5 (27)



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



UCF

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#9(TIE)

BIG 12

#48

OVERALL



UCF				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14		(B) Duke		
13	SMU	(CG) Tulane	(B) GA Tech	
12	CINCINNATI	NAVY	TEXAS TECH	
11	NAVY	ECU	WVU	
10	Louisville	Louisville	OKLAHOMA	
9	(B) Florida	USF	KANSAS	
8	USF	TULANE	BAYLOR	
7	UConn	MEMPHIS	KANSAS ST	
6	TULANE	CINCINNATI	HOUSTON	
5	TEMPLE	TEMPLE	OKLA ST	
4	MEMPHIS	SMU	CINCINNATI	
3	ECU	Georgia Tech	Arizona	
2	Beth-Cook (FCS)	FAU	Boise State	
1	Boise State	SC State (FCS)	Kent State	
2021		2022	2023	2024
GUS MALZAHN				FROST

UCF				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
JAX ST W 17-10	100	0	54.7	
NC A&T (FCS) W 68-7	360	3	77.8	
UNC W 34-9	149	2	78.2	
KANSAS ST L 20-34	-32	-2	24.9	
KANSAS L 20-27	19	-1	32.0	
CINCINNATI L 11-20	107	-1	38.1	
W. VIRGINIA W 45-13	368	-1	86.0	
BAYLOR L 3-30	-192	-1	5.5	
HOUSTON L 27-30	-151	2	33.9	
TEXAS TECH L 9-48	-269	-2	1.1	
OKLAHOMA ST W 17-14	168	-1	51.3	
BYU L 21-41	-111	-2	19.4	
OVERALL: 52nd / 68 BIG 12: 13th / 16 41.9				

UCF	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK (of 16)	NATIONAL	TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	8	
RUNNING BACKS	11	
RECEIVERS & TE	13	
OFFENSIVE LINE	14	
DEFENSIVE LINE	12	
LINEBACKERS	6	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	8	

UCF	RANK
Scoring Offense 24.3 ppg	90
Points per Play 0.37	89
Total Offense 379 ypg	76
Yards per Play 5.8	64
Rushing Offense 158 ypg	67
Yards per Carry 4.9	29
O-Line Run Push 4.1	95
Explosive Rush 6.6	32
Passing Offense 221 ypg	76
Yards / Attempt 6.6	100
QB Rating 121	107
TD / INT Ratio 1.0	128
Sacks / Attempt 5%	37
Explosive Pass 6.1	91
Return. Production 61%	41
Returning Snaps 11,514	42
26.7 SECONDS/PLAY #39 of 68 P4	
FROST (2025 UCF)	

Scott Frost led UCF to an undefeated season in 2017, left to attempt to rebuild his alma mater Nebraska, and then returned here to Orlando last offseason.

2025 had the clear look of a transition season with 70 new players, 19 new starters, and new schemes on both sides of the ball.

After a 3-0 start that featured a 34-9 beatdown of Bill Belichick's UNC team, this started to look more like Frost's Nebraska teams. They were able to move the ball just fine with high yardage totals and frequent explosive plays, but they weren't able to convert into points.

Penalties, turnovers, and red zone failures led to close losses to Kansas by 7, Cincinnati by 9, and Houston by 3... this is textbook "Frost Effect." The 5-7 finish marked their first consecutive seasons without a bowl game since 2003-04.

However, some credit is due for grinding out five wins in a complete transition season. UCF did so with an unsettled quarterback room that was crushed with injuries. Younger players flashed later in the

season and emerged as stars to build around. And Frost's most controversial move, the hiring of beleaguered defensive coordinator Alex Grinch, turned out to be a success so far.

Andrew Cherico of *Knights247* listed out the seven "must-retain" players for UCF to keep in Orlando, away from the transfer portal. To Frost's credit, they retained all seven.

Retention of star players, second-year coach and scheme bonuses, and a total upgrade at quarterback have UCF well-positioned to return to bowl season and join a crowded Big 12 field in 2026.

OFFENSE

The three-man fall camp battle at quarterback ended up extending into the regular season due to a run of injuries. Tayven Jackson played the majority but struggled with the 14th ranked QB Rating in the Big 12 and threw almost as many picks (8) as touchdowns (10). He lacked the mobility to fit Frost's scheme, Jacurri Brown had the athleticism but not the passing, and all three guys ended up transferring out.

UCF found a winner to build the 2026 team around. Alonza Barnett led James Madison to the College Football Playoff last year and is 21-6 overall as a starter. Barnett earned Sun Belt Player of the Year after throwing for 23 touchdowns and 2,806 yards, while adding 589 yards and 15 scores on the ground – the sixth-most among quarterbacks.

Barnett's dual-threat skillset is a perfect match for Frost's offense. On the recruiting trail, UCF signed their highest-rated quarterback commit of all-time in Top300 four-star Rocco Marriott (Platte County, MO). And for the backup role, they signed FIU's three-year starter Keyone Jenkins.

The running back duo of Myles Montgomery and Jaden Nixon was a bright spot last year. Montgomery led with 705 yards as the between-the-tackles workhorse while Nixon had 554 and a penchant for explosive long-runs. With both off to the pros, the staff is attempting to reload the same dynamic from the portal with Landen Chambers (Central Arkansas) and Duke Watson (Louisville). Chambers rushed for 1,273 yards – a Top 10 FCS mark – while Watson led the entire nation with an explosive 8.9 yards/carry back in 2024 before his injuries last year.

DJ Black and Marcus Burke were the original starters but Duane "Speedy" Thomas and freshman Waden Charles emerged as star receivers to build around. Thomas led with 528 yards and was used all over the field – outside, the slot, the backfield, and in the return game. The 6'2 Charles showed off his big catch radius and flashed highlight reel plays later in the season. Ric'Darious Farmer is back from a season-ending injury and the staff signed first-team FCS All-American Josh Derry (Monmouth) who put up 1,101 yards and 13 touchdowns last year.

UCF										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	47	12	10	25	44	11	6	8	3	63	11th
F	COOPER	DARIN HINSHAW	LINDSEY	KINNE	GOLESH	LEBBY	HEUPEL*	TROY WALTERS			
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	GRINCH	ROOF	A. WILLIAMS	TRAVIS WILLIAMS		RANDY SHANNON		ERIK CHINANDER			
E	30	27	40	54	23	53	19	31	31	14	28th
F											

UCF		RANK	
Scoring Defense	23.6 ppg	57	
Points per Play	0.36	53	
Total Defense	336 ypg	37	
Yards per Play	5.1	33	
3rd Down Conv%	37%	49	
Rushing Defense	151 ypg	72	
Yards per Carry	3.9	51	
Negative Play %	9%	53	
Explosive Rush	5.9	46	
Passing Defense	185 ypg	22	
Yards / Attempt	6.6	45	
QB Rating	126	48	
Completion %	63.3%	86	
Explosive Pass	4.8	32	
Return. Production	60%	37	
Returning Snaps	15,431	8	

UCF		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		47
Rushing Offense	0.3	29
Passing Offense	(10.8)	59
Defense Overall		30
Rushing Defense	0.5	30
Passing Defense	4.8	35

UCF retained their star middle backer and tackle leader Lewis Carter who should push for all-league honors again. Cole Kozlowski graduated but the staff signed Old Dominion starter Jahleel Culbreath and former four-star Tackett Curtis (Wisconsin).

Four starters are back in the secondary with safety Phillip Dunnam the lone loss. All-Big 12 Jayden Bellamy emerged as the top corner, Braeden Marshall started at nickel, and both were key retentions for 2026. Demari Henderson was active in run support with 61 tackles, and the staff signed Ty Bartrum (Harvard) fresh off an FCS All-America season last year.

OUTLOOK

Grinch's defense held up well in my opponent-adjusted metric with a #5 Big 12 finish. And there is still room to improve since a main feature of his defenses are takeaways and UCF only had 14 last year (#91 nationally).

UCF is due for a second-year coach bonus with excellent player retention coupled with a proven game-changer at quarterback. Bowl season is likely as they move up to the mid-tier of the Big 12 and draw the bottom three (Kansas, Colorado, Iowa State).

UCF also retained their breakout star tight end Dylan Wade who earned All-Big 12 honorable mention as a coverage mismatch in the pass game. Wade's 43 catches, 523 yards, and five touchdowns were all UCF records.

There is uncertainty in the trenches with four starters gone from a line that struggled. They missed assignments and were heavily penalized, often killing drives and keeping them out of the endzone. UCF ranked #29 in yards/carry and #32 in long-yardage explosive rushing, but did so with minimal help from the offensive line which ranked #95 in my OL Run Push stat. Those rushing totals were a testament to what the running backs achieved in spite of the line.

Preston Cushman is the lone returning starter and the new line will be transfer-heavy. The staff signed four from the portal and all were rated as three-star transfers. Cooper Terpstra (Michigan State) was a Big Ten backup and is projected to start at center. Henry Tabansi (Buffalo) earned other Power 4 offers, and Brady Wayburn (Connecticut) and Tyler Gibson (Charlotte) were starters from the non-AQ level.

DEFENSE

Grinch was considered a controversial pick at defensive coordinator, after struggling at prior stops, but Frost said the two of them both wanted fresh starts and a chance to prove it.

UCF's defense improved in scoring and made major jumps in passing stats. They finished fifth in the Big 12 in my opponent-adjusted defense metric – #5 vs. the pass and #8 vs. the run.

Seven defenders earned All-Big 12 honors, and while they lose their game-changing defensive end pair of Malachi Lawrence and Nyjalik Kelly to the pros, there are still stars returning at each level.

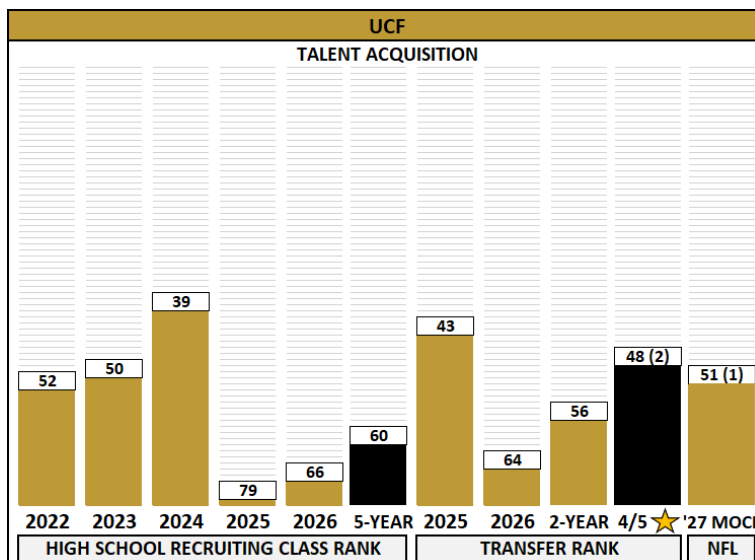
RJ Jackson is back at defensive tackle and is rejoined by original starter Horace Lockett who was playing well before his injury in week four. UCF did an excellent job with player retention this cycle, but the best one to get away was hometown four-star John Walker (Ohio State). The staff signed All-MAC Bruno Dall (Akron) and 2025 Top200 four-star Jessie Harrold (Florida State) to compete

with Sincere Edwards and four-star Isaiah Nixon.

UCF	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	BETH-COOK (FCS)
S. 12	@ Pittsburgh
S. 19	GEORGIA ST
S. 26	TCU
O. 3	@ Houston
O. 10	@ Oklahoma St
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	BYU
O. 30	BAYLOR
N. 7	@ Kansas
N. 14	ARIZONA ST
N. 20	IOWA ST
N. 28	@ Colorado

UCF		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	207	68
All-Time Win %	0.561	38
Wins (Last 100)	207	68
Wins (Last 50)	207	67
Wins (Last 25)	177	35
Wins (Last 10)	80	17
Wins (Last 5)	33	39
Game Grader (10 yr)	55.7	21
Game Grader (5 yr)	49.2	38
Game Grader (3 yr)	48.3	38
Draft Picks s' 2000	41	57
Draft Picks s' 2010	28	51
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		30
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		15

UCF		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
41.9 (52)	49.3 (42)	53.7 (30)	53.4 (31)	47.9 (42)	56.7 (27)	70.3 (12)	68.6 (11)	75.5 (9)	39.7 (51)	55.7 (21)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



WEST VIRGINIA #11(TIE) #51

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

BIG 12 OVERALL



WEST VIRGINIA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13				
12	KANSAS ST	KANSAS ST	OKLAHOMA	(B) Memphis
11	IOWA ST	IOWA ST	OKLA ST	TEXAS TECH
10	TCU	TCU	HOUSTON	BAYLOR
9	TEXAS TECH	TEXAS TECH	Penn State	KANSAS ST
8	TEXAS	TEXAS	(B) UNC	IOWA ST
7	KANSAS	KANSAS	BAYLOR	Pittsburgh
6	Pittsburgh	Pittsburgh	CINCINNATI	Penn State
5	OKLA ST	OKLA ST	BYU	UCF
4	OKLAHOMA	OKLAHOMA	UCF	CINCINNATI
3	BAYLOR	BAYLOR	TCU	ARIZONA
2	Virginia Tech	Virginia Tech	TEXAS TECH	OKLA ST
1	Towson (FCS)	Towson (FCS)	Duquesne (FCS)	KANSAS
	2022	2022	2023	2024
				2025
	NEAL BROWN			RODRIGUEZ

WEST VIRGINIA				
2025 RESULTS				
	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
R Morris (FCS)	W 45-3	502	-2	75.3
OHIO	L 10-17	-179	2	20.8
PITTSBURGH	W 31-24	85	-1	74.7
KANSAS	L 10-41	-65	-2	10.4
UTAH	L 14-48	-186	1	8.0
BYU	L 24-38	-225	1	19.4
UCF	L 13-45	-368	1	3.5
TCU	L 17-23	-1	0	39.7
HOUSTON	W 45-35	3	4	70.5
COLORADO	W 29-22	19	-2	49.7
ARIZONA ST	L 23-25	91	0	58.0
TEXAS TECH	L 0-49	-392	0	0.4
OVERALL: 58th / 68	BIG 12: 14th / 16			35.9

WEST VIRGINIA UNIT RANKS		
BIG 12 RANK (of 16)		NATIONAL TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	14	
RUNNING BACKS	6	
RECEIVERS & TE	12	
OFFENSIVE LINE	9	
DEFENSIVE LINE	11	
LINEBACKERS	16	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	16	

WEST VIRGINIA			RANK
Scoring Offense	21.8 ppg	110	
Points per Play	0.31	118	
Total Offense	350 ypg	96	
Yards per Play	4.9	121	
Rushing Offense	161 ypg	64	
Yards per Carry	3.7	109	
O-Line Run Push	3.8	121	
Explosive Rush	4.5	104	
Passing Offense	189 ypg	103	
Yards / Attempt	6.9	84	
QB Rating	120	113	
TD / INT Ratio	0.9	129	
Sacks / Attempt	9%	120	
Explosive Pass	5.9	99	
Return. Production	57%	55	
Returning Snaps	14,584	17	
21.8 SECONDS/PLAY	#1 of 68 P4		
RODRIGUEZ (2025 WVU)			FAST

Rich Rodriguez left West Virginia in 2007 just days after Backyard Brawl rival Pittsburgh ruined their shot at a BCS national title appearance.

18 years later Rodriguez returned and was able to avenge that loss with a comeback win over Pitt. Nicco Marchiol came off the bench and sparked the 10-point comeback in the final five minutes to force overtime. Then Tye Edwards cashed in the game-winning score to push West Virginia to 2-1 entering Big 12 play.

The season highlights end there. As Rodriguez said after the 41-10 loss to Kansas the following week: "nothing was good, coaching? not good, playing? not good."

It was already set up to be a typical transition season with 70 new players and a scheme change to Rodriguez's rushing attack. But the transition season was made worse by a run of injuries in September at the offensive skill positions. Before the end of the month they were already down preseason All-Big 12 running back Jahiem White, his

backup Edwards, Marchiol, top receiver Jaden Bray, and then the offensive line got hit a few games later.

West Virginia trudged through a 4-8 season with six losses by double-digits. They closed with a 49-0 beat down from eventual Big 12 champs Texas Tech, but even worse was the 45-13 loss to UCF, a fellow coaching transition program.

Normally I would be writing about all the returning starters and stat gains that are expected from a second-year coach bonus. But this has the look of another full transition season. The senior-heavy 2025 roster graduated, West Virginia added 83 new players – 49 recruits and 34 transfers – and they will have as many as 19 new starters.

OFFENSE

Rodriguez cycled through five different quarterbacks and eventually found a spark from true freshman Scotty Fox. In his second start, West Virginia almost knocked off TCU (23-17) with a 301-yard passing day from Fox who even drew compliments from the opposing head coach Sonny Dykes. Fox led two Big 12 wins, a 45-35 shootout over #22 Houston and a 29-22 win over Colorado, and he shouldered 27 carries for 123 rushing yards and two scores in the wins.

All other quarterbacks transferred out, so it will be Fox battling incoming transfer Michael Hawkins (Oklahoma) who also brings the dual-threat skillset needed for this scheme. Hawkins started a few games for Oklahoma back in 2024 as a true freshman but he struggled in a tough spot.

The top four running backs are gone, and the staff signed the nation's rushing champ Cam Cook (Jacksonville State). Cook ran for 1,659 yards and 16 touchdowns with a high 5.6 per-carry average and will be the workhorse here in 2026. Four-star signee Amari Latimer will be the second back as a true freshman.

The top three receivers are gone – Cam Vaughn, Jeff Weimer, and Rodney Gallagher – though that doesn't account for their original top target Jaden Bray who returns after the early season-ending injury. Bray is their clear #1 receiver to build around, and a trio of transfers fill out the new rotation. TaRon Francis (LSU) was a Top200 recruit in the 2025 class, Prince Strachan (USC) had success at Boise State but was stuck behind All-Big Ten stars and the Biletnikoff winner at USC, and DJ Epps (Troy) will start in the slot.

Rodriguez mentioned using more 12 personnel this year but their top two tight ends graduated. Ryan Ward got plenty of snaps last year and assumes the starting role, while 6'7 Cam Ball (Mississippi State) and Josh Sapp (Clemson) were Power 4 backups last year.

The offensive line was hit with injuries and the unit never gelled together. Last year West Virginia placed in the bottom 15 nationally in both my OL Run Push (#121) and Pass Protection (#120) by allowing a sack on 9% of pass attempts. Two starters return in center Landen Livingston and

WEST VIRGINIA OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	64	52	30	47	56	49	64	7	22
F	RODRIGUEZ	CHAD SCOTT	HARRELL	GERAD PARKER	MOORE	JAKE SPAVITAL	WICKLINE		52nd
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017
D	ALLEY	JORDAN LESLEY	KOENNING	TONY GIBSON					
E	48	64	49	62	39	7	34	38	57
F									27
									47th

WEST VIRGINIA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	30.8 ppg	114	
Points per Play	0.43	97	
Total Defense	409 ypg	106	
Yards per Play	5.7	82	
3rd Down Conv%	38%	61	
Rushing Defense	144 ypg	61	
Yards per Carry	3.6	29	
Negative Play %	9%	39	
Explosive Rush	5.9	45	
Passing Defense	265 ypg	129	
Yards / Attempt	8.2	123	
QB Rating	152	124	
Completion %	64.9%	109	
Explosive Pass	7.7	124	
Return. Production	46%	86	
Returning Snaps	10,036	61	

WEST VIRGINIA		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		64	
Rushing Offense	(0.8)	63	
Passing Offense	(10.9)	60	
Defense Overall		48	
Rushing Defense	0.9	20	
Passing Defense	(20.2)	66	

Every safety on the roster departed along with their top three cornerbacks after a rough 2025 statistical performance. Nickelback Fred Perry led the team in tackles and he also left.

Another position, another transfer reload and the new secondary will feature two non-AQ starters at the safety spots -- Kamari Wilson (Memphis) and Andrew Powdrell (UNLV) -- and two backup corners moving up to the starting lineup in Nick Taylor and Keyshawn Robinson. At nickel, the staff signed Wisconsin's starter Geimere Latimer, and they found a wildcard in Top100 recruit Matt Sieg who can play safety and may even be used as an offensive weapon.

OUTLOOK

This is not the usual "second-year coach bonus" in fact with 85 new players this is basically a second transition season. Rodriguez upgraded the roster with the nation's rushing champ, improved lines of scrimmage, and a Top 25 high school signing class to build the foundation for future seasons.

West Virginia will move up a few spots on the Big 12 ladder but next year 2027 looks like a better shot for a program revival season.

WEST VIRGINIA		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	793	16	
All-Time Win %	0.592	24	
Wins (Last 100)	624	24	
Wins (Last 50)	356	26	
Wins (Last 25)	190	26	
Wins (Last 10)	66	38	
Wins (Last 5)	30	50	
Game Grader (10 yr)	48.4	40	
Game Grader (5 yr)	42.8	56	
Game Grader (3 yr)	43.4	56	
Draft Picks s' 2000	53	47	
Draft Picks s' 2010	36	43	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		67	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		48	

honorable mention All-Big 12 Nick Krahe. Rodriguez hired back a coaching legend in Rick Trickett, who enters his 53rd season as an offensive line coach. Together these two led top-ranked rushing attacks at West Virginia (2001-2006) and more recently at Jacksonville State. His final three JSU rushing offenses all ranked in the national top five.

West Virginia added Devin Vass who started the final seven games for Kansas State last year, Amare Grayson (Jacksonville State) who earned first-team All-CUSA, and signed Top100 Kevin Brown who looks like an instant starter at right tackle. They also retained their top two backups Malik Agbo and Josh Aisosa to add experienced depth and potentially win starting spots.

DEFENSE

There is even more change on this side of the ball as West Virginia will feature a completely new starting lineup -- 11 new starters.

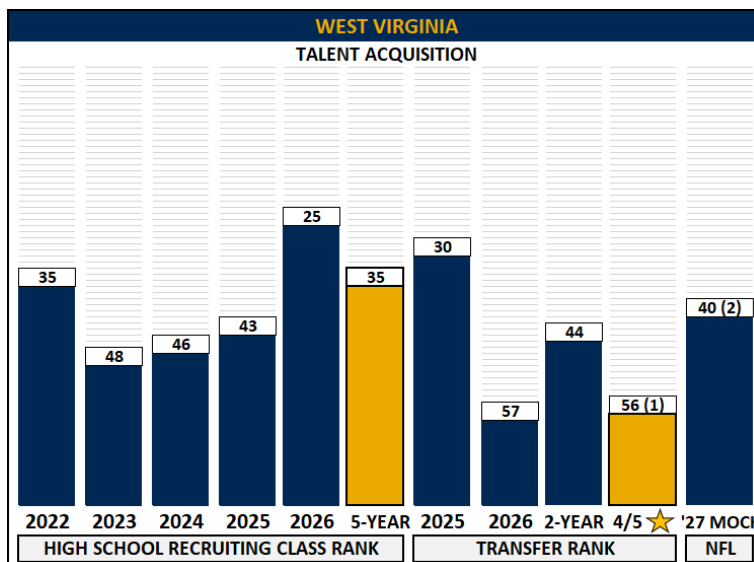
Change may be welcomed after allowing 31 points per game (#114) with a pass defense ranked in the bottom ten of most stat categories including third-worst -- #66 of 68 Power 4 -- in my opponent-adjusted passing stat.

The star of the defense, All-Big 12 lineman Edward Vesterinen, graduated and West Virginia lost their top six in the trenches. Nate Gabriel got 300 snaps and is the new projected nose tackle, and from there it's a mix of transfers. Tackle KJ Henson was a JUCO All-American last year, ends Zeke Campbell (Coastal Carolina) and Harper Holloman (Western Kentucky) both earned all-league honors at the non-AQ level, and Tobi Haastrup (Oregon) was a Top250 recruit in the 2025 cycle. This is an upgraded room from 2025 despite the loss of Vesterinen.

The two starting backers and two more potential rising stars are all gone. Ben Cutter rises to a starting spot, and FAU starter Tyler Stolsky will battle Illinois backup Malachi Hood for the other spot.

WEST VIRGINIA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	C. CAROLINA
S. 12	UT-MARTIN (FCS)
S. 19	*VIRGINIA (CLT)
S. 26	OKLAHOMA ST
O. 3	@ Iowa State
O. 10	ARIZONA
O. 17	CINCINNATI
O. 24	@ TCU
O. 31	--- BYE ---
N. 7	@ Texas Tech
N. 14	KANSAS
N. 21	HOUSTON
N. 27	@ Utah

WEST VIRGINIA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
35.9 (58)	39.9 (54)	54.6 (29)	37.8 (54)	45.9 (44)	58.7 (23)	34.5 (58)	68.6 (10)	48.1 (40)	60.1 (18)	48.4 (40)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



BAYLOR

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#11(TIE) #52

BIG 12 OVERALL



BAYLOR				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14	TCU	(B) Air Force	WVU	(B) LSU
13	OKLA ST	TEXAS	TCU	IOWA ST
12	(B) Ole Miss	TCU	KANSAS ST	BYU
11	(CG) OKLA ST	KANSAS ST	HOUSTON	COLORADO
10	TEXAS TECH	WVU	IOWA ST	Utah *
9	KANSAS ST	OKLA ST	TEXAS TECH	KANSAS
8	OKLAHOMA	BYU	TEXAS	HOUSTON
7	TEXAS	OKLAHOMA	Utah	TCU
6	BYU	TEXAS TECH	Texas State	WVU
5	WVU	KANSAS	CINCINNATI	OKLA ST
4	IOWA ST	IOWA ST	UCF	TEXAS TECH
3	KANSAS	Texas St	Long Isl. (FCS)	Air Force
2	TX So. (FCS)	Albany (FCS)		Tarleton (FCS)
1	Texas St			
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				
DAVE ARANDA				

BAYLOR				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
AUBURN L 24-38	68	0	40.2	
SMU W 48-45	143	-1	77.8	
Samford (FCS) W 42-7	273	2	74.0	
ARIZONA ST L 24-27	-43	-3	37.8	
OKLAHOMA ST W 45-27	164	-1	65.7	
KANSAS ST W 35-34	-63	-1	42.8	
TCU L 36-42	12	-3	39.7	
CINCINNATI L 20-41	-110	-2	13.1	
UCF W 30-3	192	1	82.7	
UTAH L 28-55	80	-2	31.4	
ARIZONA L 17-41	-12	-2	21.5	
HOUSTON L 24-31	4	-1	35.5	
OVERALL: 43rd / 68 BIG 12: 10th / 16 46.9				

BAYLOR	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 16)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	10	
RUNNING BACKS	10	
RECEIVERS & TE	14	
OFFENSIVE LINE	12	
DEFENSIVE LINE	9	
LINEBACKERS	8	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	9	

BAYLOR	RANK	
Scoring Offense	31.1 ppg	33
Points per Play	0.4	68
Total Offense	451 ypg	18
Yards per Play	5.9	47
Rushing Offense	142 ypg	83
Yards per Carry	4.1	85
O-Line Run Push	4.2	62
Explosive Rush	4.1	114
Passing Offense	310 ypg	4
Yards / Attempt	7.3	64
QB Rating	137	63
TD / INT Ratio	2.6	48
Sacks / Attempt	4%	24
Explosive Pass	6.5	76
Return. Production	44%	102
Returning Snaps	14,523	18
22.3 SECONDS/PLAY	#2 of 68 P4	
SPAVITAL (2025 BAYLOR)	FAST	

Baylor closed the 2024 season on a six-game Big 12 win streak, placed in the Top 25 of Game Grader, and carried that momentum forward into 2025 with a Top 10 mark in returning production. 18 starters were back and both coordinators returned.

The fundamentals clearly pointed up. This was the year to cash in with a veteran roster and return to the Big 12 title game for the first time since 2021.

It turns out that the pass game was the only thing that was as-advertised. The defensive flaws were apparent right away, as Auburn rushed for 300+ yards in the opening loss. Arizona State won a coinflip game in the Big 12 opener, but still Baylor got to 4-2 with a pair of miracle comeback wins.

Sawyer Robertson threw for 440 yards to outlast SMU 48-45 and was the first Big 12 quarterback since Patrick Mahomes to post three straight 400+ yard games. Robertson led another comeback against Kansas State with help from Jacob Redding's Pick Six and Cooper Lanz's blocked field goal as time expired.

Baylor was 4-2 with all goals still on the table but then crashed, losing five of the final six. The defense allowed nearly 200 rushing yards/game

(bottom ten nationally) and the high-powered passing attack couldn't keep playing from behind.

The 5-7 season brought Dave Aranda's record back below .500 at 36-37 and perhaps the timing of a November athletic director change saved his job. Thanks to extra bowl openings, Baylor actually earned a bowl invitation but rather than use the 15 bonus practices as a chance to shift the momentum back in the positive direction, Aranda shockingly rejected the bid.

2026 is certainly a make-or-break season, and their veteran roster now flips to a new-look, transfer-heavy starting lineup.

OFFENSE

Offensive coordinator Jake Spavital put it simply: "we're a brand-new team."

That is not an overstatement, at least offensively, as 10 starters are gone from their pass-heavy attack that finished #20 in my opponent-adjusted rankings.

Robertson graduated after a high-volume final season. He threw for 3,681 yards and 31 touchdowns – both top five national marks – and his 14-game streak of multiple touchdown passes was the longest in the Big 12 since Baker Mayfield.

Baylor went all-in on their new quarterback and he instantly became the new face of the program. DJ Lagway was the #1 ranked quarterback of the 2024 recruiting cycle, and the five-star started 16 games for Florida. Lagway's father was a running back here at Baylor, and he was drawn to Spavital's scheme which he notes "reminds me of my high school offense."

That should be music to Baylor fans' ears – Lagway compiled 5,500+ yards of offense and 75 touchdowns as a senior in that offense for nearby Willis. At 6'5, 240 pounds, Lagway adds a quarterback-run dynamic and can be a bowling ball in short-yardage spots. He ranked second in the SEC in QB Rating in 2024, but fell to second-worst last season.

All four receivers are gone – first-team All-Big 12 Josh Cameron, Ashtyn Hawkins, Kobe Prentice, and Kole Wilson – plus the pass-game mismatch and human highlight reel Michael Trigg at tight end. It's a full rebuild here, but the staff pulled in other Power 4 starters Dre'Lon Miller (Colorado) and Gavin Freeman (Oklahoma State). Miller is the most dynamic addition after earning starts as a freshman in 2024 and then moving to running back in 2025. Jadon Porter and Louis Brown are the only returners but they only combined for 15 catches last year. Former four-star tight end Tony Livingston (Florida) followed Lagway to Waco, and blocker Matthew Klopfenstein is back.

It's another complete rebuild in the trenches as four of the starting five are gone. All-Big 12 Omar Aigbedion graduated, and two more starters landed at SEC programs: center Coleton Price (Kentucky) and Sean Thompkins (LSU). Right tackle Kaden Sieracki is the only full returning starter, though his brother Koltin started a few at right guard. The other three spots are up for grabs and three incoming transfers are projected to win the jobs with Yakiri Walker (Memphis) at center, Nate Kibble (Texas) at left guard, and Logan Moore (UAB) at left tackle. The starting five were all three-star recruits or transfers.

BAYLOR					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	20	22	51	42	36	64	23	45	53	37				
F	JAKE SPAVITAL	JEFF GRIMES	FEDORA	GLENN THOMAS / JEFF NIXON	BRILES									47th
F	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	MATT POWLEDGE	RON ROBERTS	PHIL SNOW	BENNETT										
E	47	54	67	28	13	31	7	65	64	30				42nd
F														

BAYLOR		RANK
Scoring Defense	32.6 ppg	122
Points per Play	0.47	119
Total Defense	392 ypg	88
Yards per Play	5.7	85
3rd Down Conv%	41%	96
Rushing Defense	197 ypg	122
Yards per Carry	4.9	118
Negative Play %	6%	129
Explosive Rush	6.6	73
Passing Defense	195 ypg	31
Yards / Attempt	6.8	53
QB Rating	130	58
Completion %	62.2%	73
Explosive Pass	4.7	24
Return. Production	62%	22
Returning Snaps	13,270	23

BAYLOR		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		20
Rushing Offense	0.1	37
Passing Offense	11.9	29
Defense Overall		47
Rushing Defense	(0.3)	59
Passing Defense	(1.8)	49

Keaton Thomas was the leader of the defense but he transferred to Ole Miss. Baylor does get back original starter Travion Barnes, the former C-USA Player of the Year, as well as starter Kyland Reed and rising four-star Kaleb Burns.

Two starters return to the secondary and both had All-Big 12 honors: safety Jacob Redding and corner LeVar Thornton. Devin Turner was a former All-Big Ten star at Northwestern and he is back healthy to start at safety – Klanderman calls him a “difference-maker.” The other corner spot is a battle between Reggie Bush, Devon Jordan (Oklahoma), and wildcard JUCO All-America Stilton McKelvey. Klanderman also brought two Kansas State defenders with him: Jayden Rowe and Colby McCalister.

OUTLOOK

Aranda upgraded his defense, hired a proven coordinator Joe Klanderman, and shifted more of the roster budget over to the defense. The other side is a complete rebuild as they lose 10 starters from their elite passing offense.

Baylor is basically .500 (36-37) during the Aranda era, and this year will be similar. Baylor remains in the mid-tier of the Big 12.

BAYLOR		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	643	50
All-Time Win %	0.513	53
Wins (Last 100)	531	51
Wins (Last 50)	291	50
Wins (Last 25)	151	50
Wins (Last 10)	62	45
Wins (Last 5)	34	38
Game Grader (10 yr)	48.9	36
Game Grader (5 yr)	51.5	32
Game Grader (3 yr)	44.9	48
Draft Picks s' 2000	48	52
Draft Picks s' 2010	41	34
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		64
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		38

The run game was supposed to feature a top duo of Dawson Pendergrass and Bryson Washington, but before the season Pendergrass was knocked out with an injury. Washington hit a fumble problem, and the yards/carry fell from Top 40 to below average. Washington transferred out to Auburn, but Pendergrass returned healthy as the lead back for 2026. Caden Knighten is also back after 104 carries and 469 yards as a true freshman.

While the run/pass split will certainly balance out from last year's heavy-pass selection, Spavital will still feature his choice routes in the pass game and operate with fast tempo, which he calls “our biggest weapon.”

DEFENSE

Defense is Aranda's area of expertise but so far Baylor has landed just one Top 25 defense in six years per my opponent-adjusted rankings. The last three under coordinator Matt Powledge had a bottom ten average rank. The pass rush was historically ineffective last year, and their 13 sacks were the fewest by a Big 12 defense in a decade.

Aranda made a coordinator change here with Kansas State's Joe Klanderman and also made the decision to give up play-calling duties and return to a CEO-type role. Klanderman has a track record of effective defenses and his focus on creating havoc directly addresses the pass rush problem. His scheme is aggressive, attacking, and ranked in the Top 25 of turnovers in three of the past four seasons.

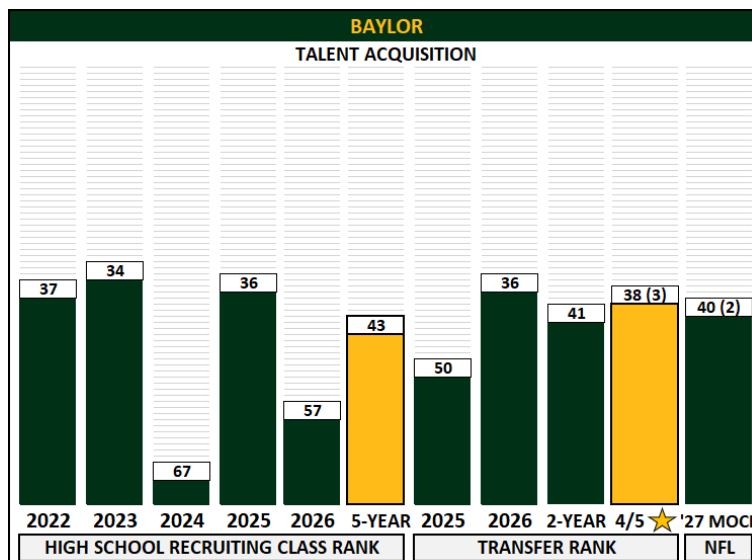
This year Aranda shifted their roster budget to this side of the ball: “this is the most money we've spent on defense since I've been here.”

Four starters return, but they also get back two more original starters from injury, two starters off other Power 4 teams, and two JUCO All-Americans.

Devonte Tezino is back at defensive tackle and is joined by national champion and four-star transfer Hosea Wheeler (Indiana) who is appealing for a bonus eligibility season. Jamaal Whyce (Marshall) and Jordan Mack (Coastal Carolina) add depth to the interior, while end Zavion Hardy (South Carolina) was the overall #1 JUCO prospect of 2025. Kyler Jordan returns at end after starting the final two games.

BAYLOR	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	*AUBURN (ATL)
S. 12	P. VIEW A&M (FCS)
S. 19	LA TECH
S. 26	COLORADO
O. 3	@ Arizona State
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	TCU
O. 24	@ Kansas
O. 30	@ UCF
N. 7	IOWA STATE
N. 14	@ BYU
N. 21	TEXAS TECH
N. 28	@ Houston

BAYLOR		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
46.9 (43)	59 (25)	28.8 (64)	53 (32)	69.9 (7)	39.9 (53)	65.5 (16)	45.8 (47)	27.5 (64)	52.9 (30)	48.9 (36)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



CINCINNATI

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#13

BIG 12

#60

OVERALL



CINCINNATI 5-YEAR WIN TREND

14	(P) Alabama				
13	(CG) Houston	(B) Louisville			
12	ECU	TULANE	KANSAS	TCU	TCU
11	SMU	UCF	WVU	KANSAS ST	BYU
10	USF	Arkansas	UCF	IOWA STATE	ARIZONA
9	TULSA	TEMPLE	OKLA STATE	WVU	UTAH
8	TULANE	ECU	BAYLOR	COLORADO	Nebraska
7	NAVY	NAVY	IOWA STATE	TEXAS TECH	BAYLOR
6	UCF	SMU	BYU	Pittsburgh	OKLA. ST
5	TEMPLE	USF	OKLAHOMA	ARIZONA ST	UCF
4	Notre Dame	TULSA	Miami (OH)	UCF	IOWA ST
3	Indiana	Indiana	HOUSTON	HOUSTON	KANSAS
2	Murray St (FCS)	Miami (OH)	Pittsburgh	Miami (OH)	NW St (FCS)
1	Miami (OH)	Kenn. St (FCS)	EKU (FCS)	Towson (FCS)	Bowling Green
2021		2022	2023	2024	2025
LUKE FICKELL		SCOTT SATTERFIELD			

CINCINNATI					
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
NEBRASKA	L	17-20	-82	-2	32.3
BOWLING GREEN	W	34-20	67	-1	54.1
NW St (FCS)	W	70-0	503	1	77.8
KANSAS	W	37-34	6	1	48.2
IOWA ST	W	38-30	4	-1	67.1
UCF	W	20-11	-107	1	47.6
OKLAHOMA ST	W	49-17	50	2	70.6
BAYLOR	W	41-20	110	2	76.3
UTAH	L	14-45	-53	-1	16.4
ARIZONA	L	24-30	-131	-2	27.7
BYU	L	14-26	-5	-2	34.9
TCU	L	23-45	-147	-1	14.1
(B) NAVY	L	13-35	-110	-1	13.8
OVERALL: 47th / 68 BIG 12: 11th / 16 44.7					

CINCINNATI UNIT RANKS		
BIG 12 RANK (of 16)		NATIONAL TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	15	
RUNNING BACKS	16	
RECEIVERS & TE	11	
OFFENSIVE LINE	2	11
DEFENSIVE LINE	16	
LINEBACKERS	14	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	14	

CINCINNATI			RANK
Scoring Offense	30.3 ppg	43	
Points per Play	0.51	18	
Total Offense	407 ypg	43	
Yards per Play	6.9	8	
Rushing Offense	176 ypg	46	
Yards per Carry	5.7	5	
O-Line Run Push	5.0	3	
Explosive Rush	7.5	11	
Passing Offense	231 ypg	62	
Yards / Attempt	8.2	29	
QB Rating	155	16	
TD / INT Ratio	5.0	8	
Sacks / Attempt	2%	2	
Explosive Pass	8.8	18	
Return. Production	57%	57	
Returning Snaps	8,399	79	
24.4 SECONDS/PLAY #12 of 68 P4			
SATTERFIELD (2025 CINCI) FAST			

In 2024 Cincinnati had five tries to clinch bowl eligibility but went 0-5 to close out a losing season.

Again in 2025 they started fast, riding their dual-threat quarterback and powerful offensive line to wins over Kansas, UCF, and a ranked Iowa State. This time, Scott Satterfield's squad finished the job and clinched their ticket to bowl season and the locker room celebrated accordingly.

Cincinnati got to 7-1 with their longest win streak since their 2021 Playoff run and even cracked the AP Top 20.

But once the calendar flipped to November, it was a similar finish to their 2024 skid. Brendan Sorsby was held to just a 33% completion rate and the defense could not slow down Utah in the 45-14 loss. Then the turnovers continued in a close 30-24 loss to Arizona. Kicker Stephen Rusnak was perfect most of the year but missed three field goals in a 12-point loss to BYU.

Then the wheels fell off. TCU scored at-will in the 45-23 rout, and in the rain-soaked bowl game, Navy's option attack dominated 35-13. Another

year, another five-game skid to close the season.

The offseason hit hard right away with Sorsby breaking his contract and transferring out to Texas Tech as the top-rated transfer of the entire cycle. Cincinnati sued him, and was embroiled in another off-field controversy and lost his college eligibility.

Sorsby is the headline departure, but in total Cincinnati loses 17 starters – eight from the offense, and nine from the defense -- and Satterfield is going with a double coordinator change to top it off.

Cincinnati has done well with scouting and turning non-AQ and FCS transfers into All-Big 12 stars and NFL draft picks. Their "Moneyball" approach will be put to the test again this cycle.

OFFENSE

Cincinnati signed a pair of starting quarterbacks from the lower levels in JC French (Georgia Southern) and Liam O'Brien (Penn). French emerged as the leader after compiling 5,760 passing yards, 37 passing touchdowns, and another 554 rushing yards over the past two seasons. His dual-threat skillset fits the usual Satterfield offensive scheme, but French will need to improve on his passing efficiency after placing sixth in the Sun Belt in QB Rating last year, and ninth in 2024.

French says he was drawn to Cincinnati because of their heavy RPO and play-action usage. That scheme should remain the same even with the coordinator change as Satterfield hired from within and will retain the playcalling role himself like usual.

Tawee Walker and Evan Pryor combined for 1,231 yards with Walker earning All-Big 12 honors. Walker graduated, Pryor transferred out to Florida, and they have a new cast of backs for 2026. Zion Johnson got the bowl game start, surged in spring ball as the most explosive of the bunch, and Satterfield called him the starter. Three transfers will battle for carries: All-Sun Belt Zylan Perry (Louisiana), and Power 4 backups Gi'Bran Payne (Notre Dame) and Cole Tabb (Stanford).

The receiver room is another complete rebuild after the top three all departed. Cyrus Allen was second-team All-Big 12 after placing third nationally with 13 touchdown catches, Caleb Goodie transferred out to Missouri, and Jeff Caldwell posted one of the best NFL Combine performances of all-time.

JV Gibson (Oklahoma) emerged as the new #1 receiver in spring. Gibson was limited with injuries last year at Oklahoma but his breakout year was in 2024 with 70 catches at the FCS level. Cade Wolford (Kent State) averaged an insane 27 yards/catch last year to earn All-MAC honors and the staff may get him carries in the run game. Lorenzo Fenner (South Dakota) had 15 touchdowns in the FCS, Malachi Henry (Central Arkansas) had 10, and DII Flynn Schiele (Colorado School of Mines) earned a four-star transfer grade.

CINCINNATI OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)											
O	11	31	48	51	6	10	48	52	59	51	37th
F	BRAD GLENN			GUIDUGLI			MIKE DENBROCK			ZAC TAYLOR	
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	TYSON VEIDT			BROWN			MIKE TRESSSEL			MARCUS FREEMAN	
E	54	49	68	7	6	2	16	14	62	36	23rd
F											

CINCINNATI		RANK	
Scoring Defense	25.6 ppg	74	
Points per Play	0.36	57	
Total Defense	399 ypg	93	
Yards per Play	5.6	72	
3rd Down Conv%	41%	92	
Rushing Defense	179 ypg	107	
Yards per Carry	4.3	81	
Negative Play %	6%	123	
Explosive Rush	5.7	41	
Passing Defense	221 ypg	69	
Yards / Attempt	7.4	88	
QB Rating	145	111	
Completion %	66.8%	125	
Explosive Pass	6.0	80	
Return. Production	56%	50	
Returning Snaps	12,091	36	

CINCINNATI		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		11
Rushing Offense	1.1	10
Passing Offense	14.5	25
Defense Overall		54
Rushing Defense	0.1	49
Passing Defense	(16.5)	64

Isaiah Johnson was in the rotation last year and should move up to the starting lineup with Gibson and one of the other newcomers. Transfers from the FCS or DII may seem to be roulette chips, but Cincinnati has an excellent track record recently.

Joe Royer continued Cincinnati's tight end legacy – the All-Big 12 end was drafted in the fifth round. Gavin Grover is next in line after getting 250 snaps as a true freshman and he was one yard shy of a touchdown against Kansas.

Finally some returning starters. In December, the trio of star offensive linemen made a joint announcement that they would remain at Cincinnati. They do lose Gavin Gerhardt, but the trio of left tackle Joe Cotton, left guard Evan Tengesdahl, and guard/center Taran Tyo make this one of the strongest Big 12 lines yet again. Last year they ranked #2 nationally in Sack Rate, #3 in my OL Run Push, #5 in yards/carry, and were named a Joe Moore Award semifinalist. Entering fall camp, Nolan Latulippe and Xavier Lozowicki are projected to fill in the two open spots on the starting five.

DEFENSE

The offense held up their end of the bargain, ranking #11 in my opponent-adjusted offensive rankings. Tyson Veidt's defense struggled – #54 of 68 Power 4 – with the pass defense placing in the bottom five.

Satterfield opened up the rolodex and reconnected with Nate Woody, his defensive coordinator from back at Appalachian State. He specifically cited the 2025 unit's lack of disruption – pressure, sacks, and interceptions – and Woody's aggressive scheme is the perfect solution. Last year their 3-3-5 base ranked #123 in my Negative Play rate, often due to dropping eight into coverage. Woody is shifting Cincinnati back to a 3-4 but said they'll always bring a fourth in pass rush.

Woody's 2024 defense at Army ranked #1 nationally in total defense and helped lead their 12-win season. Here at Cincinnati he is inheriting a new-look roster with nine starters gone.

All-Big 12 linemen Dontay Corleone and Jalen Hunt graduated and starter Mikah Coleman went to Miami Ohio. Marquaze Parker emerged in spring ball as the top pass rusher, and Thomas Johnson (NC Central) had 12 sacks and 18 tackles-for-loss last year at the FCS level.

Tackle-machine Jake Golday was drafted in the second round but Cincinnati gets back a third-year starter in Jonathan Thompson. He has been consistent and should push for all-league honors in the new scheme. Simeon Coleman and Brian Simms move into starting roles with incoming Filip Maciorowski (Northern Illinois) who had 97 tackles last year.

The lone starter back in the secondary is a big one in All-Big 12 Antwan Peek. The do-it-all hybrid was named a Jim Thorpe semifinalist and fits into the nickel corner role here. Satterfield said he wanted more disruption, and Peek will lead the way. The staff signed another round of defensive backs from the portal and as many as four could start. MJ Cannon (Bowling Green) earned All-MAC honors and was a spring standout along with safety Ty Goodwill (South Alabama).

OUTLOOK

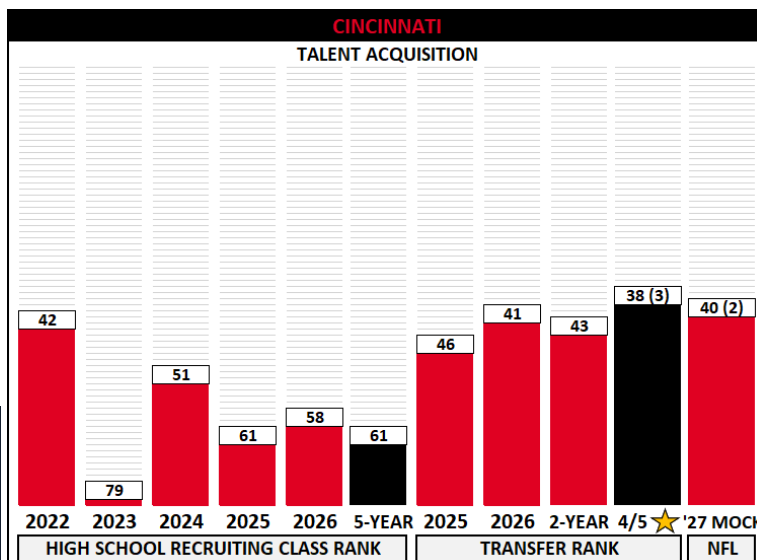
Cincinnati finished #11 in the Big 12 in my Game Grader last season, and now 17 starters are gone – including their dynamic star quarterback – but the next wave of starters are mostly from the lower tiers (non-AQ, FCS, DII). Cincinnati is also second-worst in five-year recruiting so their talent level keeps them out of title contention.

They draw the bottom two teams – Colorado and Iowa State – but also six of the top eight. Bowl eligibility may come down to their mid-October road trip to West Virginia, a Big East style swing game.

CINCINNATI	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	BOSTON COLL.
S. 12	W. CAROLINA (FCS)
S. 19	*MIAMI OH (CIN)
S. 26	KANSAS STATE
O. 3	@ Arizona
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	@ WVU
O. 24	TEXAS TECH
O. 31	UTAH
N. 7	@ Houston
N. 14	@ Iowa State
N. 21	COLORADO
N. 28	@ BYU

CINCINNATI		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	667	42
All-Time Win %	0.518	49
Wins (Last 100)	549	44
Wins (Last 50)	304	45
Wins (Last 25)	196	23
Wins (Last 10)	76	24
Wins (Last 5)	37	32
Game Grader (10 yr)	48.9	37
Game Grader (5 yr)	49.9	36
Game Grader (3 yr)	42.8	57
Draft Picks s' 2000	55	44
Draft Picks s' 2010	37	41
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		22
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		13

CINCINNATI		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
44.7 (47)	48.9 (43)	35 (56)	49.9 (36)	71 (6)	70.8 (9)	54.3 (25)	60.2 (21)	24.5 (65)	29.8 (62)	48.9 (37)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



KANSAS

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#14 #61

BIG 12 OVERALL



KANSAS				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13		(B) Arkansas	KANSAS ST	
12	WVU	KANSAS ST	TEXAS TECH	BAYLOR
11	TCU	TEXAS	OKLA ST	KANSAS ST
10	KANSAS ST	TEXAS TECH	TEXAS	ARIZONA ST
9	OKLA ST	BAYLOR	(B) UNLV	UTAH
8	OKLAHOMA	OKLAHOMA	CINCINNATI	ARIZONA
7	TEXAS TECH	TCU	IOWA ST	KANSAS ST
6	IOWA ST	OKLA ST	OKLAHOMA	TEXAS TECH
5	Duke	IOWA ST	UCF	CINCINNATI
4	BAYLOR	Duke	BYU	Missouri
3	Coastal Car.	Houston	Nevada	OKLA ST
2	TEXAS	WVU	Illinois	UCF
1	S. Dakota (FCS)	TN Tech (FCS)	MO St (FCS)	W. VIRGINIA
LANCE LEIPOLD				
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				

KANSAS				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
FRESNO ST W 31-7	167	3	80.7	
Wagner (FCS) W 46-7	488	-2	74.8	
MISSOURI L 31-42	-341	0	19.2	
W. VIRGINIA W 41-10	65	2	77.0	
CINCINNATI L 34-37	-6	-1	36.5	
UCF W 27-20	-19	1	52.3	
TEXAS TECH L 17-42	-186	0	11.4	
KANSAS ST L 17-42	-124	-3	10.9	
OKLAHOMA ST W 38-21	26	0	57.7	
ARIZONA L 20-24	46	0	51.0	
IOWA ST L 14-38	-139	-1	12.2	
UTAH L 21-31	63	-2	46.4	
OVERALL: 49th / 68 BIG 12: 12th / 16 44.2				

KANSAS		UNIT RANKS
BIG 12 RANK		NATIONAL
(of 16)		TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	16	
RUNNING BACKS	14	
RECEIVERS & TE	15	
OFFENSIVE LINE	13	
DEFENSIVE LINE	13	
LINEBACKERS	9	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	11	

KANSAS		RANK
Scoring Offense	28.1 ppg	69
Points per Play	0.43	43
Total Offense	391 ypg	67
Yards per Play	6.1	37
Rushing Offense	168 ypg	56
Yards per Carry	4.7	39
O-Line Run Push	4.8	11
Explosive Rush	5.4	63
Passing Offense	222 ypg	72
Yards / Attempt	7.7	47
QB Rating	143	45
TD / INT Ratio	2.9	34
Sacks / Attempt	6%	47
Explosive Pass	8.1	32
Return. Production	49%	79
Returning Snaps	11,412	45
28.1 SECONDS/PLAY #56 of 68 P4		
LEIPOLD (2025 KANSAS) SLOW		

Leipold views the past two years with mixed emotions, noting that “in a very short time, making a bowl has now become the expectation” which is a far cry from when they were the dead last in Power 4 as the punching bag of the 2010s decade.

The Utah loss was an unfortunate way for sixth-year quarterback Jalon Daniels to end his career. Daniels threw three picks including the decisive Pick Six, but should be remembered as a program legend. Through all the injuries, the Daniels Era gave the program memorable moments, led the highs of the Leipold rebuild, brought *ESPN's College Gameday* to Lawrence for the first time, and even debuted their state-of-the-art \$450 million stadium.

OFFENSE

Daniels departs, but Kansas brought back a familiar face in offensive coordinator Andy Kotelnicki. He led consecutive Top 10 offenses here in 2022 and 2023 per my opponent-adjusted rankings. His offenses consistently ranked high in explosiveness, yards/play, pass protection, and third-down conversions.

In 2024 he took the Penn State coordinator job and boosted their explosiveness, Tyler Warren won the Mackey Award, and the running back pair rewrote the school record book.

It may appear to be the first quarterback battle since 2020, but Kotelnicki is quick to note the staff led position battles here over the Daniels era and are experienced for this 2026 battle. Cole Ballard is a former walk-on who rose up the depth chart and was the backup for Daniels last year. Isaiah Marshall is another contender, and the staff got him game experience with a quarterback-run package last year. They signed Rice's starting quarterback Chase Jenkins, who rushed for 531 yards (13 carries/game) but placed 12th in AAC QB Rating. Ballard has the slight edge but it will be a fall camp battle.

Leshon Williams and Daniel Hishaw each rushed for 500+ yards but both are gone. The staff signed three veteran transfers and it will be a committee approach here. Yasin Willis was Syracuse's lead rusher last year with 558 yards, Jalen Dupree led Colorado State with 508, but the real wildcard is the electric former Top200 prospect Dylan Edwards (Kansas State). Edwards has over 1,000 yards combined the past three years at KSU and Colorado, but the Derby, KS native has been held back with injuries. He is a threat to score whenever he touches the ball and will contribute in the pass game and as a return specialist.

Four of the top six receivers are gone, including the speedy All-Big 12 Emmanuel Henderson. Cam Pickett returns in the slot, Keaton Kubecka remains in the rotation, and the staff signed two instant playmakers from the non-AQ level. Nik McMillan (Buffalo) led the entire MAC with 82 yards/game and nearly eclipsed 1,000. He set a school record with seven straight 100-yard games and earned first-team All-MAC. Nahzae Cox was a starter for Middle Tennessee and adds a 6'3 frame with speed as a deep threat.

KANSAS					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)											
O																
F	16	6	7	10	57	68	43	59	68	66	55th					
	ZEBROWSKI	GRIMES	ANDY KOTELNICKI			BRENT DEARMON		DOUG MEACHAM		LIKENS						
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR					
D	McDONALD	BRIAN BORLAND				DJ ELIOT		CLINT BOWEN								
F	59	56	39	61	66	62	50	62	60	45	65th					

KANSAS		RANK	
Scoring Defense	26.8 ppg	80	
Points per Play	0.4	86	
Total Defense	387 ypg	86	
Yards per Play	5.9	97	
3rd Down Conv%	41%	90	
Rushing Defense	173 ypg	97	
Yards per Carry	4.7	108	
Negative Play %	10%	25	
Explosive Rush	8.3	122	
Passing Defense	214 ypg	57	
Yards / Attempt	7.2	72	
QB Rating	140	102	
Completion %	63.9%	99	
Explosive Pass	5.8	75	
Return. Production	67%	10	
Returning Snaps	14,929	10	

KANSAS		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		16	
Rushing Offense	0.5	20	
Passing Offense	19.4	15	
Defense Overall		59	
Rushing Defense	(0.1)	53	
Passing Defense	(12.8)	60	

Kansas retained their top playmaker in Trey Lathan. The middle backer led the team in tackles, and made the two key plays in the 27-20 win over UCF when he recovered a fumble at the goal-line and later made the game-sealing tackle in the final minute. Bangally Kamara graduated with Big 12 honors but Kansas landed Boston College captain Daveon Crouch and two SEC backers Landyn Watson (Kentucky) and Jaron Willis (South Carolina).

The new-look secondary struggled last year with a bottom ten finish in opponent-adjusted passing, but the hope is that it will pay dividends as veterans in 2026. Three starters are back with safety Taylor Davis and the corner pair of Jalen Todd and Austin Alexander. They signed Louisville's starting safety Corey Gordon, and Jaden Harris (Miami & Georgia) who was stuck in crowded NFL factories.

OUTLOOK

Kansas suffered plenty of one-score losses with blown fourth-quarter leads but it will only get tougher from here with the worst five-year recruiting average in the Big 12. In the past two transfer cycles they added just one four-star.

The defense has a few proven all-conference candidates to build around but overall they placed third-worst in my opponent-adjusted defense stat last year. There are too many uncertainties to call for a bowl bid.

KANSAS		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	616	56	
All-Time Win %	0.472	63	
Wins (Last 100)	429	65	
Wins (Last 50)	213	66	
Wins (Last 25)	101	68	
Wins (Last 10)	36	68	
Wins (Last 5)	27	59	
Game Grader (10 yr)	33.0	67	
Game Grader (5 yr)	44.7	53	
Game Grader (3 yr)	53.1	30	
Draft Picks s' 2000	25	66	
Draft Picks s' 2010	16	67	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		15	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		22	

Tight end Carson Bruhn broke into the starting lineup as a redshirt freshman before an injury, and he is back along with incoming Jailen Butler (Old Dominion).

2025 was Kansas' fourth-straight Top 20 offense, and the offensive line was a key reason. They ranked #11 in my OL Run Push and three linemen earned All-Big 12 recognition: Bryce Foster, Enrique Cruz, and Kobe Baynes.

Unfortunately all three are gone and the staff hit the portal to reload those three open spots. The three additions all bring starting experience and are rated as three-star transfers. Kasen Carpenter (Oklahoma State) was a former starting center for Tulsa, Nick Morrow (California) started 16 games at tackle, and Connor Stroh (Texas) started five at guard. Amir Herring and Calvin Clements are returning starters though they could use a boost in pass blocking.

DEFENSE

Last offseason, Kansas went through a defensive coordinator change, learned a new scheme, and had to replace the entire back seven. As expected, there were growing pains and Kansas fell to the bottom ten of my opponent-adjusted defensive rankings.

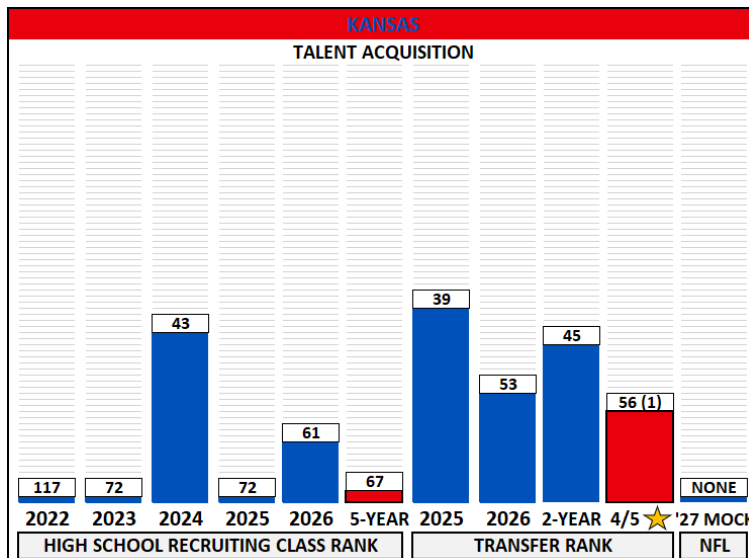
This year that flips to a veteran back seven, a second-year coordinator bonus, but the loss of nearly 2,000 snaps along the defensive line.

All-Big 12 defensive end Leroy Harris is back and end Dakus Brinkley is a rising star on the opposite side. Kansas signed Michigan State starter David Santiago with the hope that this trio can produce a more consistent pass rush. Last year they relied more on blitzing linebackers and cornerbacks.

Blake Herold returns at defensive tackle and he could push for all-league honors, but the other three tackles are gone. The staff signed Tre'Von McAlpine (Tulane) who earned second-team All-AAC last year as a run-stuffing nose tackle.

KANSAS	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 4	LONG ISLAND (FCS)
S. 11	MISSOURI
S. 19	*Ariz. St (LONDON)
S. 26	--- BYE ---
O. 3	MIDDLE TENN.
O. 10	@ Utah
O. 17	@ Kansas State
O. 24	BAYLOR
O. 31	@ TCU
N. 7	UCF
N. 14	@ West Virginia
N. 21	BYU
N. 28	@ Oklahoma St

KANSAS		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
44.2 (49)	53 (32)	62 (20)	45.2 (50)	19 (67)	11.5 (68)	30 (62)	31.8 (63)	13.8 (68)	19.5 (68)	33 (67)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



COLORADO

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#15

BIG 12

#62

OVERALL



COLORADO				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13			(B) BYU	
12	UTAH	UTAH	KANSAS	KANSAS ST
11	UCLA	WASHINGTON	KANSAS ST	ARIZONA ST
10	OREGON	USC	Nebraska	WVU
9	CAL	OREGON	OKLA ST	ARIZONA
8	USC	ARIZONA ST	UTAH	UTAH
7	ARIZONA ST	OREGON ST	TEXAS TECH	TCU
6	Minnesota	ARIZONA	CINCINNATI	BYU
5	Texas A&M	ARIZONA	ARIZONA	HOUSTON
4	WASHINGTON	UCLA	UCF	GA Tech
3	OREGON ST	Minnesota	BAYLOR	IOWA ST
2	ARIZONA	Air Force	Colorado St	Wyoming
1	N. Colorado (FCS)	TCU	NoDak St (FCS)	Delaware
2021		2022	2023	2024
KARL DORRELL		DEION SANDERS		

COLORADO				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
GA TECH L 20-27	-158	3	28.6	
DELAWARE W 31-7	2	2	60.5	
HOUSTON L 20-36	-131	-2	16.6	
WYOMING W 37-20	150	-1	62.5	
BYU L 21-24	-96	-1	39.5	
TCU L 21-35	-26	-4	25.7	
IOWA ST W 24-17	-46	1	62.9	
UTAH L 7-53	-447	-1	0.4	
ARIZONA L 17-52	-118	-3	7.0	
W. VIRGINIA L 22-29	-19	2	29.5	
ARIZONA ST L 17-42	-280	3	10.7	
KANSAS ST L 14-24	2	-1	33.4	
OVERALL: 63rd / 68 BIG 12: 15th / 16 31.4				

COLORADO	UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK (of 16)	NATIONAL TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	12	
RUNNING BACKS	15	
RECEIVERS & TE	3	
OFFENSIVE LINE	16	
DEFENSIVE LINE	14	
LINEBACKERS	11	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	12	

COLORADO	RANK
Scoring Offense 20.9 ppg	116
Points per Play 0.32	114
Total Offense 328 ypg	114
Yards per Play 5.0	115
Rushing Offense 126 ypg	104
Yards per Carry 3.5	123
O-Line Run Push 3.9	102
Explosive Rush 5.7	49
Passing Offense 203 ypg	95
Yards / Attempt 6.8	90
QB Rating 125	92
TD / INT Ratio 1.5	93
Sacks / Attempt 11%	130
Explosive Pass 6.7	67
Return. Production 57%	60
Returning Snaps 13,514	25
26.7 SECONDS/PLAY #39 of 68 P4	
MARION (2025 SAC. STATE)	

ten of my opponent-adjusted ranks.

When pressed on his future, Sanders doubled down on himself and his program vision: "I don't doubt me, let's get that straight, I don't doubt me."

Right away he landed one of the top coordinator hires this cycle with the innovative Brennan Marion bringing his so-called "Go-Go Offense" to Boulder.

Then Colorado signed a top 25 transfer haul – Sanders' fourth in four years – with a trio of four-stars and multiple all-conference players. Yes, it's another transfer-heavy roster, but this time with the elimination of the second, post-spring transfer window, there will be no summer Musical Chairs.

His first three seasons averaged 22 new transfers per summer, essentially an entire recruiting class leaving and joining *after* spring ball. That retention will help with the new scheme installation and Sanders views it positively saying they "really know the hand that you're dealt" rather than restarting in fall camp.

OFFENSE

When asked to describe his Go-Go Offense, Marion said it is a "Friday offense, a Saturday offense, and a Sunday offense" meaning they draw concepts from all three levels of football. While that sounds like typical coach-speak, there is some truth to it here, as this is a super-creative offense that is both run-heavy but takes vertical passing shots more than most.

Over six years as a head coach and coordinator, Marion's offenses have averaged over 30 points/game, and his Sacramento State unit last year exploded for 34 points and 426 yards per game, with runs on a very high 69% of snaps.

That is quite the contrast to Colorado's pass-heavy tendency over the Sanders era.

Kaidon Salter started the most games, Ryan Staub had one start and his breakthrough moment in the Delaware win, but both are gone. Top100 recruit Julian Lewis surged late in the season and retained his redshirt, and is set to battle Utah transfer Isaac Wilson in fall camp. Wilson was also a four-star prospect thrown into action as a true freshman, and struggled with more picks than touchdowns as a part-year starter during Utah's injury-filled 2024 season.

Marion tends to go with a two-back formation and there are four guys in the mix for carries. Micah Welch is back after leading the team with 384 yards last year, DeKalon Taylor is back healthy and has the skillset for this scheme, and Richard Young (Alabama) is a 210-pound power back. Marion brought his thunder/lightning pair with him from Sacramento State with Damian Henderson and speedy JaQuail Smith – they combined for 1,100 yards and 10 touchdowns last year.

All-Big 12 star and team MVP Omarion Miller transferred out to Arizona State as the #3 ranked receiver this cycle. Colorado added a four-star of their own with Texas starter DeAndre Moore, plus first-team All-MAC Kam Perry (Miami Ohio). Then they signed Biletnikoff semifinalist Danny Scudero (San Jose State) who led the entire country with 1,297 yards. Last year's #2 target Joseph Williams is back, plus

COLORADO										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	60	39	52	68	68	37	50	58	57	52	65th
F	PAT SHURMUR LEWIS SANFORD DARRIN CHIAVERINI JOHNSON CHIAVERINI BRIAN LINDGREN										
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	ROBERT LIVINGSTON KELLY CHRIS WILSON TYSON SUMMERS D.J. ELIOT LEAVITT										
E	60	8	55	67	57	50	56	29	61	8	54th
F											

COLORADO		RANK	
Scoring Defense	30.5 ppg	112	
Points per Play	0.44	102	
Total Defense	426 ypg	123	
Yards per Play	6.1	118	
3rd Down Conv%	35%	34	
Rushing Defense	223 ypg	135	
Yards per Carry	5.3	131	
Negative Play %	7%	102	
Explosive Rush	8.5	125	
Passing Defense	203 ypg	41	
Yards / Attempt	7.5	90	
QB Rating	133	69	
Completion %	55.4%	13	
Explosive Pass	6.5	96	
Return. Production	53%	66	
Returning Snaps	12,870	27	

COLORADO		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		60	
Rushing Offense	(0.5)	57	
Passing Offense	3.3	42	
Defense Overall		60	
Rushing Defense	(0.6)	63	
Passing Defense	3.1	37	

Thomas (Notre Dame) and All-Sun Belt Justin Eaglin (James Madison). Boo Carter is a total wildcard – the former Top100 was once a top SEC freshman and is looking for a bounce-back year and may even get snaps on offense.

Three linebacker transfers will battle for the starting spots with former four-star Liona Lefau (Texas), All-MAC Gideon Lampron (Bowling Green), and New Mexico State starter Tyler Martinez.

The defensive line is an area of uncertainty after five guys transferred out to Power 4 rosters. They backfilled with players from the FCS and non-AQ level and all four starters will be transfers. Santana Hopper (Tulane) is the headliner after earning first-team All-AAC honors as a productive tackle. Ezra Christensen (New Mexico State), Toby Anene (North Dakota State), Tyler Moore (Coastal Carolina), and Sedrick Smith (Maryland) all received three-star transfer grades.

OUTLOOK

Marion was a strong coordinator pick, Colorado signed a fourth straight Top 25 transfer class and restocked the receiver room. But to get to bowl season they have to fix both lines of scrimmage and get better effort from the defense.

Marion brought another speedster with him from Sacramento State in 4.3 40 burner Ernest Campbell. This room is the clear strength of the roster.

Zach Atkins returns at tight end, and the position will be utilized more since they are moving away from the four-wide formations of the past few seasons.

The offensive line struggled again last year allowing a sack on 11% of pass attempts (#130) and failing to create a consistent run push (#102). Their best lineman Jordan Seaton missed some games due to injury and now transferred out as a five-star to LSU. In the past three years, an insane 27 different linemen have started games.

It will be another reset here in 2026 with just one full-time starter returning in Larry Johnson. Marion wanted to “build a wall of big humans” and did just that with a pair of 6’8 transfers Leon Bell (California) and Bo Hughley (Georgia). Both guys have Power 4 starting experience. So do Taj White (Rutgers) and center Demetrius Hunter (Houston) and Jayven Richardson was Missouri’s sixth man last year.

DEFENSE

Colorado completed the three-year boomerang on defense: bottom ten in 2023, a Top 25 surge in 2024, and then all the way back down in 2025. They allowed 223 rushing yards/game – second worst in America.

Coordinator Robert Livingston went to the pros and Sanders promoted Chris Marve from within. Marve was the defensive coordinator on Brent Pry’s Virginia Tech teams 2022-2024 with a three-year average rank of #37 of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted rankings.

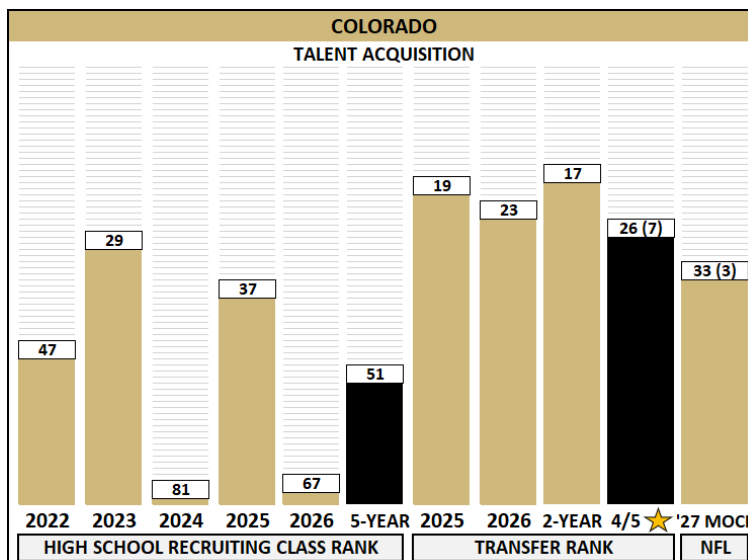
The defense is a total reset and could feature new transfers at all eleven spots. The only returning player with more than six starts is safety Ben Finneseth and from there the staff signed impressive groups at linebacker and in the secondary.

Finneseth will battle All-CUSA Naeten Mitchell (New Mexico State) and former four-star prospect Randon Fontenette (Vanderbilt). The top corner pair appears to be Cree

COLORADO	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	@ GA TECH
S. 12	WEBER ST (FCS)
S. 19	@ Northwestern
S. 26	@ Baylor
O. 3	TEXAS TECH
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	UTAH
O. 24	@ Oklahoma St
O. 31	KANSAS STATE
N. 7	@ Arizona State
N. 13	HOUSTON
N. 21	@ Cincinnati
N. 28	UCF

COLORADO		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	735	29	
All-Time Win %	0.567	34	
Wins (Last 100)	562	40	
Wins (Last 50)	288	52	
Wins (Last 25)	124	65	
Wins (Last 10)	50	62	
Wins (Last 5)	21	67	
Game Grader (10 yr)	39.0	64	
Game Grader (5 yr)	33.4	67	
Game Grader (3 yr)	43.8	53	
Draft Picks s' 2000	49	49	
Draft Picks s' 2010	23	60	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		60	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		61	

COLORADO		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
31.4 (63)	62.4 (19)	37.5 (53)	10.6 (68)	24.8 (63)	49.1 (35)	37.7 (53)	40.2 (57)	36.6 (56)	59.9 (19)	39 (64)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



IOWA STATE

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#16

BIG 12

#65

OVERALL



IOWA STATE					
5-YEAR WIN TREND					
14	(B) Clemson		(B) Memphis	(CG) Arizona St	
13	OKLAHOMA	TCU	TEXAS	KANSAS	ARIZONA ST
12	TEXAS TECH	TEXAS TECH	KANSAS	TEXAS TECH	BYU
11	WVU	OKLA ST	OKLAHOMA	(B) Miami	COLORADO
10	BAYLOR	OKLAHOMA	Ohio	KANSAS ST	CINCINNATI
9	Iowa	TEXAS	Iowa	UTAH	OKLA ST
8	TCU	KANSAS ST	KANSAS ST	CINCINNATI	KANSAS
7	TEXAS	KANSAS	BYU	UCF	TCU
6	OKLA ST	BAYLOR	BAYLOR	WVU	ARIZONA
5	KANSAS ST	WVU	CINCINNATI	HOUSTON	Arkansas St
4	KANSAS	Ohio	TCU	Arkansas St	Iowa
3	UNLV	Iowa	OKLA ST	Iowa	S. Dakota (FCS)
2	N. Iowa (FCS)	SE MO (FCS)	N. Iowa (FCS)	N. Dakota (FCS)	KANSAS ST
1					
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025					
MATT CAMPBELL					

IOWA STATE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
KANSAS ST W 24-21	-70	0	47.9	
S. Dakota (FCS) W 55-7	320	2	77.1	
IOWA W 16-13	24	0	67.6	
ARKANSAS ST W 24-16	70	0	55.2	
ARIZONA W 39-14	39	1	93.4	
CINCINNATI L 30-38	-4	1	31.8	
COLORADO L 17-24	46	-1	30.7	
BYU L 27-41	85	-4	41.3	
ARIZONA ST L 19-24	-131	2	31.3	
TCU W 20-17	-160	1	44.2	
KANSAS W 38-14	139	1	82.4	
OKLAHOMA ST W 20-13	117	1	56.0	
OVERALL: 32nd / 68 BIG 12: 6th / 16 54.9				

IOWA STATE		UNIT RANKS	
BIG 12 RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 16)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	13		
RUNNING BACKS	13		
RECEIVERS & TE	16		
OFFENSIVE LINE	15		
DEFENSIVE LINE	15		
LINEBACKERS	15		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	15		

IOWA STATE		RANK	
Scoring Offense	27.4 ppg	70	
Points per Play	0.4	72	
Total Offense	396 ypg	60	
Yards per Play	5.8	63	
Rushing Offense	175 ypg	49	
Yards per Carry	4.4	67	
O-Line Run Push	4.3	57	
Explosive Rush	5.1	79	
Passing Offense	221 ypg	75	
Yards / Attempt	7.7	48	
QB Rating	135	65	
TD / INT Ratio	1.8	81	
Sacks / Attempt	6%	70	
Explosive Pass	7.0	56	
Return. Production	44%	104	
Returning Snaps	7,723	88	
31.7 SECONDS/PLAY #68 of 68 P4			
ROEHL (2023 N. DAKOTA ST) SLOW			

OFFENSE

That extreme roster turnover is critical experience, because he and his staff will need to do it again here. Campbell brought 20 Cyclones – 15 starters – with him to Penn State. In total, Iowa State welcomes in 60 newcomers, and 16 projected new starters all from lower levels (non-AQ, FCS, DII).

The offense was hit especially hard with all 11 starters transferring or graduating.

Rocco Becht followed Campbell to Penn State and leaves as one of the best Iowa State quarterbacks of all-time. He placed third in career passing yards (9,274), second in touchdowns (64) and led several fourth-quarter comebacks. Backup quarterback Alex Manske joined him, and a pair of transfers battled in spring.

Jaylen Raynor (Arkansas State) was a three-year starter with multiple All-Sun Belt accolades and a productive stat-line: 9,877 yards of offense and 67 total touchdowns. Raynor appeared to win the job over Zane Flores (Oklahoma State) who threw 7 picks and just 3 touchdowns in a tough spot last year.

Then the dominos started following. Leading rusher Carson Hansen to Penn State. Top two receivers Chase Sowell and Brett Eskildsen ... top two tight ends Ben Brahmer and Gabe Burkle ... starting guard Trevor Buhr ... all to Penn State. That's five All-Big 12 players out the door.

Hansen's co-star Abu Sama went to Wisconsin so it will be a new duo at running back with MAC Freshman of the Year Cameron Pettaway (Bowling Green) joining the elusive Aiden Flora.

The top four receivers are gone and the staff signed starters off lower-level schools like Omari Hayes (Tulane) and Cody Jackson (FCS Tarleton). Carter Pabst (Washington State) got some time as a freshman and followed the staff here, Evan Boyd (Michigan State) was a Big Ten backup, and Dominic Overby remains in the rotation from last year.

IOWA STATE										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	43	37	16	59	13	13	13	34	50	36	23rd
F											
F	TAYLOR MOUSER SCHEELH. TOM MANNING CAMPBELL* TOM MANNING										
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	JON HEACOCK										
E	49	42	23	3	12	16	28	17	15	46	17th
F											

IOWA STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	20.2 ppg	26	
Points per Play	0.32	35	
Total Defense	357 ypg	54	
Yards per Play	5.6	78	
3rd Down Conv%	39%	62	
Rushing Defense	138 ypg	50	
Yards per Carry	4.4	88	
Negative Play %	8%	82	
Explosive Rush	7.0	90	
Passing Defense	219 ypg	64	
Yards / Attempt	6.8	52	
QB Rating	124	44	
Completion %	61.2%	60	
Explosive Pass	4.9	41	
Return. Production	46%	85	
Returning Snaps	9,790	65	

IOWA STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		43	
Rushing Offense	0.2	31	
Passing Offense	(1.6)	45	
Defense Overall		49	
Rushing Defense	0.0	51	
Passing Defense	5.5	32	

The starting trio – Caleb Bacon, Kooper Ebel, and Cael Brezina – all went to Penn State so Carson Willich elevates into a starting role alongside a rising star Sullivan Schlimgen (Washington State). Montreze Smith is a former FCS All-American, and Tristan Exline (UT Permian Basin) put up an insane 143 tackles, 19.5 for loss, and was a Harlon Hill finalist aka the “Division II Heisman.”

The top six defensive backs are gone. Jaheim Singletary (Arkansas) is a former Top100 prospect but his playing time has decreased each year. Seth Johnson (Montana State) will start opposite him at the other corner spot. Perhaps their top transfer this cycle, the All-AAC safety Braden Awls (Tulane), was injured in spring so the pair will likely be Jacksonville State starter Malcolm Jones and Micah Harper (Montana) who previously was productive at BYU.

OUTLOOK

Campbell took 15 Iowa State starters with him to Penn State and it's the biggest starting lineup exodus I've seen from one Power 4 school to another. Instead, as many as 16 new starters are from lower-tiers (non-AQ, FCS, DII), and it's a double coordinator scheme change.

This is the definition of a rebuilding season.

Raynor has a familiar face to throw to with the addition of his Arkansas State tight end Tyler Fortenberry who caught 32 balls last year.

The Iowa State offensive line led a consistent run push down the stretch and they rushed for 150+ in the final seven games – a Top 10 streak to close the season. It is a complete restart here as all five starters are gone including their 50-start ironman Tyler Miller. This will be a full transfer starting five here in 2026. Braden Smith (Tarleton) was an FCS All-American at guard, Jake Taylor (Oklahoma) was a starter in 2024 before an injury, and the other three bring a handful of starts: Gavin Broschious (Michigan State), DeAndre Carter (Auburn), and Maasai King (Akron).

Rogers hired Tyler Roehl at offensive coordinator, and before his stop here in 2024 he was leading the national champion power rushing attack for North Dakota State. Rogers' South Dakota State faced off against him and must have earned his respect.

DEFENSE

The legendary Jon Heacock retired after a decade leading the defense here in Ames. His development and installation of the 3-3 so-called Dime Stack defense puzzled opposing coordinators and was a key reason for the program's rise. In those ten years, seven defenses ranked in the Big 12's top three, and he coached 80 All-Big 12 defenders.

Rogers brought his coordinator Jesse Bobbit with him after the successful South Dakota State years and a Top 20 unit last year at Washington State. They will switch back to a four-man front.

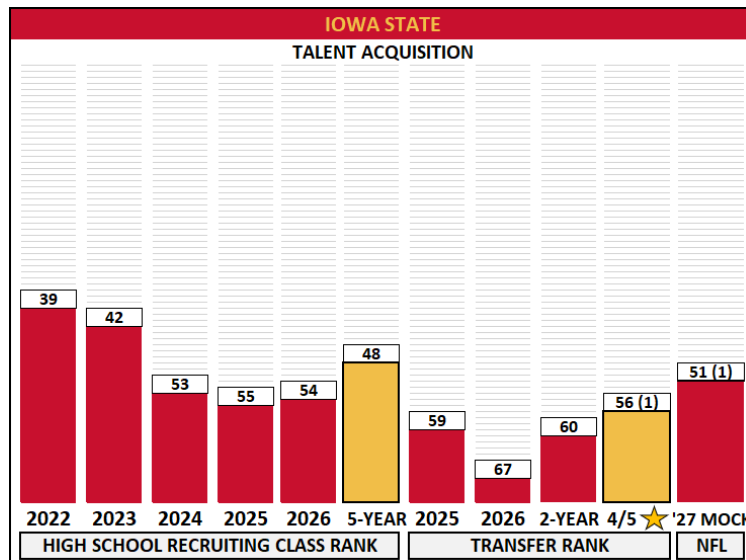
Eight starters transferred out and seven followed Campbell to Penn State. The new starting eleven has two Iowa State incumbents, one Power 4 transfer, 3 non-AQ, 4 FCS, and 2 DII.

Domonique Orange was drafted and there was a noticeable difference when he was not on the field. Zaimir Hawk returns at nose tackle and the staff had huge spring reviews of Bryson Lamb (Washington State). Isaac Terrell (Washington State) was a top pass rusher with 7 sacks and 12 tackles-for-loss.

IOWA STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	SE MISSOURI (FCS)
S. 12	@ Iowa
S. 19	BOWLING GREEN
S. 26	UTAH
O. 3	WEST VIRGINIA
O. 9	@ BYU
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	@ Arizona
O. 31	OKLAHOMA ST
N. 7	@ Baylor
N. 14	CINCINNATI
N. 20	@ UCF
N. 28	KANSAS STATE

IOWA STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	586	59	
All-Time Win %	0.463	65	
Wins (Last 100)	433	63	
Wins (Last 50)	253	62	
Wins (Last 25)	143	55	
Wins (Last 10)	72	30	
Wins (Last 5)	37	32	
Game Grader (10 yr)	58.4	18	
Game Grader (5 yr)	58.8	20	
Game Grader (3 yr)	57.2	24	
Draft Picks s' 2000	31	64	
Draft Picks s' 2010	21	62	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		24	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		17	

IOWA STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
54.9 (32)	64.3 (16)	52.4 (32)	56.3 (27)	66.3 (13)	73.9 (8)	63.2 (19)	57.6 (24)	59.2 (25)	36 (55)	58.4 (18)	



PICK SIX PLUS

WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS